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MAINS MAGNUM

2026

Indian Society, Social Justice & Governance

Jan 2025 – May 2026 Mains Current Affairs



Theme-wise Most Probable Questions (MPQs)

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TO OUR READERS

Dear Future Administrators,

Welcome to **PMF IAS Mains Magnum 2026 Series 3.0– Indian Society, Social Justice & Governance**, a focused compilation designed to strengthen your conceptual clarity and analytical understanding for the UPSC Civil Services Mains Examination.

This volume covers **current affairs from January 2025 to May 2026**, carefully curated from a Mains-oriented perspective with a strong emphasis on Indian society, social justice, vulnerable sections, health, education, nutrition, governance, welfare delivery, civil services, and emerging socio-governance challenges.

The objective of this volume remains simple yet crucial: maximum revision in **minimum time with maximum relevance**. Key topics have been **marked with */**** to support prioritised revision and efficient preparation. To maintain conciseness and examination utility, the content focuses on important issues, constitutional provisions, government initiatives, committee recommendations, social indicators, governance reforms, judicial developments, and analytical dimensions, while avoiding unnecessary theoretical elaboration.

Indian Society, Social Justice, and Governance constitute a crucial component of both **GS Paper I and GS Paper II**. UPSC consistently tests candidates on issues related to social diversity, demographic transitions, gender justice, vulnerable groups, health and education outcomes, welfare architecture, digital governance, institutional reforms, public service delivery, and citizen-centric administration. A careful analysis of previous year questions indicates that these themes collectively contribute significant weightage **(approximately 80-120 marks)**, making them among the most rewarding areas in the Mains examination.

For enhanced preparation support, aspirants may also refer to **PMF IAS Pathfinder for Mains**, which provides structured answer-writing frameworks, value addition tools, and multidimensional perspectives essential for **GS Paper I and GS Paper II**.

We hope this compilation helps you revise faster, retain better, and approach **Indian Society, Social Justice & Governance** with clarity and confidence.

With best wishes,
(Mains Team, PMF IAS)

If you find any discrepancy or wish to share feedback, feel free to reach out. Every suggestion is valued and contributes to the continuous improvement of future editions. Connect with us at **Jha1Mohit@Gmail.Com**

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PMF IAS Mains Magnum 2026 — Indian Society, Social Justice & Governance

UPSC CSE Mains 2026 Specific Indian Society, Social Justice & Governance Current Affairs and Mains Pathfinder Questions from January 2025 to May 2026

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Salient Features & Diversity of Indian Society

{IS – Diversity} India's Cultural Diversity **

❖ **Context (IE): India's diversity** is highlighted through **simple**, **everyday symbols** like currency notes, fabrics, and culinary traditions, showcasing the nation's uniqueness.

Illustrations of Diversity

- **Currency Notes:** Display multiple scripts, unlike other nations' currencies, reflecting linguistic plurality.
- **Religious Structures:** Include mosques, churches & derasars, showcasing coexistence despite conflicts.
- **Fabric Usage:** Unstitched clothes like saris and dhotis are draped in numerous styles, symbolising cultural evolution over millennia.

Multilingual Reality

- **Linguistic Versatility:** Indians speak multiple languages — mother tongue, state language, **Hindi/English** for governance, and **English** for global communication.
- **Cognitive Flexibility:** Exposure to varied languages fosters adaptability and respect for diversity.
- **Resistance to Homogenisation:** Attempts to impose a single language have met with strong opposition, preserving regional identities.

Culinary Diversity

- **Thali System:** Encourages personalisation and mixing of items like dal, sabzi, and papad.

⇨ ***Thali Philosophy:*** *Represents **personalisation in food culture**, in contrast to Western fine dining.*

- **Contrast with Western Dining:** Simultaneous serving of all courses reflects flexibility, unlike the sequential courses of Western fine dining.

Challenges of Diversity

➢ **Complex Hierarchies:** Diversity leads to multiple hierarchies, requiring a nuanced understanding.
➢ **Preserving Identity:** Balancing regional and national identities while engaging with global systems.

Advantages of Diversity

- **Survival Strategy:** Natural inclusion ensures societal adaptability and resilience.
- **Cultural Richness:** Diverse practices, languages, and cuisines enrich national identity and global appeal.

Philosophical Insights: Diversity vs. Equality

- Diverse societies embrace **heterogeneity** and **fluid hierarchies,** fostering inclusivity.
- Equality demands uniformity and control, which may clash with natural diversity.
- Cultural Hierarchies in Indian society evolve over time, highlighting impermanence.

Measures to Sustain Diversity

✓ **Cultural Preservation:** Promote multilingual education, regional arts, traditional knowledge, and stronger legal safeguards for heritage.
✓ **Inclusive Diversity:** Encourage intercultural dialogue, celebrate cultural festivals, and view diversity as a developmental strength.

{IS – Diversity} Caste System in India *

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❖ **Context (NIE):** India's caste system persists today, **shaping identity** and **opportunity**, increasingly manifesting through **subtle institutional biases** despite constitutional safeguards and social change.

Historical Background of the Caste System

- **Varna Basis:** **Four-fold varna system** (Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra) mentioned in the Rig Veda.
- **Jati Expansion:** Over **3,000 castes** and **25,000 sub-castes** evolved through hereditary occupations.
- **Social Hierarchy:** SCs (**16.6%**) and STs (**8.6%**) remain disadvantaged in socio-economic indicators.
- **Untouchability Legacy:** Despite **Article 17**, caste discrimination persists in many regions today.

Key Characteristics of the Caste System

- **Birth-Based Membership:** Caste is determined by **birth and remains fixed**, limiting social mobility.
- **Hierarchy:** Society is divided into ranked groups with clear notions of superiority and inferiority.
- **Endogamy:** Marriage is restricted within one's own caste, maintaining caste boundaries.
- **Occupational Fixity:** Each caste is traditionally linked to specific occupations, restricting choice.
- **Purity and Pollution:** Social interactions are governed by ritual purity, leading to discrimination.

Why does Caste still exist in India?

- **Endogamy in Marriage:** Most marriages still occur within the caste due to social norms and family pressure. E.g., Matrimonial sites like **Shaadi.com** use caste-based filters for partner selection.
- **Political Mobilisation:** Caste remains central to **elections** and **vote-bank politics**. E.g., the Maratha Reservation movements in Maharashtra and the Jat Reservation movements in Haryana.
- **Economic Inequality:** Historical disadvantages persist in income, land ownership, and employment. E.g., SCs are disproportionately engaged in the sanitation and informal labour sectors.
- **Institutional Biases:** **Subtle discrimination** exists in recruitment and promotions. E.g., Rejection of SC/ST candidates in universities under labels like **"Not found suitable."**
- **Social Mindset:** **Deep-rooted caste biases** continue in everyday interactions. E.g., Rise in caste discrimination complaints in universities as reported by UGC (2019–2024).

Factors Changing the Caste System in India

- **Urbanisation & Industrialisation:** Cities and new jobs weaken **caste-based occupations** and **social barriers**. E.g., Mixed-caste workplaces in IT and service sectors.
- **Social Mobility:** Lower castes adopt upper-caste practices to improve status. E.g., Adoption of vegetarianism and rituals by OBC communities.
- **Education:** Education promotes merit, equality, and reduces caste rigidities. E.g., Increased SC/ST participation in higher education.
- **Political & Legal Reforms:** Reservation policies and democratic politics empower lower castes. E.g., Rise of OBC leaders and caste-based political representation.

Transformation of Caste in India

- **Power-Based Hierarchy:** Caste status is now shaped more by economic and political power than ritual purity. E.g., Rise of OBC groups like **Yadavs as dominant political forces** in states like UP and Bihar.
- **Subtle Discrimination:** Visible practices like untouchability have declined, but **hidden biases persist** in institutions. E.g., Use of terms like **"Not found suitable"** in faculty recruitment.
- **Occupational Mobility:** Traditional caste-based occupations are weakening due to education and urbanisation. E.g., Dalits are entering professions like civil services, IT, and academia.
- **Political Identity:** Caste has become a tool for **political mobilisation and empowerment**. E.g., Growth of caste-based parties like BSP and reservation-based movements.

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Caste is More Relevant in Rural than Urban Areas

- **Traditional Structure:** Villages follow **age-old caste hierarchies** with minimal change. E.g., Upper caste dominance in village panchayats.
- **Agrarian Economy:** Land ownership and farm work reinforce caste roles. E.g., Upper castes as landlords, Dalits as labourers.
- **Community Control:** **Strong social pressure** enforces caste norms and rules. E.g., Khap panchayats oppose inter-caste marriages.
- **Limited Exposure:** Low education and fewer opportunities sustain caste divisions. E.g., High SC/ST dropout in rural schools.

Key Government Initiatives to Eradicate Caste in India

- India has adopted a comprehensive framework of constitutional, legal, and welfare measures to eliminate caste-based discrimination and promote social justice.

Constitutional Provisions

- **Article 14 (Equality):** Ensures equality before the law for all citizens.
- **Article 15 (Non-Discrimination):** Prohibits discrimination on grounds of caste.
- **Article 16 (Equal Opportunity):** Guarantees equal access to public employment.
- **Article 17 (Abolition of Untouchability):** Declares untouchability illegal.
- **Article 46 (Welfare of SC/ST):** Promotes educational and economic interests of weaker sections.

Legal Measures

- **Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955:** Punishes the practice of untouchability.
- **SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989:** Prevents caste-based violence and discrimination.
- **PEMSR Act, 2013:** Banned manual scavenging and broadened the definition to include cleaning septic tanks and railway tracks.

Government Schemes

- **Post-Matric Scholarship Scheme (SC/ST):** Provides financial support to SC/ST students for higher education.
- **Stand-Up India:** Promotes entrepreneurship among SC/ST & women by providing bank loans.
- **PM-AJAY:** To reduce the poverty of the SC communities by generating additional employment opportunities.

Key Challenges in Tackling the Caste System in India

- **Social Prejudice:** **Deep-rooted caste beliefs persist** across generations in society. E.g., Preference for same-caste marriages through matrimonial platforms like Shaadi.com.
- **Law Enforcement:** Weak implementation of anti-discrimination laws limits their effectiveness. E.g., Continued caste atrocities despite the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989.
- **Economic Deprivation:** Poverty and lack of education increase vulnerability to caste-based exclusion. E.g., SC/ST communities are overrepresented in informal sanitation work.
- **Low Awareness:** Limited understanding of caste discrimination prevents people from challenging it. E.g., victims are often unaware of their rights under the **SC/ST (PoA) Act, 1989**.

Way Forward to Address the Caste System in India

- **Legal Enforcement:** **Strengthen enforcement** of anti-discrimination laws with strict punishment for caste atrocities, ensuring effective use of the SC/ST Act through fast-track courts.

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- ✓ **Educational Inclusion:** Promote **inclusive education** & **awareness** to reduce caste prejudices from an early age. E.g., Reservation in higher education and sensitisation programs in schools and universities.
- ✓ **Economic Empowerment:** Improve access to jobs, credit, and skill development for marginalised communities. E.g., **Stand-Up India Scheme** supporting SC/ST entrepreneurs with bank loans.
- ✓ **Social Reform:** Promote social harmony and inter-caste interactions to reduce discrimination. E.g., Campaigns encouraging inter-caste marriages and community integration initiatives.

{IS – Diversity} Linguistic Secularism

❖ **Context (TH):** India's linguistic and religious diversity is central to its secular identity. However, recent **language-based violence**, notably in Maharashtra, threatens this ethos.

- With **121 languages** and **270 mother tongues** (2011 Census), protecting linguistic pluralism is vital to preserving **India's unity in diversity**.

Understanding Indian Secularism

- **Inclusive Model:** Distinct from the Western model, Indian secularism is **not a strict separation** of state and religion, but a model of equal respect for all religions and communities **(Sarva Dharma Sambhava)**.
- **Constitutional Foundations:** Enshrined in **Articles 25-28**, it protects the freedom of conscience and religion. Importantly, Indian secularism recognises language as an equally vital identity marker.
- **State's Role:** The state neither promotes nor suppresses any religion or language and can actively intervene to curb both religious and linguistic communalism.

Why India Has No National Language

- **Constitutional Design:** India **does not** have a national language. **Article 343** designates **Hindi** (in Devanagari script) as the official language of the Union, not the national language.
- **Linguistic Autonomy:** States are free to choose their own official languages based on cultural context, reinforcing **India's linguistic federalism.**
- **Cultural & Linguistic** Rights **Article 29** protects citizens' rights to preserve their language & culture. It prohibits language-based discrimination, safeguarding India's multicultural and pluralistic character.
- **Eighth Schedule:** Recognises **22 languages**, covering the mother tongues of 96.71% of the population. Yet, 99 languages remain outside the Schedule, reflecting the scale of India's language diversity.

Recent Challenges to Linguistic Secularism

- ➢ **Identity Politics:** Recent violence against non-Marathi speakers in Maharashtra marks a troubling rise in identity politics disguised as cultural protection.
- ➢ **Imposition Fears:** Southern and northeastern States, especially Tamil Nadu, have historically resisted the imposition of Hindi, defending **local linguistic autonomy**.
- ➢ **Undermining pluralism:** When political groups use language identity to exclude or intimidate, it distorts **cultural pride** and fractures India's inclusive federal structure.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Policy Safeguards:** Ensure equity in language policy by promoting multilingual education and the use of diverse languages in administration, education, and public communication.
- ✓ **Political Responsibility:** Leaders must avoid divisive rhetoric and promote inclusive policies celebrating India's linguistic and cultural diversity.
- ✓ **Civic Engagement:** Citizens must actively uphold linguistic respect through everyday interactions, inclusive education, and respectful public discourse to nurture a culture of mutual coexistence.

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✓ **Institutional Oversight:** Strengthen the role of the **Commissioner for Linguistic Minorities** and uphold protections under **Articles 29** and **30** to safeguard linguistic minority rights.

{IS – Issues} Dowry Eradication in India

- **Context (DH):** The Supreme Court termed **dowry a persistent social evil**, demanding stronger laws and awareness campaigns.

About the Dowry System in India

- **Meaning:** Dowry is any property or valuable security given or promised in connection with marriage. It may be exchanged before, during, or after marriage, excluding customary gifts.
- **Extent of the Problem:** NCRB data shows a **14% rise in dowry-related cases in 2023**, with **15,000+ cases registered** and **over 6,100 dowry deaths**, indicating weak deterrence.

Constitutional Basis

- **Article 14:** Equality before law; dowry institutionalises gender-based disadvantage.
- **Article 15(1):** Prohibits discrimination on grounds of sex.
- **Article 21:** Dowry-related cruelty and deaths violate the right to life and dignity.
- **Article 38:** Obligation of the State to promote social justice and reduce inequalities.
- **Article 51A(e):** Renounce practices derogatory to the dignity of women.

Social and Economic Causes of the Dowry System

- **Patriarchal Burden:** Most dowry deaths occur within **7 years** of marriage (NCRB).
- **Status Bargaining:** Government jobs and NRI grooms often attract higher dowry demands.
- **Property Exclusion:** Only **~14% women** own land in India (Agriculture Census).
- **Market Culture:** Cash, vehicles, and electronics frequently trigger dowry harassment cases.
- **Social Silence:** Over **15,000 dowry cases annually** reported, yet conviction rates remain low (NCRB).

Key Observations by the Supreme Court

- **Persistent Evil:** **6,000–7,000 dowry deaths annually** despite decades of legislation.
- **Legal Imbalance:** Enforcement gaps and allegations of misuse undermine public confidence.
- **Delayed Justice:** Many dowry trials take **over 20 years**.
- **Rising Cases:** 15,000+ cases recorded; 14% increase in 2023.

Government Initiatives for Dowry Eradication in India

1. **Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961:** Criminalises giving, taking, and demanding dowry, with penalties of imprisonment and fines to deter the practice.
2. **Section 80, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (Earlier IPC 304-B):** Provides stringent punishment for dowry deaths within seven years of marriage, strengthening legal accountability.
3. **Section 86, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (Earlier IPC 498-A):** Addresses cruelty and harassment by husbands or relatives linked to dowry demands.
4. **Appointment of Dowry Prohibition Officers (DPOs):** Mandated under the Act to prevent dowry, conduct awareness campaigns, and ensure enforcement at the district level.

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5. **Women's Safety & Support Scheme:** Initiatives like **One Stop Centres**, **NCW helplines**, and **Nirbhaya Fund** interventions provide legal, psychological, and rehabilitation support to dowry victims.
6. **Domestic Violence Act, 2005:** Provides civil remedies and protection against domestic abuse, including dowry-linked violence.

Challenges in Dowry Eradication in India

- **Cultural Acceptance:** Dowry is culturally normalised as a **"tradition"** or **status symbol**, making social rejection difficult despite legal prohibition.
- **Enforcement Gaps:** Poor implementation, low conviction rates (around 11–17%), and delayed investigations reduce deterrence against dowry offences. (NCRB)
- **Judicial Delays:** **Prolonged trials** and **case backlogs** dilute punishment and discourage victims from pursuing justice.
- **Legal Imbalance:** Alleged misuse of provisions like **Section 498-A** coexists with widespread underreporting, weakening the public trust and enforcement balance.
- **Economic Dependence:** Low female labour force participation and limited property ownership reduce women's bargaining power to resist dowry demands.

Supreme Court's Multi-Pronged Strategy to Curb Dowry

- ✓ **Curriculum Reforms:** Centre and States to introduce educational content at all levels, emphasising gender equality and equal status of spouses in marriage.
- ✓ **Dowry Prohibition Officers (DPOs):** States to ensure effective appointment, resourcing, and visibility of Dowry Prohibition Officers under the **Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961**.
- ✓ **Expeditious Case Disposal:** High Courts directed to take stock of pending cases under **Sections 304-B (dowry death)** and **498-A (cruelty)** and ensure time-bound disposal from the earliest cases onward.
- ✓ **Capacity Building:** Periodic training for police and judicial officers to sensitise them to the social and psychological dimensions of dowry-related offences.
- ✓ **Grassroots Awareness:** **District administrations and Legal Services Authorities** to conduct regular awareness programmes with civil society and social activists to curb dowry at the community level.

{IS – Issues} Child Trafficking in India

- **Context (TH):** Supreme Court upheld **victim-centric justice**, treating trafficked children as victims and endorsing trauma-sensitive procedures.

Child Trafficking

- As per the UN, child trafficking involves the recruitment, transportation, or harbouring of children for exploitation, including forced labour, begging, or sexual abuse.

Scale of Child Trafficking

- **Reported Cases:** India recorded **10,659 human trafficking cases** **(2018–2022), one-third** of global child trafficking victims, indicating persistent and widespread exploitation.
- **Vulnerability:** NCRB data shows **~55–60%** of trafficking victims are minors, with sexual exploitation and forced labour as the dominant purposes.
- **Digital Shift:** Cyber-trafficking cases rose sharply post-2020, with child-related online exploitation complaints crossing **1.6 million** annually in recent years.

Causes of Child Trafficking in India

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- **Poverty Trap:** Children from poor families are trafficked for labour or begging. E.g., **30% of victims live below the poverty line** (NCRB).
- **Education Gap:** Lack of schooling makes children vulnerable to exploitation. E.g., **60% of minor victims** were school dropouts or never enrolled.
- **Crime Networks:** Organised inter-state rings recruit and exploit children. E.g., trafficking hotspots include Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha, and West Bengal.
- **Digital Risk:** Online grooming and cyber-trafficking are rising. E.g., child sexual exploitation complaints crossed **1.6 million annually post-2020** (NCEB).
- **Social Vulnerability:** Marginalised children and girls face higher exploitation. E.g., **55–60% of victims are minors**, with girls disproportionately affected (NCRB).

Key Directions from the Supreme Court

- **Victim-Centric Approach:** A trafficked child is not an accomplice, but an injured witness whose testimony deserves high credence, **recognising trauma-induced gaps** in narration.
- **Sensitive Testimony:** Courts must allow latitude for inconsistencies, as child victims often cannot recall abuse with precision due to psychological harm.
- **Organised Crime Lens:** Trafficking is run by layered networks spanning recruitment, transport, harbouring and exploitation, requiring **coordinated prosecution**.

Government Initiatives to Combat Child Trafficking in India

- **Anti-Human Trafficking Units (AHTUs):** Specialised inter-state police units for rescue, investigation, and prosecution of trafficking cases.
- **Integrated Child Protection Scheme (ICPS):** Provides rescue, rehabilitation, and reintegration of trafficked and vulnerable children across India.
- **POSCO Act Implementation:** Strengthens protection of children from sexual offences, directly addressing trafficking for sexual exploitation.
- **Cybercrime Monitoring:** Nodal agencies track online child exploitation, tackling rising digital trafficking and cyber grooming.
- **National Plan of Action (NPA):** Government framework to prevent trafficking, protect victims, and prosecute offenders, with special focus on minor girls and marginalised children.

Enforcement and Rehabilitation Gaps

- **Enforcement Deficit:** The conviction rate stands at only 4.8%, reflecting failures in prosecution.
- **Legal Fragmentation:** Multiple laws exist, but the absence of a **single comprehensive anti-trafficking framework** weakens coordination and victim care.
- **Rehabilitation Weakness:** Despite thousands of rescues annually, **less than one-third** of rescued children are sustainably rehabilitated through education or skill programmes.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Specialised Units:** Scale professional anti-trafficking squads; E.g., expand inter-State task forces on the lines of **India's Anti-Human Trafficking Units**.
- ✓ **Comprehensive Law:** Enact an umbrella anti-trafficking statute; E.g., align with **integrated models used in the UK** that combine prevention, protection and prosecution.
- ✓ **Child-Friendly Justice:** Institutionalise trauma-informed courts; E.g., adopt best practices from **Scandinavian child-sensitive** testimony procedures.

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✓ **Rehab-to-Education:** Link rescued children to residential education run by state systems.

{IS – Salient Features & Diversity of Indian Society – Pathfinder for Mains}

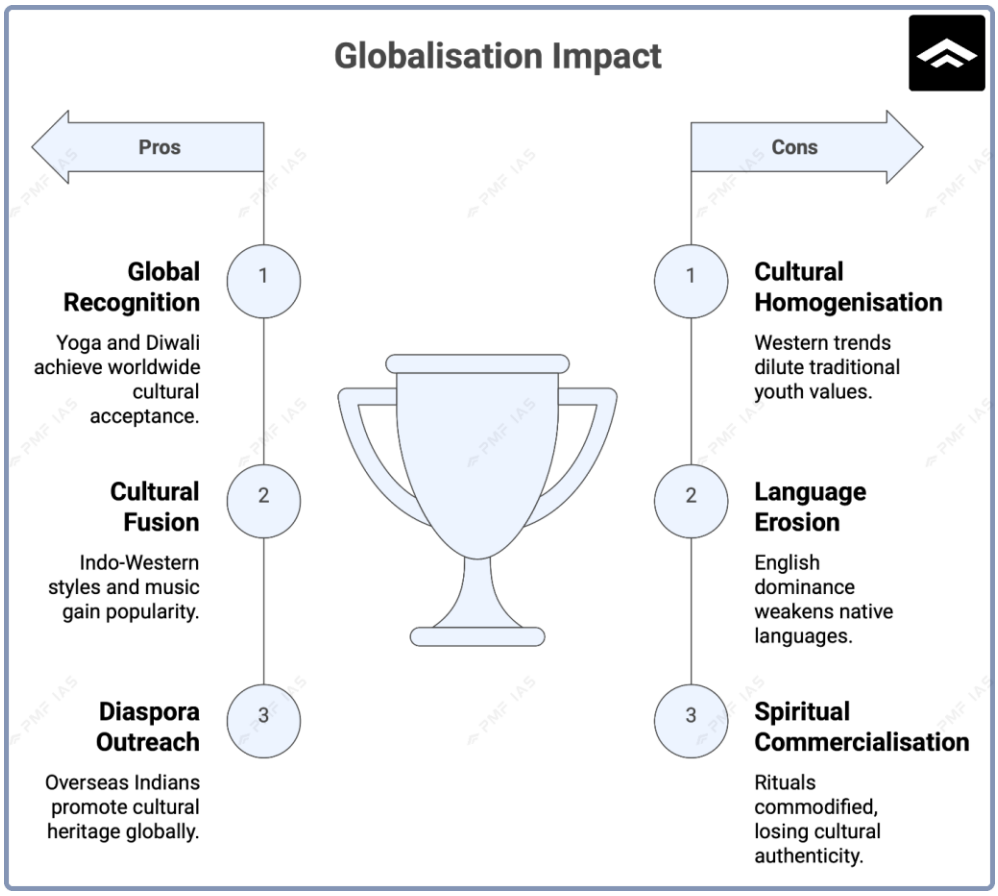
Q. To what extent has globalisation strengthened India's unity in diversity, and suggest a comprehensive roadmap to promote and protect this diversity? (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about India's diversity and mention the impact of globalisation.
- **Body:** Write about how globalisation strengthened India's unity in diversity and suggest a comprehensive roadmap.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on federal inclusion, digital access, and grassroots cultural preservation.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- India's identity is deeply rooted in its cultural, linguistic, religious, and ethnic diversity. Globalisation has had a mixed impact on this unity.



Globalisation Strengthened India's Unity in Diversity

- **Cultural Reach:** **Yoga** and Malayalam films on **Netflix globalise** Indian traditions.
- **Digital Diversity:** **850 million internet** users boost regional voices in Bhojpuri, Tamil, and Marathi.
- **Inclusive Growth:** **Indore**, **Coimbatore**, and rise in **Northeast handloom exports** reflect regional economic integration.

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- **Diaspora Linkage:** 35 million-strong diaspora & Pravasi Bharatiya Divas unite diverse Indian cultures.

Comprehensive Roadmap

- ✓ **Celebrate Pluralism:** Shift global narratives to see **diversity as an asset**, not a challenge.
- ✓ **Institutional Reforms:** Strengthen legal frameworks to protect linguistic and cultural heritage.
- ✓ **Decentralised Tourism:** Promote **eco-cultural tourism** in NE, tribal belts, and linguistic belts.
- ✓ **Curriculum Reform:** Integrate regional histories, tribal knowledge systems, and local languages into the **National Curriculum Framework**.

Conclusion

- With mindful policy & government emphasis on **"Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat"**, globalisation can amplify India's unity in diversity through federal inclusion, digital access, & grassroots cultural preservation.

Q. Discuss the impact of poverty on fertility rates in India, highlighting the socio-economic factors responsible for higher fertility among poor populations. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Briefly discuss the relationship between poverty and TFR, and also reference NFHS-5 data.
- **Body:** Discuss the impact of poverty on fertility rates in India and identify the socio-economic factors responsible for higher fertility rates among poor populations.
- **Conclusion:** Highlights the impact of poverty, such as restricting access to education, healthcare, and empowering choices and also emphasises stabilising population growth.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- **Poverty has a strong positive correlation** with **higher fertility rates** in India. According to the NFHS-5 survey, women from low-income households have a Total Fertility Rate (TFR) of 2.6, compared to 1.6 among women from higher-income families.

Impact of Poverty on Fertility Rates in India

- **Higher Fertility Among the Poor:** Poorer states like **Bihar** (32% poverty) **show higher TFR** (3.0) than affluent states like Kerala (1.7). (SRS 2021)
- **Low Access to Contraceptives:** Only **48.4%** of the poorest women use modern contraceptives, versus 64.7% among the richest. (NFHS-5)
- **Educational Disparities:** **Low female literacy** (53% in Bihar) **reduces reproductive autonomy** and sustains higher fertility. (Census 2011)
- **Economic Dependence on Children:** In poor agrarian households, children are valued for labour and old-age support, encouraging large families.

Socio-Economic Factor Responsible For Higher Fertility

- **Lack of Education:** Women with no formal schooling have a Total Fertility Rate (TFR) of 2.8, while those with 12 years or more have a TFR of 1.7 (NFHS-5).
- **Limited Access to Contraceptives:** Modern contraceptive use is **48.4%** among the poorest women, compared to 64.7% among the richest (NFHS-5).

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- **Economic Utility of Children:** Poor families often view children as contributors to household income and future old-age support, thereby sustaining higher fertility rates.
- **High Child Mortality:** Infant Mortality Rate remains high in poorer states like Uttar Pradesh (38 per 1,000 live births), leading to more births for survival assurance (SRS, 2021).
- **Early Marriage:** Over 27% of women in the lowest wealth quintile **marry before the age of 18**, thereby extending their reproductive span (NFHS-5).

Conclusion

- Poverty sustains high fertility in India by restricting access to education, healthcare, and empowering choices. Reducing poverty is thus crucial for stabilising population growth.

Q. With rising instances of communal and language-based conflicts, do you think India's secular framework is under strain? Critically analyse how it can be strengthened to protect the nation's religious and linguistic pluralism. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about secularism and mention a current example.
- **Body:** Write how India's secular framework is under strain, constitutional and policy safeguards and the way forward to strengthen the secular framework.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on robust policies and civic awareness to strengthen the secular framework and mention B. R. Ambedkar's view on it.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India's secularism, based on **Sarva Dharma Sambhava**, ensures equal respect for all religions and linguistic communities. Rising communal and language-based conflicts, like in Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu, indicate a growing strain on this framework.

India's Secular Framework is Under Strain

- **Communal Polarisation:** 1,150 Hindu–Muslim incidents in 2023 (MHA) weaken **social cohesion**.
- **Language Conflicts:** Non-Marathi attacks in Maharashtra and anti-Hindi protests in Tamil Nadu threaten inclusivity.
- **Majoritarian Pressures:** Dominant cultural promotion marginalises minorities & undermines pluralism.
- **Policy Gaps:** Weak implementation of **Articles 25–30** compromises minority protections.
- **Civic Apathy:** **Low public awareness** of rights fuels localised religious and linguistic tensions.

Constitutional and Policy Safeguards

- **Religious Freedom:** Articles 25–28 ensure equality and protect all religions.
- **Linguistic Rights:** Articles 29–30, 345 safeguard minority languages and state autonomy.
- **Scheduled Languages:** 22 languages cover 96.71% population, ensuring constitutional recognition.
- **Oversight:** The commissioner monitors and enforces linguistic minority rights.

Way Forward to Strengthen the Secular Framework

- ✓ **Policy Reforms:** **Promote multilingual education** and inclusive language policies.
- ✓ **Political Responsibility:** Leaders must avoid **divisive rhetoric** and support inclusivity.
- ✓ **Civic Engagement:** Citizens foster coexistence via education and respectful interaction.

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- ✓ **Institutional Strengthening:** Empower oversight to enforce **Articles 29–30** effectively.
- ✓ **Judicial Enforcement:** Courts protect minority rights and resolve identity conflicts.

Conclusion

- India's secularism and linguistic pluralism face challenges from identity politics, yet robust policies and civic awareness can protect them. As **B.R. Ambedkar** said, **"Tolerance is the chief moral lesson of the Constitution,"** underscoring respect for all religions and languages.

Q. "The transformation of caste in India from overt exclusion to covert institutional bias reflects a shift from visible discrimination to systemic inequality." Critically examine this transition, highlighting its underlying causes and implications for substantive equality. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the caste system in India.
- **Body:** Write how caste transforms in India, highlighting its underlying causes and implications for substantive equality.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on substantive equality to ensure social harmony and caste equality.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Caste discrimination in India has shifted from visible, direct exclusion to subtle institutional and procedural bias, reflecting deeper systemic inequalities despite constitutional safeguards.

Transformation of the Caste System

- **Overt Exclusion:** Earlier caste discrimination was visible and social exclusion-based. E.g., Denial of temple entry and access to public wells for Dalits.
- **Institutional Bias:** Discrimination now operates through neutral-looking administrative processes. E.g., Use of **"Not found suitable"** in university faculty recruitment.
- **Merit Discourse:** **"Merit" and "suitability"** often mask structural disadvantages. E.g., Low SC/ST representation in elite institutions such as the IITs.
- **Legal Safeguards:** Constitutional provisions reduced open discrimination but not hidden bias. E.g., **Article 17** abolished untouchability, but social exclusion persists.

Underlying Causes

- **Social Continuity:** Deep-rooted caste prejudices persist across generations. E.g., Preference for same-caste marriages via matrimonial platforms.
- **Institutional Neutrality:** Formal equality in systems masks unequal outcomes in practice. E.g., Uniform recruitment criteria ignoring historical disadvantage.
- **Political Economy:** Caste continues to influence access to power and resources. E.g., Dominance of certain caste groups in land ownership in rural India.

Implications for Substantive Equality

- **Unequal Outcomes:** Formal equality fails to ensure real equality in opportunities. E.g., Low representation of SC/ST in senior academic positions.
- **Hidden Discrimination:** Bias becomes indirect and harder to identify within institutional processes. E..g, Rejection of candidates under vague criteria like **"Not found suitable."**

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- **Structural Disadvantage:** Historical deprivation continues to affect access to education and jobs. E.g., SC/ST communities remain concentrated in informal and low-income labour sectors.
- **Policy Challenge:** Requires moving beyond legal equality to structural correction. E.g., Need for transparency and accountability in recruitment systems.

Conclusion

- Caste inequality persists in new forms, requiring **reforms** and **transparency**; PM Modi's vision of **"Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas"** guides inclusion.

Q. Critically assess the effectiveness of the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961, as dowry offences continue to be under-reported and unevenly enforced, while also attracting allegations of misuse. Suggest reforms to enhance its effectiveness and victim-oriented justice. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

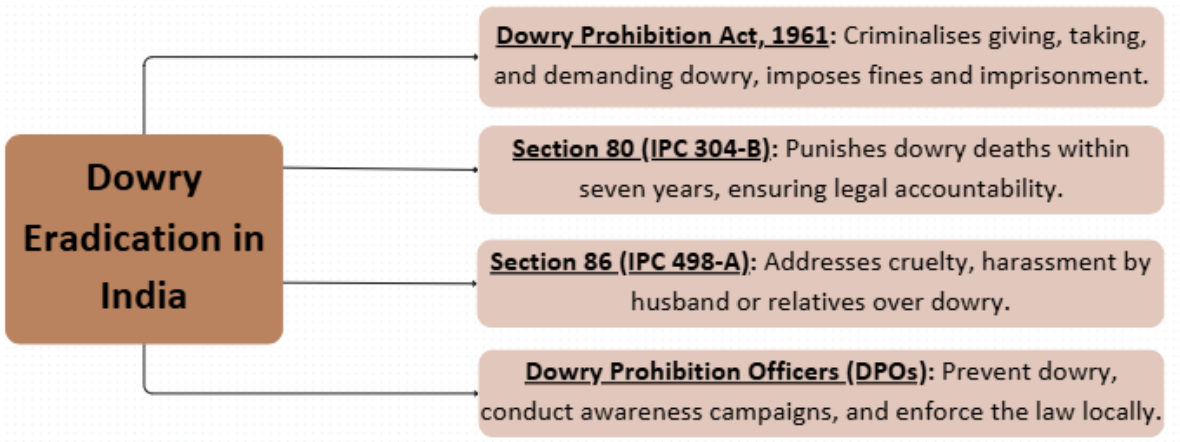
- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961.
- **Body:** Write about the effectiveness of the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961 and suggest reforms to enhance its effectiveness and victim-oriented justice.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on an integrated approach and mention the future course of action.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- Enacted to abolish dowry, the **DPA, 1961,** persists as weakly enforced, as dowry continues due to deep social, legal, and institutional gaps.

Effectiveness of the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961

- **Under-Reporting:** Social stigma and family pressure deter complaints; yet **6,000–7,000 dowry deaths annually (NCRB)** reveal a large hidden incidence.
- **Low Convictions:** **Conviction rates remain 11–17% (NCRB)** due to weak investigation and prosecution, undermining deterrence.
- **Poor Enforcement:** **Dowry Prohibition Officers (DPOs)** remain under-appointed and under-resourced, limiting preventive and monitoring roles.
- **Judicial Delay:** Cases often span 15–20 years, eroding victim confidence and penal credibility.



Reforms to Enhance Its Effectiveness and Victim-Oriented Justice

✓ **Enforcement Strengthening:** Appoint full-time, trained **DPOs** with monitoring and preventive powers.

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- ✓ **Speedy Justice: Establish fast-track courts** and time-bound investigation protocols.
- ✓ **Legal Balance:** Introduce preliminary scrutiny to filter false cases without deterring genuine victims.
- ✓ **Victim-Centric Support:** Expand **One Stop Centres**, **legal aid**, counselling, & rehabilitation support.

Conclusion

- As Ambedkar warned, **"Law and order are the medicine of the body politic"**; only **strong enforcement**, **swift justice**, and **social reform** can end dowry.

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Population and Associated Issues

{IS – Population} India Fertility Transition *

❖ **Context (LM):** India's fertility has **fallen below replacement**, raising concerns over reproductive agency, family structures, and **long-term demographic sustainability**.

Fertility Trends in India

- **Sub-Replacement:** NFHS-5 reports TFR at 2.0, confirming below-replacement fertility nationally.
- **Urban–Rural Gap:** Urban TFR is 1.6, rural TFR remains 2.1, widening demographic disparities.
- **Regional Divide:** Fertility rate remains higher in northern India, but persistently lower in southern India.
- **Desired Gap:** Desired children per woman are **2.2** in rural & **2** in urban areas, showing unmet aspirations.
- **Momentum Effect:** Youthful age structure sustains population growth despite declining fertility rates.

⇨ ***TFR:*** *Total Fertility Rate is the average no. of children a woman bears between the ages of 15 & 49.*
⇨ ***Replacement Level:*** *A **TFR of 2.1** balances parental mortality, sustaining population replacement.*

Cultural and Structural Determinants of Fertility

- **Family Nuclearisation:** Decline of joint families reduces childcare support, lowering fertility outcomes.
- **Urban Constraints:** High housing costs and weak childcare discourage larger family sizes.
- **Parenting Norms:** Rising childcare and education expectations increase stress, delaying childbirth.
- **Patriarchal Control:** Restrictive gender norms limit women's autonomy, reducing reproductive choices.
- **Son Preference:** Cultural bias for male heirs sustains fertility despite smaller family aspirations.

Policy Challenges in Fertility Management

➢ **Regional Diversity:** Varied fertility across states complicates uniform demographic policy design.
➢ **Family Planning:** Programs remain focused on control, neglecting broader reproductive rights.
➢ **Childcare Deficit:** Scarcity of affordable childcare weakens support for fertility aspirations.
➢ **Female FLFPR:** Low female labour force participation rate worsens fertility–employment reconciliation.
➢ **Health Access:** Fertility treatments and reproductive health services remain underutilised nationwide.

Way Forward

✓ **Family Support:** Strengthen childcare, parental leave, and support systems to ease parenting.
✓ **Gender Justice:** Reduce unpaid care burdens and expand women's labour participation opportunities.
✓ **Fertility Services:** Ensure affordable fertility treatment and reproductive healthcare access across India.
✓ **Rights Framework:** Shift family planning **policies towards reproductive rights** and personal autonomy.
✓ **Regional Focus:** Tailor interventions for high-fertility and ageing-prone states differently.

Read More> *State of World Population Report, 2025* | *Total Fertility Rate in India*

{IS – Population} Demography as Strategic Asset

❖ **Context (TH):** India's large youth population, amid ageing global societies, provides unmatched leverage against protectionism and shifting geopolitical challenges.

Demography as Geopolitical Capital

- India's youthful population ensures scale, resilience, and competitiveness in an ageing world.
- **Largest Share:** Youth comprising **~27%** of the population reinforces demographic advantage.

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- **Relative Edge:** Ageing in China and the West enhances India's global demographic position.
- **Labour Supply:** Annual entry of **~8 million workers** strengthens industrial and service productivity.
- **Median Age:** India's **28-year median age** ensures a sustained demographic advantage.

Youth as Instruments of Influence

- **Soft Power:** Youth project India's global influence through art, sports, and cultural exchange.
- **Diaspora Leverage:** Skilled migrants shape policies abroad, amplifying India's strategic influence.
- **Research Diplomacy:** Participation in global science networks enhances India's innovation credibility.
- **Digital Presence:** Youth-led IT expertise projects India as a digital governance leader.
- **Consumer Force:** Expanding youth demand cushions trade shocks and attracts foreign investment.

Constraints Diluting Youth Potential

- **Skill Deficit:** Inadequate training & skill mismatch limit youth contribution to global competitiveness.
- **Economic Divide:** Persistent income and gender gaps reduce youth international mobility.
- **Visa Barriers:** Geopolitical restrictions limit opportunities for youth migration and exchanges.
- **Research Gaps:** Weak R&D and poor global integration limit youth in high-value sector chains.
- **Institutional Exclusion:** Youth lack formal representation within foreign policy institutions & processes.

Way Forward

- ✓ Strategic reforms in skills, inclusion, and institutions can unlock youth diplomacy dividends.
- ✓ **Skill Expansion:** Strengthen vocational training & **STEM education** to enhance global competitiveness.
- ✓ **Inclusive Growth:** Address regional, gender, and income divides to broaden youth opportunities.
- ✓ **Research Linkages:** Expand R&D spending and integrate universities into global innovation networks.
- ✓ **Mobility Framework:** Negotiate **easier visa regimes** and enhance international exchange programmes.
- ✓ **Institutional Inclusion:** Create youth advisory roles within MEA and multilateral organisations.

Read More> *India's Demographic Dividend*

{IS – Population} India's Demographic Transition

- **Context (TH):** India is transitioning from a youthful, fast-growing population to an ageing, urbanised society, presenting both challenges and demographic opportunities by 2051.

Demographic Transition in India

- **Slower Growth:** Population to rise from **1,355.8 million (2021)** to **1,590.1 million** (**2051**) at **0.5% annual growth**, slowing expansion.
- **Falling Child Population:** Pre-primary (0–4 years) numbers drop from **113.5 million (2021)** to **8.6 million** (**2051**), affecting school demand.
- **Education Shift:** Government schools fall from **11.07 lakh (2014–15)** to **10.18 lakh (2023–24)**; private schools rise from **2.88 lakh to 3.31 lakh**.
- **Ageing Society:** Elderly (60+) increase from **130.5 million (9.6%)** to **325.3 million** (**20.5%**), straining healthcare and social security.
- **Workforce Trends:** Working-age population peaks at **1,009 million** (**65.5%**) **in 2041**, then declines to **998.1 million (62.8%) in 2051**, limiting the demographic dividend.

Opportunities for India

- **Education Reform:** Shrinking pre-primary population from **113.5 million to 8.6 million** (mid-century) improves teacher-student ratios and school resource use.

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- **Healthcare Efficiency:** Falling birth rates lower maternity care demand, enabling better resource allocation and quality in maternal health.
- **Gender Dividend:** Declining working-age population after 2041 can be balanced by higher female workforce participation to boost productivity.
- **Silver Economy:** Elderly population rising to **20.5% by 2051** offers opportunities in **geriatric care** and **senior-focused services**.

Implications of India's Demographic Transition

- **Schooling Impact:** Pre-primary population (0–4 years) to drop to 8.6 million by 2050, reducing demand for government schools.
- **Private Education:** Growing preference for private schools (rose from **2.88 lakh to 3.31 lakh**) reflects shifting education demand and quality expectations.
- **Workforce Decline:** Working-age population peaks at 1,009 million (65.5%) in 2041, then declines to **998.1 million** (**62.8%**) by 2051, shrinking the demographic dividend.
- **Policy Challenges:** Median age rises to **40 years** (**2051**), requiring reforms in healthcare, pensions, education, and skill development.

Key Challenges

- **Falling Child Population:** Pre-primary population drops to 8.6 million, reducing school demand and affecting education planning.
- **Skill Gap:** Youth lack skills and education to use India's demographic advantage effectively.
- **Resource Pressure:** Declining fertility and ageing require restructuring healthcare and social support systems.

Way Forward: Demographic Strategy

- ✓ **Education Upgrade:** PMKVY trained **1.64 crore youth**, strengthening employability and vocational skills.
- ✓ **Gender Inclusion:** Rising women's participation in **IT and healthcare** boosts workforce diversity.
- ✓ **Geriatric Support:** Expand elderly healthcare and pensions. E.g., **Kerala's senior care programs**.
- ✓ **Silver Economy:** Promote senior entrepreneurship and employment, inspired by **Japan's elder entrepreneurship initiatives**.

{IS – Population} Generation Beta and India's Digital Future **

❖ **Context (IE | IE | ET): Generation Beta**, born **2025–2039**, follows **Gen Z** and **Alpha**, representing **India's digital future generations** shaped by AI and technology.

Characteristics of Generation Beta

- **Born between 2025 and 2039:** The first cohort to grow up with micro-computing technologies
- **Tech-Savvy:** More adept than previous generations due to advanced exposure to emerging technologies like AI, virtual reality and smart systems.
- **Innovative and Adaptable:** Expected to embrace cutting-edge developments such as quantum computing and the **metaverse**.
- **Highly Connected:** Through **digital platforms**, fostering inclusivity & empathy.

⇨ ***Artificial Intelligence (AI):*** *Machines performing tasks requiring human-like intelligence, such as language understanding, pattern recognition, and decision-making.*

⇨ ***Metaverse:*** *A virtual reality space where users can interact in a computer-generated environment, often used for entertainment, education and socialising.*

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Technology's Role in Generation Beta

- **Instant Gratification:** Constant exposure to AI and Virtual Reality could foster instant gratification.
- **Education Transformation:** Tech-driven personalised learning using AI tutors, VR classrooms, and digital tools will allow for tailored and efficient learning experiences.
- **Higher Adaptability:** Digital fluency enables rapid innovation, adaptability, and problem-solving.
- **Workplace Shifts:** Careers will focus on **creativity** and **emotional intelligence** as automation grows.

Cultural and Social Impact

- **Breaking Conventional Norms:** Growing up in a connected world, they may promote inclusivity, empathy, eco-conscious lifestyles and global understanding.
- **Redefining Relationships:** Technology-driven interactions may redefine personal relationships and work-place dynamics.
- **Challenges to Tradition:** **Fluid identities** and cultural shifts might create intergenerational challenges.

Challenges Faced by Generation Beta

- **Mental Health Risks:** Prolonged screen exposure causes anxiety, social isolation & poor self-esteem.
- **Attention issues:** Increased **digital immersion** might challenge their long-term problem-solving ability.
- **Privacy and Ethics:** Integrating AI and VR raises concerns about privacy, safety & ethical boundaries.
- **Sustainability Concerns:** Climate change awareness could foster **eco-consciousness** but may also create **existential anxiety**.

Way Forward for Generation Beta

- ✓ **Digital Wellness:** WHO-backed screen-time management, counselling services, and digital literacy programs to reduce anxiety and attention disorders.
- ✓ **Ethical Governance:** Strengthen AI regulation and child data protection through the **Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023**.
- ✓ **Future Education:** Implement NEP 2020 reforms emphasising AI literacy, coding, critical thinking, emotional intelligence, and sustainability skills.

{IS – Population and Associated Issues – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. Despite having the world's largest youth population, India struggles to fully realise its demographic dividend. Critically examine the structural bottlenecks and analyse the effectiveness of current government initiatives. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the youth population in India.
- **Body:** Write key structural bottlenecks, also mention the effectiveness of current government initiatives, and the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on an integrated & inclusive policy to unlock full demographic dividend for growth.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India's large youth population offers a unique opportunity to accelerate economic growth and innovation, provided education, skills, and employment are effectively harnessed.

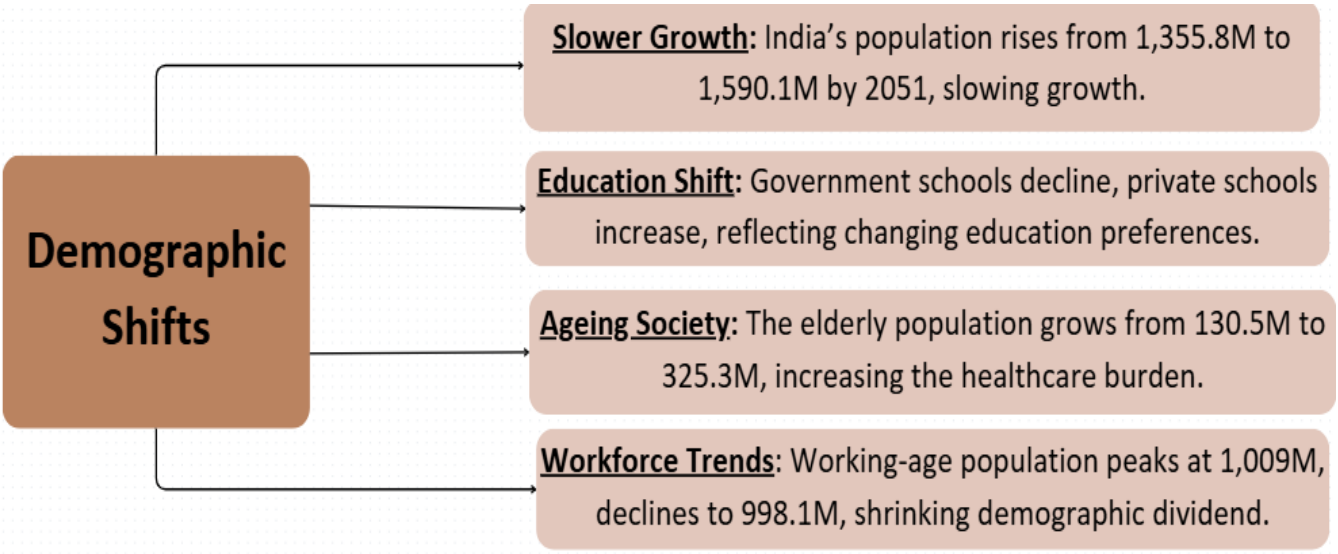
Structural Bottlenecks

- **Skill Gap:** Only **4.4–4.9% of Indian youth** receive formal skill training, limiting employability.

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- **Education Inequality:** Less than **47% of schools** provide skill-based courses, restricting job readiness. (Economic Survey 2025-26).
- **Unemployment:** **67% of unemployed youth** are graduates, reflecting a mismatch between education and employment.
- **Gender Disparity:** Female labour participation is **32.8%,** underutilising India's workforce potential.



Effectiveness of Current Government Initiatives

- **Skill Initiatives:** PM Kaushal Vikas Yojana trained **1.64 crore youth**, improving employability, but is limited in coverage and industry relevance.
- **Education Reforms:** NEP 2020 promotes holistic and skill-integrated education; implementation and scale remain challenging.
- **Entrepreneurship Support:** Startup India and Atmanirbhar Bharat encourage youth self-employment, but **access to finance and mentorship** is constrained.
- **Gender Inclusion:** Programs like MGNREGA and Beti Bachao Beti Padhao aim to raise female workforce participation, yet socio-cultural and urban employment gaps limit effectiveness.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Skill Linkage:** Align vocational training with industry and regional employment needs to enhance youth employability.
- ✓ **Education Quality:** Improve government schools through digital learning, vocational courses, and **teacher upskilling**.
- ✓ **Gender Inclusion:** Boost female workforce participation via flexible work, skill programs, & safety measures.
- ✓ **Silver Economy:** Invest in geriatric care, pensions, and senior entrepreneurship to harness the ageing population's potential.

Conclusion

- **India's youth are its greatest asset**; bridging skill gaps, promoting gender inclusion, and fostering entrepreneurship will unlock the full demographic dividend for growth.

-------- End of Chapter --------

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Women, Children & Vulnerable Sections

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Ageing Women and Health Challenges **

❖ **Context (TH):** As India's elderly population may reach 20% by 2050, ageing women face longer lives but greater health vulnerabilities.

Health-Seeking Behaviour

- **Family Roles:** Socialised to prioritise family over self; household dynamics delay care.
- **Financial Insecurity:** 60% of elderly women have no personal income, and less than 20% can pay medical bills independently.
- **Digital Divide:** Creates dependence on male relatives and restricts access to healthcare.
- **Facility Gaps:** Lack of gender-sensitive facilities and female providers.

Disease Burden

- **Chronic Diseases:** Higher risks of osteoporosis, arthritis, cardiovascular diseases, and cancers (breast, cervical, ovarian).
- **Under-diagnosis:** Like uro-gynaecological issues and mental health (depression, dementia).
- **Caregiving Burden:** Continued caregiving duties even in old age worsen physical and mental stress.

Social & Structural Factors

- **Support Systems:** Widowhood, migration-driven nuclear families, & isolation reduce support systems.
- **Isolation:** Over **18.7%** of elderly women now live alone, heightening risk of isolation.

Policy Interventions

- The **National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE)** to provide accessible, specialized healthcare for older persons at all levels.
- Ayushman Bharat: Provides hospitalisation coverage but limited geriatric and outpatient focus.
- Atal Pension Yojana: Social security measures, but with gender-blind eligibility and inadequate payouts.
- **Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana:** Free assistive devices for BPL senior citizens.
- **State Initiatives:**
  - ❖ **Kerala's Vayomithram:** Mobile clinics for elderly healthcare.
  - ❖ **Kudumbashree:** Women-led self-help groups providing economic and social support in Kerala.

Way Forward

✓ **Geriatric Care:** Screening for osteoporosis, cancers, uro-gynaecological conditions, and mental health.
✓ **Insurance Reform:** Add women-specific geriatric packages (bone scans, mental health, physiotherapy).
✓ **Support Systems:** Smart City elder centres reduce loneliness through healthcare and engagement.
✓ **Social Security:** Inflation-linked pensions recognise women's unpaid caregiving and support.

Also Read More> *India's Elderly Population | Senior Citizens in India | Silver Economy | Healthy Ageing*

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} ASHA Workers and Rural Healthcare

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❖ **Context (TH):** ASHA workers, central to India's healthcare system, demand fair compensation amid challenging working conditions.

ASHA Workers in India

- **Role & Function:** ASHAs support maternal-child health, immunisation, & grassroots health awareness.
- **Community Link:** Connect communities with healthcare services, sanitation, and welfare programmes.
- **Coverage:** Over **10 lakh ASHAs** strengthen healthcare delivery across India.
- **Incentive Issues:** Performance-based incentives trigger demands for salaries and social security.
- **Global Recognition:** Received **WHO Global Health Leaders Award 2022** for COVID-19 contributions.

Selection and Training

- **Eligibility Criteria:** **Women aged 25-45**, selected through a rigorous community-driven process.
- **Training Modules:** Receive training in maternal care, sanitation, and primary healthcare.

Societal Impact

- **Empowerment Through Work:** ASHA work provides financial independence and dignity to women in abusive or restrictive households.
- **Social Bonding and Support:** Workers form strong support systems, helping each other navigate personal hardships.

Challenges Faced by ASHA Workers

➢ **Low Remuneration:** ₹3,000 honorarium with additional performance-based incentives for earnings.
➢ **Pay Revision:** Average earnings reached **₹16,000** in 2024 after protests.
➢ **Recognition Gap:** Perform government duties but remain classified as volunteers.
➢ **Workplace Risks:** Face harassment, mobility challenges, and unsafe working conditions.

Reforms Needed

✓ **Fair Compensation:** Shift from incentive-based earnings to a fixed monthly salary.
✓ **Employment Rights:** Formal recognition as government employees with associated benefits.
✓ **Workplace Safety Measures:** Stronger protections against harassment and unsafe working conditions.
✓ **Mental and Social Security:** Provision of healthcare benefits and psychological support services.
✓ **Policy Revisions:** Strengthen ASHA program with structured pay scales and formal employment status.
✓ **Govt Support:** Enhance incentives and integrate ASHAs into state health insurance and pension schemes.
✓ **Public Awareness:** Greater acknowledgement of ASHA workers' contributions to rural healthcare.

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Feminisation of Agriculture *

❖ **Context (TH):** Feminisation of agriculture in rural dynamics raises questions about whether it leads to empowerment or reinforces existing gender disparities.

⇨ ***Feminisation of agriculture*** *refers to the increasing participation of women in agricultural activities (as cultivators or casual agricultural wage workers), driven largely by male migration.*

Status of Female Workforce Participation in Agriculture

- **Labour Force Participation:** Women constitute **63%** of India's agricultural labour force but face significant challenges regarding land ownership, financial resources, and decision-making power.
- **Rural Involvement:** Over **76%** of rural women are engaged in agriculture, yet land ownership and control remain skewed.

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- **Land Ownership:** **Only 11.72%** of India's agricultural land is managed by female operational holders, reflecting gender disparity in land ownership.

Factors Driving Feminisation of Agriculture

- **Male Migration:** Economic distress and limited non-farm employment opportunities push men to migrate, leaving women to take on farm responsibilities.
- **Rural Distress:** Declining agricultural production, higher input costs, and climate change have worsened rural economic conditions, forcing women to step into agriculture.
- **Limited Non-Farm Jobs:** Most rural women have limited access to non-farm employment, pushing them into agriculture, where opportunities are more prevalent.

Challenges to Women's Empowerment in Agriculture

- **Double Burden:** Women juggle farm work, household duties, and caregiving responsibilities.
- **Limited Agency:** Despite farm participation, women lack decision-making over inputs and crops.
- **Land Ownership Gap:** Only **8.4% of women** own land, limiting economic independence.
- **Credit Exclusion:** Lack of land collateral restricts loans, KCC, and investments.
- **Poverty Trap:** Weak land rights deepen rural poverty and economic vulnerability.

Benefits of Women's Empowerment in Agriculture

- **Economic Growth:** Equal access to agricultural resources can **increase yields by 20-30%,** enhancing food security and rural economic stability.
- **Strengthened Decision-Making:** Empowering women in agriculture boosts their participation in decision-making, increasing their agency over household and agricultural matters.
- **Improved Livelihoods:** Access to land and credit can help women secure a better livelihood, reducing poverty and economic dependency.

Way Forward for Empowering Women in Agriculture

- ✓ **Policy Reforms:** Women should be central to policies addressing agriculture, land rights & credit access.
- ✓ **Land Distribution and Rights:** Equal distribution of land and ensuring women's legal rights over land can enable better access to resources, increasing productivity.
- ✓ **Financial Support:** Providing women with easier access to credit and subsidies will enable them to invest in land and farming technology.
- ✓ **Replicate Kudumbashree Model:** In Kerala, the **Kudumbashree initiative** has successfully empowered women through community-based organisations, enhancing their agricultural roles & economic security.
- ✓ **Gender-Responsive Climate Policies:** Developing policies that address climate change effects on agriculture while considering gender dynamics can enhance women's resilience in farming.
- ✓ **Implement Collective Action:** **Multi-tier collectives** focused on poverty eradication have raised women's status from agricultural labourers to cultivators and entrepreneurs.

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Women's Workforce Potential in India

❖ **Context(TH):** India's female LFPR is 37%, hindered by unpaid care work and lack of formal part-time jobs, as per the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER).

About NCAER

- **Oldest Economic Think Tank:** Established in **1956**, NCAER is India's **oldest and largest independent** economic policy research institute.

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- **Research & Data Collection:** Conducts **grant-funded** and **commissioned studies** for governments and industry, uniquely combining policy research with primary data collection.
- **Thematic Focus Areas:** Macroeconomic policy & trade, industry & labor, agriculture & environment, and poverty & human development.

Findings from NCAER Study

Current Status of Female Labour Force Participation

- **Low LFPR:** India's female LFPR (**37%**) lags behind the global average (47%) & the OECD average (67%).
- **Economic impact:** **60%** of working-age women remain outside the workforce, limiting India's economic growth.
- **Gender disparity in unpaid work:** Women spend **twice as much time on unpaid care work as men** (Time Use in India Report 2019), restricting their participation in paid employment.

Barriers to Women's Workforce Participation

- **Unpaid care responsibilities:** Child-rearing, elder care, and household work disproportionately burden women, reducing time for formal employment.
- **Lack of formal part-time work:** Unlike advanced economies, India lacks formal recognition for part-time jobs, pushing women into informal and unprotected employment.
- **Dual burden of work:** Women struggle to balance professional and domestic duties, limiting career prospects and economic contributions.

Policy Recommendations by NCAER

- **Formal Part-Time Work:** Regulated part-time jobs could raise female LFPR from **37%–43%**.
- **Care Infrastructure:** Expand childcare and eldercare facilities to reduce women's unpaid burdens.
- **Shared Caregiving:** Paid parental leave promotes equitable caregiving and workforce participation.
- **Flexible Employment:** Remote work and flexible schedules support working women.

Economic and Social Benefits of Higher Female LFPR

- **Economic Growth:** Closing gender gaps could increase **India's GDP by 27%.**
- **Higher Incomes:** Women's earnings improve household living standards and stability.
- **Social Change:** Greater participation challenges stereotypes and promotes gender equality.
- **Family Welfare:** Financially independent women improve family health and education

Challenges in Implementation

- **Cultural Resistance:** Deep-rooted gender norms hinder equitable sharing of caregiving responsibilities.
- **Employer Reluctance:** Many businesses resist flexible work without regulatory mandates.
- **Informal Workforce:** Over **80% workforce is informal**, complicating part-time job formalisation.

Best Practices from Advanced Economies

- **Scandinavian Model:** Subsidised childcare and parental leave significantly boost female employment.
- **France's Protection:** Part-time workers receive equal benefits and job security.
- **EU Directives:** Equal pay and social security mandated since 1997.

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Maternity Rights Expansion

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- **Context (IE)**: Recent Supreme Court ruling (**K. Umadevi v. Government of Tamil Nadu**) affirming maternity leave as a **constitutional right** has reignited debate on reproductive justice and social inclusion.

SC Judgment

- Upheld maternity leave as a **reproductive right** protected under **Article 21**.
- Held that state rules cannot override central laws (Maternity Benefit Act, 1961) under **Art 254 of IC**.
- Emphasised that reproductive rights form part of international human rights law, including right to health, dignity & non-discrimination.

⇨ *Maternity leave is a paid leave provided to expecting or pregnant women who can utilise it before and after the delivery of the child.*

Reproductive Rights

- Composite human rights including access to contraception, safe abortion, fertility treatments & maternal healthcare.
- **Categories**:
  1. Right to reproductive self-determination.
  2. Right to sexual & reproductive health services, information & education.
  3. Right to equality & non-discrimination.
- **International Conventions**:

1. Universal Declaration of Human Rights **(UDHR):** Affirms the right to health, dignity, and social security, including maternity-related protections under Article 25.
2. ILO **Maternity Protection Conventions (1919, revised 2000)**: Guarantee paid maternity leave, protection from dismissal & access to healthcare for working women during pregnancy and childbirth.

Maternity Leave Policy in India

- **Maternity Benefit Act, 1961:** Provides paid maternity leave for 12 weeks.
- **Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017:** Provides for **paid maternity leave** to all women (incl. adoptive & commissioning mothers) for 26 weeks for 1st and 2nd child and 12 weeks for 3rd child.
- **Creche Facility:** Mandatory for **establishments with 50+ employees**, allowing **4 daily visits** by mother.

Need for Maternity Leave

- **Equal Participation of Women:** PLFS 2022–23 states Female Labour Force Participation Rate (FLFPR) stands at **37%**.
- **Workplace Benefits:** Reduces attrition, improves employee retention, job satisfaction, and women's career continuity.
- **Physical & Emotional Recovery:** Essential for maternal health, postpartum healing & reducing maternal mortality.
- **Childcare & Bonding:** Crucial for neonatal care & development of strong mother-child emotional bonds.

Challenges

- **Coverage Gaps: Only 10%** of women in the formal sector are included & majority of working women in the informal sector are excluded.
- **Private Sector Non-Compliance:** Women face discrimination in hiring, promotions or are forced to resign post-pregnancy. Resistance to providing creche facilities.
- **Policy Limitation:** No universal parental or paternity leave law yet. Countries like Sweden (1974), Norway, & Estonia offer gender-neutral family leave of up to 1 year.

Way Forward

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- ✓ **Extend Coverage:** Bring informal sector and contractual employees under the Maternity Benefit Act.
- ✓ **Awareness:** Conduct awareness campaigns about legal maternity rights.
- ✓ **Gender Equity:** Introduce paid paternity and family leave to balance caregiving roles.
- ✓ **Rights-Based Approach:** Reproductive autonomy must not be sacrificed for population control goals.

Also read > *Maternity Benefit Amendment Act, 2017*

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} AI & Women's Employment **

- **Context (IE):** Women remain underrepresented in the AI workforce despite high STEM graduation rates.

Women in the AI Industry

- **STEM Employment Gap:** Women are **43% of STEM graduates** but only **14%** of STEM workers.
- **Workplace Bias:** **81% of women in tech** report bias during performance evaluations.
- **AI Representation Gap:** Women comprise only **10–15% of AI specialists** globally.
- **Research Inequality:** Women authors are just **13.83% of AI research papers**.

How is AI Empowering Women in the Workforce?

- **Job Potential:** India needs **1 million AI professionals by 2026**, boosting opportunities.
- **Flexible Work:** AI enables remote jobs for women facing caregiving constraints.
- **Domestic Automation:** AI tools reduce unpaid work, increasing women's economic participation.
- **Inclusive Workplaces:** AI mentorship and upskilling foster gender-inclusive professional environments.

Gendered Risks of AI

- **Under-Representation:** Women make up 43% of STEM graduates but only 26% of AI professionals.
- **Automation Risk:** 10% of women's jobs are vulnerable to AI, compared with 3.5% of men's.
- **Algorithmic Bias:** Male-centric datasets create biased AI systems and outcomes.
- **Time Poverty:** Women spend **201 extra minutes daily** on unpaid work.

Government Initiatives for Gender-Inclusive AI

- **KIRAN Scheme:** Supports women scientists' return to R&D careers through fellowships and grants.
- **WISE-KIRAN Scheme:** Support women at various stages of their scientific careers.
- **WISE-PhD and WISE-Post Doctoral Fellowship (WISE-PDF):** Encourages women to pursue research in basic and applied sciences.
- **Vigyan Jyoti Program:** Encourages female students to pursue higher education and careers in STEM.
- **Consolidation of University Research for Innovation and Excellence (CURIE) Program:** Empowers exclusive women's universities by supporting research facilities in basic and applied sciences.
- **#AIforAll Strategy:** Promotes inclusive AI development.
- **WE-Hub Hyderabad:** Trained 700+ girls (13–17 yrs) in AI, empowers women entrepreneurs in tech space.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Enhance Women's Role:** Promote women in leadership, close pay gaps, and support roles in AI ethics, governance, and R&D.
- ✓ **Education & Skilling:** Launch **AI-focused scholarships**, mentorships, and rural skilling programs for women. **Revamp STEM curricula** to reduce gender bias.
- ✓ **Labour & Security Policies:** Ensure flexible work, income continuity & legal safeguards against AI-led job losses. Introduce conditional cash transfers and subsidised pensions for low-skill displaced workers.
- ✓ **Technology for Unpaid Work:** Use AI to reduce unpaid domestic workload (e.g., smart home tech), enabling greater female economic participation, especially in agriculture and informal sectors.

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{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Women in the STEM Sector *

❖ **Context (TH):** Persistent barriers **continue to restrict women's access** to career opportunities in the fields of **Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics (STEM)**.

The STEM Paradox in India

- **STEM Gap:** Women are **43% of STEM graduates** but only 27% of the workforce.
- **Participation Divide:** Female LFPR **41.7%;** STEM fields still show gender gaps.
- **Leaky Pipeline:** Workplace barriers and caregiving burdens drive women's attrition.

Need for Gender Inclusion in STEM

- **Economic Growth:** Higher female participation could add **$770 billion** to GDP.
- **GDP Boost:** **50% female workforce participation** may raise growth by **1%**.
- **Innovation Gains:** Diverse STEM teams generate better solutions and innovations.
- **Social Equity:** Women's role models challenge stereotypes and inspire generations.

Challenges Faced by Women in STEM

➢ **Gender Stereotypes:** Despite **43% of STEM graduates,** women remain **only 27%** of the workforce.
➢ **Workplace Barriers:** Women hold just **14% of STEM jobs** despite educational achievements.
➢ **Career Awareness Gap:** Rural women's LFPR is **47.6%**, yet STEM participation remains limited.
➢ **Skill Mismatch:** Only **26% of AI roles** are occupied by women professionals.

Government Initiatives

1. **New Education Policy (NEP) 2020:** It promotes STEM, gender inclusion, experiential learning, and integrates early life skills & technical training to enhance career readiness, especially for girls.
2. **Gender Budgeting:** The share of the gender budget in the total national Budget has increased from 6.8% in 2024-25 to **8.8% in 2025-26**, with **₹4.49 lakh crore**.
3. **'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao':** A nationwide campaign aimed at improving the status of girls through education and empowerment, encouraging girls to pursue higher education, including STEM.
4. **Skill India Mission:** Offers **technical and vocational training**, with a growing focus on skilling women in non-traditional domains, including electronics, IT, and mechanical trades.
5. **Digital India:** It promotes digital literacy, e-governance, and entrepreneurship, creating pathways for women to enter the technology and innovation sectors.
6. **STEM-Focused Scholarships and Fellowships:** Programmes like **Vigyan Jyoti** and **KIRAN** support women researchers and encourage them to pursue careers in science.

Way Forward

✓ **Industry Linkages:** Align curricula with industry needs; women form **43% of STEM graduates**.
✓ **Gender-Sensitive Workplaces:** Flexible policies can help retain women beyond **27%** of STEM workforce.
✓ **Mentorship Networks:** More role models can improve women's **26% AI workforce representation**.
✓ **Career Awareness:** Target rural girls; female LFPR reaches **47.6%** in villages.
✓ **Re-entry Programmes:** Upskilling supports women returning after caregiving-related career breaks.

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Women Entrepreneurship in India *

- **Context (PIB):** Women entrepreneurship in India is being actively promoted to **enhance inclusive growth** and **increase their share in the MSME sector**.

Current Facts and Data

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- **Women-Owned MSMEs:** **Over 46.7 lakh** women-owned MSMEs are registered on the **Udyam portal**.
- **Informal Dominance:** 70.5% of micro-enterprises on the **Udyam Assist Platform** are women-owned.
- **Low Share:** Less than 1% of Indian women are formal entrepreneurs compared to **3% of men**.
- **Self-Employment Trend:** **67.4% of working women** were self-employed (PLFS).

Government Initiatives to Promote Women Entrepreneurship

1. **Collateral-Free Loans:** Provide loans **up to ₹10 lakh** to women-led micro-enterprises under the Micro Units Development and Refinance Agency (MUDRA) Scheme.
2. **Targeted Lending:** Mandates **one woman borrower** per bank branch for loans between ₹10 lakh and ₹1 crore under the Stand-Up India Scheme.
3. **Subsidy Support:** Offers **35% capital subsidy** to women entrepreneurs under the Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme (PMEGP).
4. **Student Training:** Trains women students in entrepreneurship under the Swavalambini Programme, a joint initiative of **SIDBI** and **NITI Aayog's** Women Entrepreneurship Platform.
5. **Artisan Empowerment:** Supports women artisans in **18 traditional trades** through training and branding under the Pradhan Mantri Vishwakarma Yojana.
6. **Tribal Skilling:** Provides entrepreneurship & skill development for tribal women under **PM JANMAN (PM Tribal Justice and Empowerment Mission)** & **Dharti Aaba Janjatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan**.

Significance of Women Entrepreneurship in India

- **Jobs Contribution:** Employ over **2.84 crore people**, boosting GDP and formal job creation.
- **Demographic Dividend:** With women forming **48% of India's population**, their inclusion in entrepreneurship taps a vast, underutilised human resource base.
- **Startup Diversity:** India hosts **76,000+ women-led startups**, enhancing innovation, diversity, and problem-solving capacity in the entrepreneurial ecosystem.
- **Poverty Reduction:** With **67.4%** of working women self-employed (PLFS), entrepreneurship enables income generation and financial independence, helping reduce poverty.

Structural Challenges in Women Entrepreneurship in India

- **Credit Exclusion:** Around 90% of women-led enterprises remain excluded from formal credit access.
- **Collateral Barrier:** Low property and asset ownership restricts women from securing loans.
- **Missing Middle:** Nearly **95%** of women-owned firms remain micro, rarely scaling to the medium.
- **Digital Divide:** Women entrepreneurs face barriers of literacy, affordability, and technology access.
- **Online Harassment:** **Gender-based cyberviolence** restricts visibility & digital participation.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Credit Inclusion:** Enable no-collateral micro-loans via SHGs and digital lending platforms.
- ✓ **Digital Literacy:** Expand Internet Saathi-style training to boost rural women's digital skills.
- ✓ **Market Access:** Ensure women-only stalls and 100% trade-fair subsidies for visibility.
- ✓ **AI Mentorship:** Pilot AI-powered mentorship networks using grassroots SHG platforms for guidance.
- ✓ **Financial Partnerships:** Form a **women-focused VC fund** to back women-led startups.

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Gendered Care Burden

- **Context (TH):** India's **female labour force participation is 37%,** below the **global average of 47.8%**, with many women remaining unpaid caregivers in the hidden economy sector.

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Reason for Low Female Labour Force Participation

- **Unpaid Care Burden:** Indian women spend **299 minutes/day** on unpaid work vs men's **97 minutes**.
  Social Norms: **40%** of women need permission even for healthcare visits (NFHS).
- **Skill Gap:** Only 23% of employable youth are women (India Skills Report 2024).
- **Informal Labour:** **90%** of working women are in informal jobs with low wages (IL0).

Need for a Comprehensive Care Ecosystem

- **Workforce Boost:** India's **FLPR is 37%** (2022-23), below the **global 47.8%,** showing care services are key to higher participation.
- **Unpaid Burden:** Women spend **3 times more** time than men on unpaid care (NSO).
- **GDP Potential:** Equal gender participation could add **$770 bn to GDP by 2030** (McKinsey).
- **Care Informality:** **About 4.2 million domestic workers** act as caregivers without training or protections.

Challenges

- **Lack of Standards:** Around **4.2 million domestic workers** lack formal wages and protections.
- **Funding Constraints:** Public spending on care services remains limited and fragmented.
- **Sector Undervaluation:** Women perform **76% of unpaid care work** globally (ILO).
- **Policy Gaps:** India lacks a comprehensive national policy governing the care economy.
- **Data Deficit:** Time Use Survey data remains limited for care planning.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Policy Framework:** Sweden provides **480 days of parental leave**, ensuring life-course care support.
- ✓ **Skilled Workforce:** **Canada** funds certified training programmes for a professionalised care workforce.
- ✓ **Coordination:** Inter-ministerial bodies coordinate care policy. E.g., UK care integration model.
- ✓ **Economic Driver:** **Australia's NDIS** shows the care sector boosts inclusion and productivity.

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Women's Political Participation in India *

- **Context (TH):** Over the past six decades, Indian women have achieved near-equal voter participation, yet this remarkable inclusion has not translated into proportional political representation or power.

Current Status of Women's Political Participation

- **Meaning:** It refers to empowering women to vote, contest elections, engage in decision-making, and shape policies, ensuring gender equality and inclusive governance.
- **Voter Parity:** Gender turnout gap fell from **11.2%** (1967) to **nearly 0%** (2019 & 2024).
- **Representation Low:** Women hold **74 seats** (**~13.6%**) in the 2024 Lok Sabha.
- **Candidature Gap:** **800 women** contested in 2024, still far fewer than men.
- **Success Higher:** 2024, **9%** of women candidates won vs. **6%** of men.
- **State Trend:** Post-2011, women's turnout exceeds men by **~2% in many states**.

Empowering Women Through Politics

- **Democratic Voice:** Women's voter turnout **nearly equals men's in elections**.
- **Policy Influence:** Higher participation strengthens women-centric policies in governance.
- **Political Autonomy:** About **50% women voted independently** in 2024 elections.
- **Leadership Base:** **Over 1.4 million women** serve in Panchayati Raj institutions.

Factors Limiting Women's Political Participation

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- **Patriarchal Norm:** **22%** of women cite **patriarchal structures** as the biggest obstacle to political participation (Lokniti–CSDS Survey).
- **Household Burden:** **13%** of women report that domestic responsibilities and caregiving limit their engagement in politics.
- **Family Approval:** Most women require family permission to attend rallies or campaign. E.g., only **50% voted independently in 2024**.
- **Candidature Gap:** In 2024, only **800 women** contested Lok Sabha elections, a small fraction compared to thousands of male candidates.
- **Representation Deficit:** Women hold just **74 seats** (**~13.6%**) in the 2024 Lok Sabha, highlighting **structural underrepresentation** despite near-equal voter turnout.

Impact of Low Women's Participation

- **Policy Bias:** Few women leaders make local projects focus less on water, toilets, and schools. E.g., In **Ajmer, Rajasthan**, Panchayats prioritised community halls over toilets and water.
- **Proxy Politics:** Women elected in villages often don't make decisions; men take charge. E.g., **Odisha's "Pati-Panchayat"** allows husbands to control women leaders' work.
- **Social Stagnation:** Without women leaders, important social issues like child marriage are ignored. E.g., in Sehore, Madhya Pradesh, low women's leadership delayed child marriage reforms.
- **Assembly Gap:** **Karnataka** has **only 10 women MLAs out of 224**, limiting influence on state budget and industrial policy decisions.

Government Initiatives

- **Constitutional Guarantees: Articles 325 & 326** of IC provide equal voting rights, while **Articles 84 & 173** allow all citizens, including women, to contest elections.
- **Seat Reservations:**
  - 33% seats reserved for women in Panchayats & Urban Local Bodies via **73rd & 74th Amendments**.
  - **Women's Reservation Act, 2023** (**106th Amendment**) mandates **33% seats** in the Lok Sabha & State Assemblies (to be implemented post-delimitation & census).
- **Sashakt Panchayat-Netri Abhiyan:** Trains Women Elected Representatives in leadership and governance to enhance their political effectiveness.
- **Nirbhay Raho Initiative: Empowers women in panchayats** by building legal awareness and promoting gender-sensitive leadership.
- **Model Women-Friendly Gram Panchayats:** Establish gram panchayats that are inclusive and supportive of women's participation in local governance.
- **Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan:** Strengthens Panchayati Raj Institutions through systematic training and support, with a focus on women leaders.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Expand Quotas: Increase legal reservations** beyond 33% in Parliament, State Assemblies, and Panchayati Raj Institutions to ensure equitable representation.
- ✓ **Leadership Training:** Scale mentorship and capacity-building programs like **Sashakt Panchayat-Netri Abhiyan** to prepare women leaders for local, state, and national politics.
- ✓ **Digital Empowerment:** Leverage technology for campaigns, e-training, and voter outreach, as seen in **Kenya's Women in Politics platform**, enabling online training and virtual campaigning.

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- ✓ **Norm Change:** Run awareness campaigns and community outreach to challenge stereotypes and normalise women's political leadership.
- ✓ **Party Incentives:** Implement party quotas, offer campaign support, and create safe environments to increase women's participation.

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Women-Led Development in India

❖ **Context (PIB): International Women's Day** is observed every year on **8 March** to celebrate women's achievements and accelerate progress towards gender equality.

- The first observances took place in Europe in 1911, and the UN officially recognised the day in **1977**.
- The 2026 theme, *'Rights. Justice. Action. For ALL Women and Girls'*, emphasises dismantling structural barriers to ensure equal justice.
- India shifted its policy from "development for women" to "**Women-Led Development**", making Nari Shakti the driver of **Viksit Bharat @2047**.

India's Key Initiatives for Women-Led Development

- **Gender Budgeting:** Union Budget FY 2026-27 allocated **₹5.01 lakh crore** (**9.37%**) to advance women's equality and empowerment.
- **Women's Rights:** The 106th Constitutional Amendment reserves 33% seats in legislatures, complementing the **Triple Talaq ban** to ensure dignity.
- **Rural Empowerment:** DAY-NRLM mobilised **10 crore women** into SHGs and helped over 3 crore women in becoming "Lakhpati Didi".
- **Tech Integration:** NaMo Drone Didi Scheme provides 15,000 SHGs with agricultural drones with 80% subsidy to modernise rural livelihoods.
- **Financial Inclusion:** PM MUDRA allocated **68%** micro-loans to women, while Stand-Up India supported 2 lakh greenfield women entrepreneurs.
- **Education Support:** **Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana** mobilised **₹3.33 lakh crore** savings for girls' education.

Key Challenges to Women-Led Development

- ➢ **Care Burden:** Women spend **305 minutes daily on unpaid domestic work** (Time Use Survey 2024), limiting sustained participation in paid employment.
- ➢ **Labour Gap:** **Female LFPR is 41.7%** (PLFS 2023–24) versus 78.8% for men, reflecting persistent structural and workplace barriers.
- ➢ **Digital Divide:** Only **33.3% women aged 15-49** (NFHS-5) have ever used the internet, restricting access to digital finance and markets.
- ➢ **Political Gap:** Women hold **13.6% Lok Sabha seats** (2024), while the 106th Constitutional Amendment remains pending post-census delimitation.
- ➢ **Credit Constraint:** Women-owned MSMEs receive only **7.09% of outstanding MSME credit** (2023), due to limited collateral and asset ownership.

Way Forward for Women-Led Development

- ✓ **Care Support:** Expand **Palna Scheme** under **Mission Shakti** to provide accessible childcare and reduce unpaid care constraints on working women.
- ✓ **Employment Push:** Strengthen skilling and placement under **PMKVY** and **DAY-NRLM** to raise female labour force participation.
- ✓ **Digital Inclusion:** Bridge access gaps under the **Digital India Mission** to increase women's internet use.

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✓ **Credit Expansion:** Deepen **collateral-free lending** under **MUDRA** and **Stand-Up India** to improve women's share in MSME credit.

India's Key Achievements in Women's Empowerment

- **Grassroots Leadership:** Women now constitute **nearly 50%** of Panchayati Raj representatives.
- **Educational Development:** Female tertiary enrolment reached **2.18 crore** (GER 30.2) with women forming 53% of UGC NET-JRF scholars in STEM.
- **Maternal Health:** Schemes such as **Janani Suraksha Yojana** (JSY) and PMMVY reduced **India's Maternal Mortality Ratio** from **130** to **88**.
- **Financial & Skill Inclusion:** Women hold **56%** of PMJDY accounts and constitute **45%** of the beneficiaries of PMKVY training.
- **Leadership Milestone:** The first **women cadets** from the **National Defence Academy graduated** in 2025 alongside rising female leaders in ISRO research roles.

Read More > *Understanding Women's Empowerment & Its Evolution*

{Vulnerable Sections – Women} Nari Shakti Reforms in India

❖ **Context (TH):** India's approach to women's empowerment has evolved from a welfare-driven intent to structural transformation, placing women at the core of development policy.

Pillars of Nari Shakti Reform

- **Financial Inclusion:** Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana opened **57+ crore accounts**, **55%** of which are held by women, enabling access to formal banking.
- **SHG Revolution:** 10 crore women in **90 lakh Self-Help Groups**, boosting grassroots entrepreneurship and local economies.
- **Clean Energy:** PM Ujjwala Yojana reached **10.5+ crore households**, reducing health risks & drudgery.
- **Credit Access:** In PM MUDRA Yojana, **~70%** loans are granted to women, promoting small businesses and financial independence.
- **Workforce Participation:** Female Labour Force Participation **increased to ~37%,** reversing past decline.
- **Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam:** Provides **33%** reservation for women in Parliament and Assemblies.

Challenges in Nari Shakti Reform

➢ **Awareness Gap:** Limited awareness among women reduces enrolment and prevents full utilisation of government schemes.

➢ **Low Workforce Participation:** Female Labour Force Participation (**~37% –** PLFS) remains **below global averages**, indicating structural employment barriers.

➢ **Uneven Inclusion:** Marginalised and vulnerable women still face barriers in accessing benefits due to social and economic constraints.

➢ **Output vs Outcome Focus:** Policies often emphasise coverage rather than measuring real improvements in empowerment and quality of life.

➢ **Leadership Barriers:** Persistent patriarchal norms and low representation (currently, women hold only about **13.6%** of Lok Sabha seats) limit decision-making power and leadership roles.

Way Forward for Nari Shakti

✓ **Last-Mile Saturation:** Use the Aspirational Districts Programme (NITI Aayog) and DBT systems to ensure **100% coverage of eligible women** under key schemes.

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- ✓ **Capacity Building & Leadership:** Expand training via Mission Shakti and strengthen implementation of **Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam** to convert representation into effective governance.
- ✓ **Outcome-Based Monitoring:** Leverage dashboards like Poshan Tracker and Ayushman Bharat IT systems to shift from coverage to measurable outcomes (nutrition, health, income).
- ✓ **Financial & Digital Inclusion:** Deepen access through PMJDY + UPI + Aadhaar (**JAM Trinity**) to enhance credit, savings, and digital transactions for women-led enterprises.
- ✓ **Sectoral Participation:** Promote women in high-growth sectors via **Skill India**, **Digital India**, and **STEM initiatives** (India has ~43% women in STEM enrolment – AISHE).

{Vulnerable Sections – Children} Child Labour in India **

❖ **Context (IE):** A study based on judicial records from the **e-Courts platform** reveals 8 times more **child labour** cases than reported by NCRB (2015-2022).

Key Findings

- **Discrepancy in Data:** Number of cases filed under **Child & Adolescent Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986**, highlighting significant underreporting.
- **Issues with NCRB Data:** NCRB follows the **"Principal Offence Rule,"** recording only the most serious crime in cases involving multiple offenses. This often excludes child labour if coupled with graver crimes.

Statistics on Child Labour in India

- **Census 2001:** 1.26 crore working children **(aged 5-14)** out of a total child population of 25.2 crore.
- **Census 2011:** 10.1 million child labourers (aged 5-14), making up 3.9% of the total child population.

Challenges in Preventing Child Labour

- ➢ **Poverty:** Families depend on children's earnings for survival.
- ➢ **Limited Access to Education:** Poor infrastructure and school availability hinder learning opportunities.
- ➢ **Cultural Acceptance:** Child labour is normalised in several regions.
- ➢ **Lack of Awareness:** Employers and families often ignore legal provisions against child labour.
- ➢ **Economic Exploitation:** Demand for cheap labour in industries, eg- textiles, agriculture & construction.
- ➢ **Migration:** Migrant families push children into work due to instability and lack of schooling options.

Impact of Child Labour on Society

- **As per the International Labour Organization (ILO),** child labour deprives children of their childhood, dignity, and development, causing harm to their physical and mental well-being.
- **Hinders Economic Growth:** Lack of education results in unskilled workforce, slowing economic progress.
- **Perpetuates Intergenerational Cycle of Poverty** by preventing children from gaining the skills required for decent work, leading to reduced human capital accumulation.
- **Social Inequality:** Child labour disproportionately affects marginalised communities.
- **Violation of Child's FRs:** It deprives them of education, exposes them to hazardous working conditions, and denies them the right to enjoy their childhood.
- **Negative Impacts on Child Health:** Eg- In the mining industry, children are exposed to toxic substances and dangerous machinery, which can cause serious health problems.
- **Weakens Social Progress:** Hampers advancements in education, health, and quality of life.

Framework to Eradicate Child Labour

Constitutional Provisions

- **Article 21A:** Guarantees free and compulsory education for children of 6-14 yrs.

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- **Article 24:** Prohibits employment of children below 14 years in hazardous occupations.
- **Article 39(e):** Protects children from exploitation.
- **Article 39(f):** Ensures children's development with dignity and freedom.

Judicial Verdicts on Child Labour

- **M.C. Mehta v. State of Tamil Nadu (1996):** SC ordered the prohibition of child labour in hazardous industries and directed the government to rehabilitate affected children.
- **Bachpan Bachao Andolan v. Union of India (2011):** Emphasized stricter enforcement of child labour laws and directed states to rescue and rehabilitate child labourers.
- **People's Union for Democratic Rights v. Union of India (1982):** Employment of children in construction work violates fundamental rights.
- **Sanjit Roy v. State of Rajasthan (1983):** The Court ruled that child labour under exploitative conditions violates human dignity and constitutional rights.

Legislative Actions Against Child Labour

- **Child Labour (Prohibition & Regulation) Act, 1986:** Called Child & Adolescent Labour (Prohibition & Regulation) Act (CALPRA).
  - **Prohibits** child employment **below 14 years** in **all occupations**.
  - **Amendment (2016):** Extends protection to adolescents (14-18 years) in hazardous jobs.
  - **Punishment:** Employers hiring children face imprisonment (6 months - 2 years) and a fine (₹20,000 - ₹50,000); Repeat offenders face stricter penalties.
  - **Rehabilitation Fund:** Ensures financial assistance and education for rescued child labourers.
- **Factories Act, 1948:** It prohibits the employment of children below the age of 14 in factories.
- **The Mines Act, 1952:** It prohibits the employment of children below the age of 18 years in mines.
- **Right To Education Act, 2009:** It provides **free, compulsory** education to all children **aged 6 to 14**.

Policy Framework

- **Gurupadswamy Committee (1979):** Identified poverty as a major factor and recommended banning child labour in hazardous sectors while regulating non-hazardous industries.
- **National Policy on Child Labour (1987):** Focuses gradual elimination & rehabilitation of child workers.
- **National Child Labour Project (NCLP):** Provides education (also vocational) to rescued child labourers.
- **Mid-Day Meal Scheme:** This encourages school attendance by offering free meals.
- **Integrated Child Protection Scheme (ICPS):** Supports and rehabilitates children at risk of exploitation.

International Frameworks

- **ILO Conventions:** **Convention No. 138** sets minimum working age; Convention No. 182 calls for eliminating the worst forms of child labour.
- **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs): Target 8.7** aims to eradicate forced labour and child labour in all forms by 2025.
- **United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC)** sets out **children's** civil, political, economic, social, health and cultural **rights**.

{Vulnerable Sections – Children} AI in Parenting **

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❖ **Context (IE):** OpenAI CEO Sam Altman shared that he relies on ChatGPT for day-to-day infant care guidance, highlighting a wider trend of parents using AI tools for personalised advice.

Significance of AI in Parenting

- **Personalised Guidance:** AI **offers tailored responses** based on developmental variations.
- **Reduced Anxiety:** Quick, evidence-based answers lower stress in early parenting; E.g., a U.S. survey shows **62%** new parents use digital tools for infant queries.
- **Accessibility Boost:** Democratises expert knowledge for families lacking paediatric access; E.g., rural tele-consults in **India rose 30% post-COVID**.
- **Support New Parents:** Helps first-time parents navigate routines, feeding, sleep schedules; E.g., AI apps now used by **40% urban parents globally**.
- **Early Learning Tools:** AI-based storytelling and customised activities support cognitive development.

Concerns Associated with AI Parenting

➢ **Accuracy Gaps:** AI may offer generic or unsafe medical advice without context; E.g., MIT audit found 30% AI parenting answers lacked nuance.
➢ **Over-Reliance:** Parents risk substituting judgment with AI recommendations.
➢ **Privacy Risks:** Children's sensitive data is vulnerable to profiling; E.g., global studies show 70% of parenting apps track behaviour, breaching privacy.
➢ **Cultural Bias:** Algorithms may mirror Western parenting norms that are not aligned with Indian contexts.
➢ **Equity Divide:** Digital literacy gaps can worsen inequality in access to safe AI tools. E.g., UNESCO reports that **~2.6 billion people** worldwide lack internet access (2023).

Way Forward

✓ **Clear Standards:** EU AI Act guides child-safe AI governance frameworks.
✓ **Parental Oversight:** Co-use AI systems ensures human judgment remains primary.
✓ **Data Protection:** DPDP Act restricts profiling and protects minors' data.
✓ **Local Adaptation:** AI trained on Indian languages reduces cultural bias risks.
✓ **Medical Integration:** **Indian Academy of Paediatrics (IAP)** vetting ensures evidence-based paediatric AI recommendations.

{Vulnerable Sections – Children} Early Childhood Development & Human Capital *

❖ **Context (IE):** India's goal of **'Viksit Bharat' by 2047** hinges on Early Childhood Development (ECD) to enhance human capital and leverage its demographic dividend.

Why Early Childhood Development Matters

- **Brain Development:** Nearly 85% occurs before age **six**; early cognitive stimulation can improve learning outcomes by 25–30%. (World Bank)
- **Heckman Equation:** Investment in early childhood yields up to a **13% annual economic return** through higher future productivity.
- **Triple Dividend:** It improves child well-being, increases adult employment earnings, and breaks intergenerational poverty cycles.
- **Health Link:** Proper early nutrition prevents irreversible stunting and wasting, potentially increasing **adult earnings by 10–17%.** (World Bank)

India's ECD Landscape

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- **Nutrition Status:** NFHS-5 shows **35.5% of children under five are stunted**, **19.3% are wasted**, and **67.1%** face childhood **anaemia**.
- **Literacy Deficit:** ASER 2024 shows over **70% of Class 3 students cannot read Class 2 text**.
- **Dropout Crisis:** About 63% of five-year-olds leave Anganwadi centres, causing a developmental gap before primary school. (ASER 2024)

Challenges in India's ECD Ecosystem

- **Administrative Silos:** ECD governance is fragmented across multiple ministries (education, health, women and child development), causing inefficiencies.
- **Infrastructure Deficit:** Nearly 12 lakh Anganwadi Centres lack dedicated **pre-primary educators**, over-relying on workers with administrative and health duties.
- **Climate Vulnerability:** Rising heatwaves and extreme weather disproportionately threaten early childhood health and nutrition, particularly in rural areas.
- **Digital Divide:** Low-income households lack digital learning tools, widening early cognitive disparities with their urban and wealthier peers.
- **Public Spending:** India's public investment in ECD remains below the global GDP benchmark.

Way Forward

- ✓ **National Mission:** Scale the **Meghalaya ECD model** nationwide, integrating the First 1000 Days with local community-based health and nutrition tracking.
- ✓ **Infrastructure Funding:** Adopt the **Nand Ghar PPP model** to modernise Anganwadis and establish statutory financial support for uniform infrastructure.
- ✓ **Care Workforce:** Increase public spending to **1.5% of GDP** for Early Childhood Care and Education. Train specialised educators for Anganwadis to meet global standards.
- ✓ **Nutrition Mapping:** Combine Poshan Tracker data with education records to identify local malnutrition hotspots and offer targeted interventions like fortified milk and eggs.
- ✓ **Dropout Reduction:** Support sustained caregiving to reduce burden; adopt **Tamil Nadu's school breakfast model** to improve overall attendance rates.

Read More > Early Childhood Development for Inclusive Growth

{Vulnerable Sections – Elderly} Ageing Fiscal Challenge

- **Context (TH):** While India is often celebrated for its demographic dividend, its States are undergoing a significant but **uneven demographic transition** according to a new RBI **report**.

Uneven Demographic Transition Across States

- **Ageing South:** **Kerala** and **Tamil Nadu** face rising old-age dependency due to sustained fertility decline and longer life expectancy trends.
- **Youthful North:** Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and Jharkhand will continue seeing strong growth in working-age population beyond the 2031 period.
- **Middle Path States:** **Karnataka** and **Maharashtra** balance workforce expansion with emerging ageing pressures over the coming decades.

Financial Burden of India's Ageing Population

- **Rising Pension Costs:** In Kerala and Tamil Nadu, the elderly population is projected to cross **20–22% by 2036**, implying a sharp rise in pension and social security expenditure (RBI projections).

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- **Shrinking Revenue:** Population weightage in recent Finance Commission formulas accounts for **15–25% of devolution criteria**, benefiting high-population States at the cost of ageing southern States.
- **Delimitation Impact:** Southern States could lose up to **8–10 parliamentary seats** post-delimitation due to slower population growth, weakening fiscal bargaining power.
- **Healthcare Strain:** The elderly account for nearly 30–35% of total hospitalisation expenditure, despite forming a much smaller population share.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Geriatric Healthcare:** Build specialised elderly healthcare infrastructure across States; E.g., **Kerala's 'Vayomithram' project** providing free medical care and mobile health services for senior citizens.
- ✓ **Early Pension Building:** Expand contributory and non-contributory pension systems in youthful States before fertility decline; E.g., **National Pension System (**NPS**)** universalisation push.
- ✓ **Job Mass Creation:** Launch large-scale employment in emerging sectors like green energy and care economy; E.g., **Germany's renewable energy employment transition model**.
- ✓ **Social Pension Expansion:** Strengthen old-age income support for informal workforce retirees; E.g., **Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS)**.

{Vulnerable Sections – Elderly} Silver Economy *

❖ **Context (**FE**):** By 2050, **over 20% of India's population will be elderly**, straining healthcare due to high end-of-life costs and limited geriatric infrastructure, especially in rural areas.

⇨ ***Geriatric services*** *refer to healthcare and support* ***specifically designed for older adults****, focusing on their unique health needs and promoting their well-being.*

Key Challenges in Geriatric Healthcare in India

- ➢ **Urban-Rural Divide:** 70% of the elderly live in **rural areas**, but they **travel 28+ km** for care, compared to **10 km for urban elderly** (Lancet, 2024).
- ➢ **High Healthcare Costs:** India faced **14% medical inflation** in 2024, the highest in Asia, making chronic care unaffordable for many seniors.
- ➢ **Workforce Shortage:** Barely **200 geriatricians serve 120 million** elderly Indians, even as older adults account for 60% of ICU admissions, exposing a stark mismatch.
- ➢ **Public System Underfunding:** Health spending stagnates at **1.2–1.9% of GDP**, resulting in limited elderly-focused services and coverage.

Opportunities and Policy Innovations

- **Private Sector:** Private players are **expanding geriatric care** through preventive services, home care, and **telehealth.**
- **Public Schemes:** Ayushman Bharat-PMJAY now covers seniors above 70, **offering ₹5 lakh** in free annual care at public & private hospitals.
  - ❖ Schemes like National Programme for Prevention and Control of Cancer, Diabetes, CVDs and Stroke (NPCDCS)are helping manage the burden of NCDs.
- **Primary Healthcare:** Promotes home-based primary healthcare and mobility support through mobile medical vans, digital health platforms.

Way Forward

- ✓ Strengthen **Ayushman Arogya Mandirs** for integrated and accessible geriatric care.
- ✓ Increase Public Health Spending **beyond 2% of GDP** to build elderly-specific infrastructure.

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- ✓ Integrate Transport Services into healthcare systems to bridge rural-urban access gaps.
- ✓ Boosting investment in geriatrics as a medical specialisation is critical.

Read More > ***Senior Citizens in India***

{Vulnerable Sections – Transgenders} Transgender Equality

❖ **Context (IE):** The Supreme Court of India flagged **persistent discrimination** against transgender persons, directing the Centre and States to formulate a **comprehensive Equal Opportunity Policy**.

- The case arose from a plea by a transgender woman who was terminated from schools in **UP** and **Gujarat**, highlighting systemic exclusion despite the **Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019**.

⇨ ***NALSA v. Union of India (2014):*** *Landmark judgment recognising transgender persons as the "**third gender**" under **Articles 14, 15, 16,** and **21**, affirming their right to self-identification and equality.*

Key Directives of the Supreme Court

- **Advisory Committee Formation:** Headed by **Justice Asha Menon** (Retd.), tasked with drafting the policy and recommending institutional reforms within 6 months.
- **Institutional Mechanisms:** **Transgender Welfare Boards** in all States/UTs (as per 2020 Rules) and **Transgender Protection Cells** at district and state levels under DMs and DGPs.
- **Support Systems:** A nationwide toll-free helpline for reporting violations.

Challenges Faced by Transgenders

- ➢ **Low Workforce Participation:** **Only 6% of transgender** persons are in formal employment, and around **92% work in the informal sector**, often in begging or sex work (NHRC–NITI Aayog Report, 2021).
- ➢ **Education Gap:** **46%** of transgender children drop out before completing secondary school, and less than **2% reach higher education** (NHRC, 2022).
- ➢ **Healthcare Discrimination:** **Only 30% have access** to gender-affirming healthcare, and one in four reports denial of medical care in hospitals (Ministry of Social Justice data, 2023).
- ➢ **Policy Implementation Deficit:** **Only 11 States** have notified Transgender Welfare Boards & welfare allocation per transgender individual remains below ₹1,000 annually in most States (CAG Report, 2023).

Way Forward

- ✓ **Policy Integration:** "**Trans-Inclusive Governance**" like the **UK's Equality Act, 2010,** which mandates non-discrimination across employment & public services.
- ✓ **Education & Skill Development:** Integrate gender diversity in teacher training & Skill India Mission.
- ✓ **Economic Empowerment:** Extend PM Vishwakarma Yojana & PMEGP benefits to transgender entrepreneurs via targeted sub-quotas.
- ✓ **Data & Accountability:** Include transgender indicators in the **National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6)** & **Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS)** for evidence-based policymaking.

Read More > ***Transgenders in India*** **|** ***Government Initiatives for Transgender Empowerment***

{Vulnerable Sections – Labour} Workers' Protest in Noida **

❖ **Context (TH | IE | TH):** Large-scale **workers' protests in Noida** over wage hikes turned violent, involving arson, stone-pelting, and clashes with police.

- **Industrial Spread:** Protests were reported across Noida and Greater Noida industrial hubs, affecting traffic and factory operations.

Workers' Grievances & Issues

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- **Wage Insecurity:** Workers face **low and stagnant wages** (₹11–₹13,000/month) that fail to keep pace with inflation and rising living costs.
- **High informalisation:** Over **90% of India's workforce** is informal (ILO), lacking contracts & protections.
- **Poor Working Conditions:** Long working hours, unsafe workplaces, and a lack of occupational safety measures remain widespread.
- **Weak Social Security:** **Limited access to benefits** like provident fund, insurance, and healthcare exposes workers to vulnerabilities.
- **Implementation Gaps:** Labour laws & codes are poorly enforced, leading to denial of statutory rights.
- **Lack of Representation:** **Declining unionisation** and limited collective bargaining reduce workers' ability to negotiate fair conditions.

Government Response

- **High-Level Committee:** The UP government constituted a multi-stakeholder committee to investigate the unrest and facilitate dialogue between workers and employers.
- **Wage Revision:** The state government announced an increase in minimum wages to address workers' core demands.
- **Stakeholder Consultation:** Authorities engaged with labour unions and industrial associations.

⇨ ***Minimum wage*** *is the* ***legally mandated lowest remuneration*** *that employers must pay workers.*
⇨ ***Minimum wages*** *in India are* ***legally enforceable*** *under the Code on Wages, 2019.*

Measures to Strengthen Labour Welfare

- ✓ **Wage Framework:** Ensure timely revision and strict enforcement of minimum wages under the Code on Wages, 2019, to address income insecurity.
- ✓ **Formalisation:** Promote formal employment through incentives, digital registration (e-Shram), and compliance mechanisms for MSMEs.
- ✓ **Social Security:** Expand coverage of schemes like ESI, EPF, & pensions to include informal & gig workers.
- ✓ **Improve Law Enforcement:** Strengthen inspection systems using technology and data-driven monitoring to curb violations.
- ✓ **Collective Bargaining:** Encourage institutional dialogue platforms between workers, employers, and government.
- ✓ **Grievance Redressal:** Set up **fast-track labour dispute resolution systems** and revive **tripartite dialogue** (govt–employer–workers).
- ✓ **Skill Development:** Invest in skilling, reskilling, and upskilling to improve wages, employability, and industrial competitiveness.

Government Initiatives & Schemes for Unorganised Workers

- **e-Shram Portal:** National database of unorganised workers providing a **UAN card** to access multiple welfare schemes and benefits.
- **PM Shram Yogi Maandhan (PM-SYM):** Provides **₹3,000/month pension** after age 60 with equal contribution by government and worker.
- **Labour Codes Reform:** The **four labour codes** aim to simplify and modernise labour laws while ensuring wage security and social protection.
- **Skill India Mission:** Enhances the employability of workers **through skill development** and vocational training programmes.
- **One Nation One Ration Card:** Ensures **food security portability** for migrant workers across states.

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{Vulnerable Sections – Labour} Rehabilitation of Bonded Labour

❖ **Context (TH):** Millions of migrant labourers in India are **forced into bonded labour**, facing exploitation and harsh conditions.

Understanding Bonded Labour in India

- **Meaning:** Bonded labour refers to a situation where a person is compelled to work to repay a debt or fulfil an obligation, often under coercive conditions.

Legal Framework

- **Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act, 1976:** **Abolished bonded labour**, cancelled debts, mandated release, and provided rehabilitation.
- **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Section 143:** Penalises **forced labour** and **human trafficking**, complementing the BLSA.
- **Juvenile Justice Act & SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act:** Provide additional protection for children and marginalised communities.

Slip Back into Bondage Despite Legal Abolition

- **Rehabilitation Delay:** Hundreds of rescued labourers in Odisha waited months for financial aid under the 1976 Act, forcing them back into exploitative work.
- **Unrehabilitated Numbers:** SECC-2011 recorded **8,304 bonded labourers** rescued in **Odisha**, yet the State never reported follow-up rehabilitation actions.
- **Slow Rescue:** In 2023–24, **only 155 bonded labourers** were rescued in Odisha, reflecting weak identification and monitoring mechanisms.
- **Data Gaps:** Nationally, **1.65 lakh bonded labourers** were **legally freed**, but outdated surveys like SECC-2011 hinder long-term tracking and support.

Rehabilitation and Implementation Gap

➢ **Assistance Delay:** Financial aid and livelihood support often take months or years, forcing rescued labourers back into exploitation.
➢ **Coordination Gap:** Weak inter-departmental coordination among Labour, Revenue, Panchayati Raj, and Police hampers effective rehabilitation.
➢ **Short-Term:** **One-time relief** without education, skills training, or social security fails to ensure long-term stability.
➢ **Successful Model:** Odisha's 2010–2015 program **rehabilitated 1,200 bonded labourers** via integrated welfare schemes, showing the value of sustained support.

Measures to Strengthen Rehabilitation

✓ **Data Monitoring:** Update **bonded labour surveys** and maintain real-time databases to track rehabilitation outcomes.
✓ **Financial Assistance:** Immediate relief and graded rehabilitation must be disbursed without bureaucratic delays.
✓ **Livelihood Promotion:** Skills training, employment guarantees, and inclusion in anti-poverty schemes can reduce forced migration.

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- ✓ **Social Reform:** **Caste-based bondage** requires social reform, awareness campaigns, and legal enforcement to prevent hereditary exploitation.
- ✓ **Accountability Enforcement:** Clear roles, standard operating procedures, and inter-departmental coordination are essential for effective implementation.

{Women, Children & Vulnerable Sections – Pathfinder for Mains}

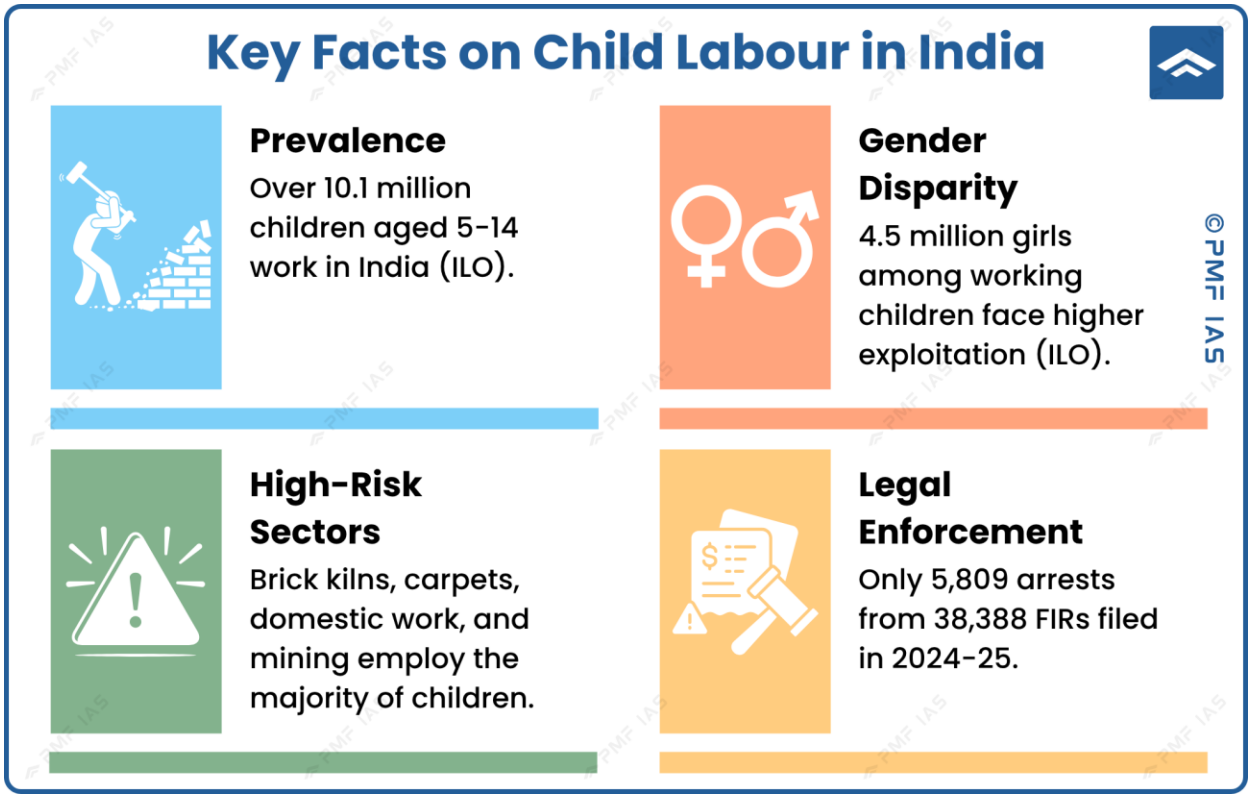
Q. Despite the Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986, and the Right to Education Act, 2009, child labour persists in India. Analyse the socio-economic factors responsible and suggest policy measures to eradicate them. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about child labour in India and mention current data.
- **Body:** Analyse socio-economic factors responsible for child labour in India & suggest policy measures.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a multi-pronged approach to provide a dignified life to children.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- The Child Labour Act (1986) and the RTE Act (2009) have not prevented **over 10 million Indian children (5–14 years)** from working in hazardous conditions. Poverty, weak enforcement, and inadequate education perpetuate this exploitation.



Socio-Economic Factors

- **Poverty Trap:** Over 53,000 children rescued in 2024–25 were from families relying on child income.
- **School Gaps:** **90%** of rescued children aged 10–14 were out of school.

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- **Informal Work:** Millions of children are employed in unregulated sectors (brick kilns & carpet weaving).
- **Child Trafficking:** Migrant children are highly vulnerable to trafficking and bonded labour.

Policy Measures for its Eradication

- ✓ **Legal Action:** Need more vigorous enforcement. E.g., only 5,809 arrests from 38,388 FIRs in 2024–25.
- ✓ **Promote Education:** Ensure free education up to 18 years and offer **bridge courses** and vocational training for adolescents.
- ✓ **Economic Aid:** NCLP meals and scholarships support over 53,000 rescued children.

Conclusion

- Eradicating child labour requires strong laws, education, and economic support for vulnerable children. Child labour steals childhoods; let's give them back with dignity and compassion.

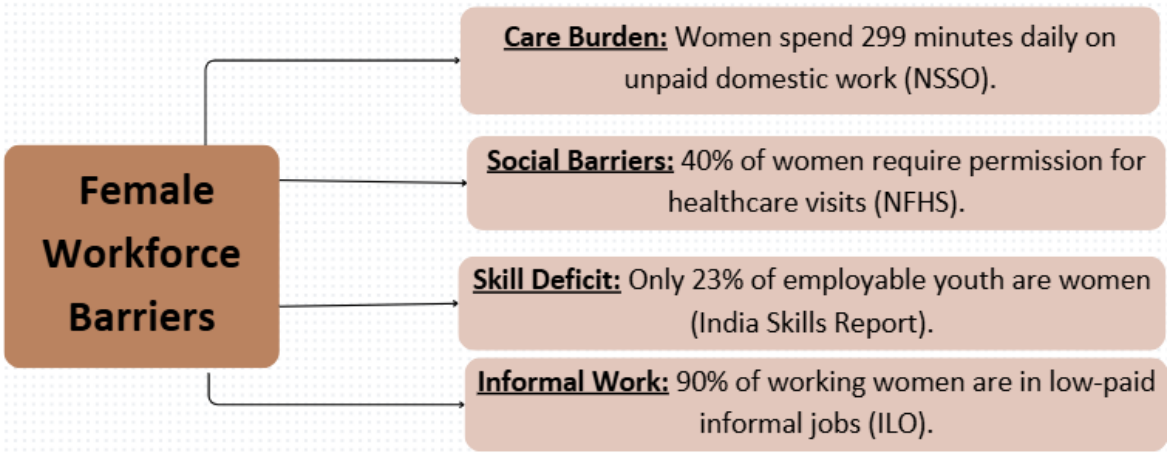
Q. To what extent does women's unpaid care burden restrict women's participation in India's labour force, and how can a robust care ecosystem promote gender equality? Discuss (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction by mentioning the current facts.
- **Body:** Write how women's unpaid care burden restricts women's participation, and a robust care ecosystem can promote gender equality.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a multi-pronged care ecosystem to increase women's participation in India's labour force.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- India's low female labour force participation rate (FLFPR) at 37% is driven by the unequal unpaid care duties that women shoulder.



Women's Unpaid Care Burden Restricts Women's Participation

- **Time Constraint:** Women spend **299 mins/day** on unpaid care vs **men's 97,** reducing work hours (NSO).
- **Skill Gap:** Care duties limit women's access to education and vocational training.
- **Informal Work: 90% of women work** in low-paid informal jobs while managing care (ILO).
- **Mobility Restriction:** Social norms and caregiving reduce workforce participation, despite Anganwadi and creches' support.

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Robust Care Ecosystem Can Promote Gender Equality

- **Reduced Burden:** Anganwadis & crèches free women from unpaid care, raising workforce participation.
- **Economic Gain:** **Skilling 4.2 million** caregivers ensures paid, secure employment (ILO).
- **Work-Life Balance:** Parental leave and flexible work boost **FLFPR 37%** (2022-23).
- **Recognition:** Valuing care work reduces gender inequality and enhances societal status.

Conclusion

- A multi-pronged care ecosystem policy, infrastructure, skilling, and reforms reduce women's unpaid care, boosting workforce participation, gender equality, and India's economic growth.

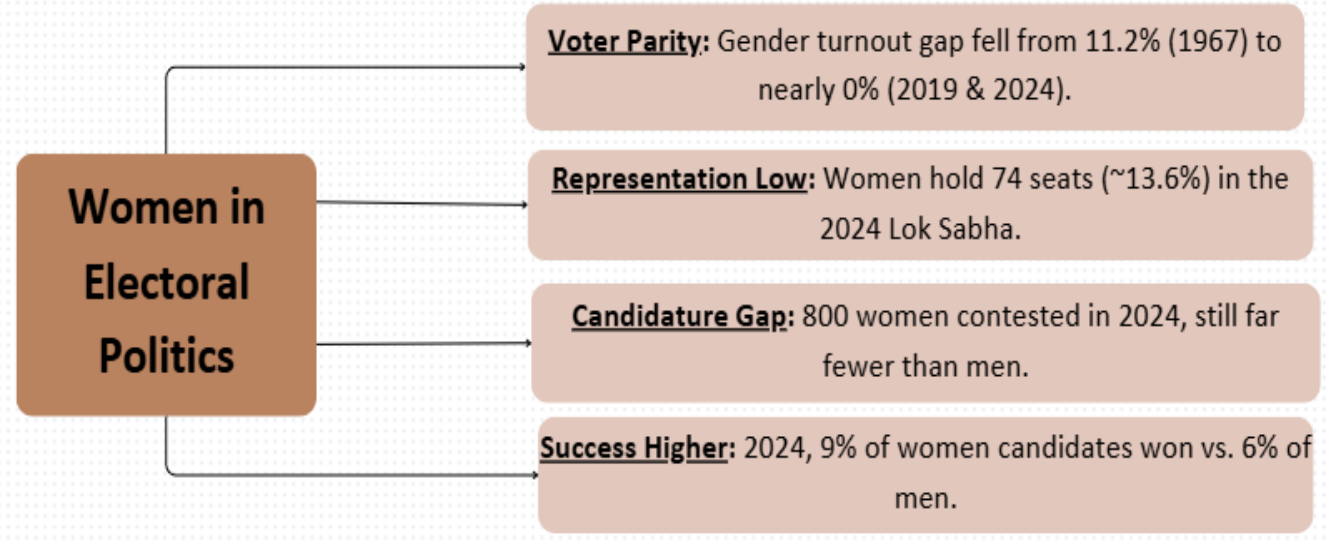
Q. Substantive gender representation is essential for deepening democratic governance and inclusive policy outcomes. Discuss the significance of enhancing women's representation in political institutions in India and suggest measures to strengthen their participation in decision-making processes. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the substantive gender representation in politics.
- **Body:** Write the significance of enhancing women's representation in political institutions in India, mention key challenges, & suggest measures to strengthen their participation in decision-making processes.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a "whole-of-government" and "whole-of-society" approach to strengthen women's participation in decision-making processes.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- **Substantive gender representation** means women not only occupy political offices but also actively shape policies and decisions, strengthening democratic legitimacy, accountability, gender equality, and inclusive development outcomes.



Significance of Enhancing Women's Representation

- **Democratic Legitimacy:** Women are **~48%** of voters but only **74 MPs (13.6%)** in the 2024 Lok Sabha, revealing a major representation gap.

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- **Social Inclusion:** Women's presence raises issues like gender violence, child marriage, and wage gaps, bringing marginalised concerns into policy debates.
- **Leadership Base:** About **14.5 lakh women** (**~46%**) in PRIs create a strong grassroots pipeline for future state and national leadership.

Challenges to Political Empowerment

- **Patriarchal Norms:** About **22% of women** say social norms discourage them from entering politics (Lokniti–CSDS Survey).
- **Domestic Burden:** Around **13% of women** report that household and caregiving duties limit their ability to participate in political activities.
- **Family Control:** Many women need family approval to rally or campaign. E.g., only 50% voted independently in 2024.
- **Low Representation:** Only **800** women contested, and **74 women (13.6%)** were elected to the Lok Sabha in 2024.

Measures to Strengthen Women's Participation

- ✓ **Quota Implementation:** Operationalise 33% reservation under the Constitution (One Hundred and Sixth Amendment) Act, 2023 and consider expanding quotas in legislatures.
- ✓ **Party Reforms:** Mandate minimum ticket allocation for women and provide financial and organisational backing within political parties.
- ✓ **Leadership Training:** Expand initiatives like **Sashakt Panchayat Netri Abhiyan** to strengthen governance and leadership skills.
- ✓ **Norm Change:** Run awareness campaigns to challenge patriarchal attitudes and gender stereotypes restricting women's political roles.

Conclusion

- **"True empowerment lies in moving women 'from ballots to power'."** Strengthening reforms, leadership capacity, and social support can transform women voters into decision-makers, deepening inclusive democratic governance.

Q. Examine the key challenges that the transgender community in India faces and propose effective measures for their meaningful inclusion and empowerment. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about the current status of transgender community by mentioning the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019.
- **Body:** Examine the challenges faced by the transgender community and write effective measures such as skills, a trans-friendly healthcare system, and sensitisation.
- **Conclusion:** Write a comprehensive conclusion about empowering the transgender community.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- The **Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019**, guarantees legal recognition, protection against discrimination, and rights to healthcare and education. However, India's transgender population of **4.88 lakh** (Census 2011) continues to face deep-seated exclusion, inequality, and social stigma.

Challenges Faced by Transgender Community

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- **Social Barriers:** According to the NHRC, **over 60%** of transgender individuals faced public abuse and harassment, reflecting deep-rooted stigma.
- **Educational Exclusion:** According to the *National Human Rights Survey*, **over 50%** of transgender students **dropped out of school** due to bullying and non-inclusive educational environments
- **Economic Marginalisation:** 90% of transgender individuals rely on informal livelihoods such as begging or sex work.
- **Healthcare Disparities:** Most healthcare professionals lack sensitisation, and gender-affirming treatments are often unavailable or unaffordable.
- **Political Exclusion:** Despite being recognised as a "***third gender***", representation in political decision-making remains negligible.

Effective Measures for Their Meaningful Inclusion and Empowerment

- ✓ **Launch Inclusive Education & Skill Development:** Design programs that equip transgender individuals with **market-relevant skills** and **inclusive learning** environments.
- ✓ **Strengthen Enforcement of Anti-Discrimination Laws:** Ensure strict implementation of **legal protections** across schools, workplaces, and public institutions.
- ✓ **Build Trans-Friendly Healthcare Systems:** Establish accessible healthcare services and extend insurance coverage to include **gender-affirming procedures**.
- ✓ **Scale Up Economic Empowerment Schemes:** Expand successful models like Kerala's Transgender Entrepreneurship Program to other states.
- ✓ **Run Nationwide Sensitisation Campaigns:** Promote media and community-based initiatives to challenge stereotypes and foster social acceptance.

Conclusion

- Empowering India's transgender community is not merely a policy imperative; it is a constitutional mandate under **Articles 14**, **19**, and **21**. A future based on dignity, equality, and fraternity demands inclusive reforms, institutional empathy, and active societal participation.

Q. Bonded labour is not just a labour issue but a reflection of social injustice, poverty, and systemic failure." Examine this statement in the Indian context. Suggest a multi-pronged approach to eliminate bonded labour. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about bonded labour and mention structural issues.
- **Body:** Examine bonded labour as a reflection of social injustice, poverty, and systemic failure, and propose a multi-faceted approach to eliminate bonded labour.
- **Conclusion:** Highlights the importance of a bonded labour-free society with the help of Gandhiji's quote.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Bonded labour continues despite 1976 abolition, driven by poverty, caste inequality, debt traps, and weak enforcement of laws.

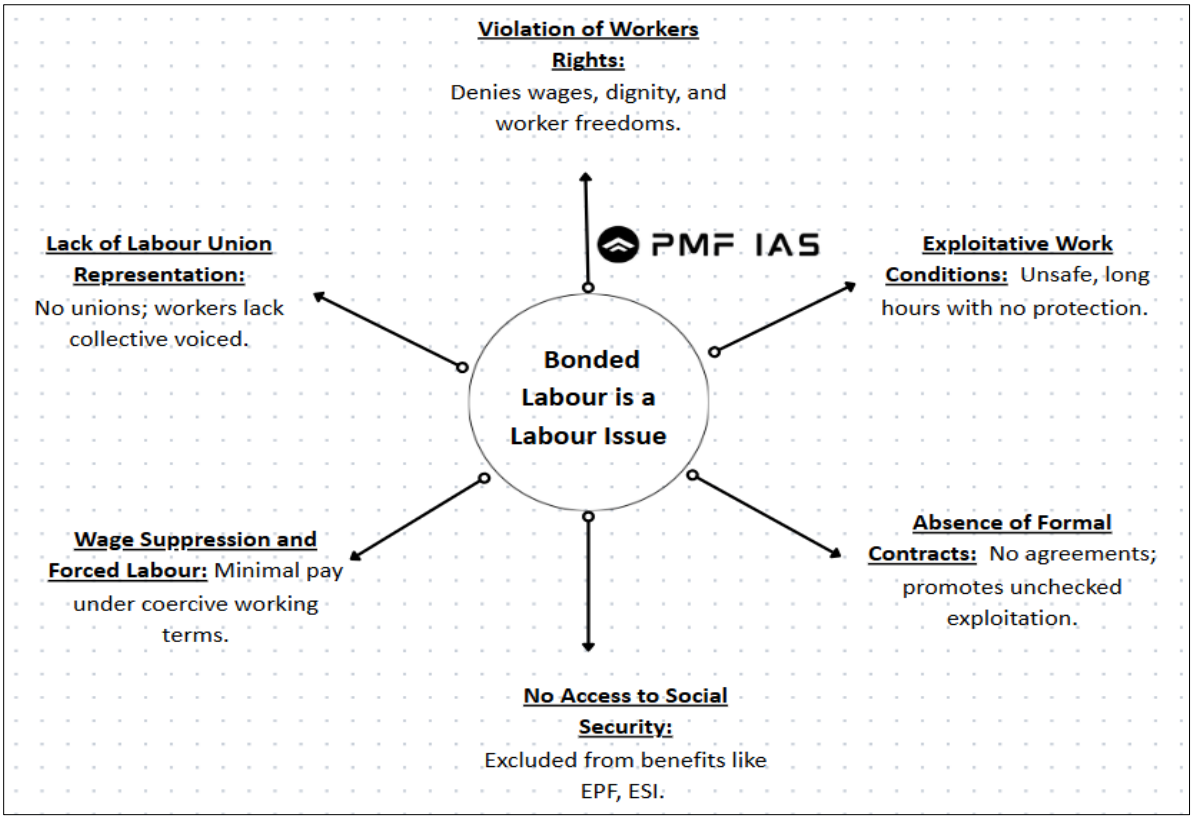
Bonded Labour as a Reflection of Social Injustice, Poverty, and Systemic Failure.

- **Caste and Social Injustice:** **Dalits** and **Adivasis** remain most affected. E.g., exploitation of Dalit workers in brick kilns across Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.
- **Poverty and Debt Dependence:** 60% of bonded labourers from BPL families lack formal credit. (ILO)

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- **Legal Unawareness and Exploitation:** Only 19% of rescued labourers knew their rights. (Ministry of Labour data).
- **Weak Enforcement and Rehabilitation:** Despite **over 3 lakh bonded labourers** being identified since 1976, less than 50% have received full rehabilitation (as per the 2024 parliamentary reply).



Multi-Pronged Approach to Eliminate Bonded Labour

- ✓ **Strengthen Enforcement and Vigilance:** Ensure **strict implementation** of labour and anti-discrimination laws with active vigilance committees involving civil society.
- ✓ **Promote Socio-Economic Upliftment:** Scale up livelihood schemes like **MGNREGA** and improve access to land, housing, health, and education for the vulnerable.
- ✓ **Enhance Access to Formal Credit:** Expand microfinance, **Jan Dhan coverage**, and regulate informal lending to break debt cycles.
- ✓ **Ensure Effective Rehabilitation:** Provide timely release, vocational training, and psychosocial support under the Central Sector Scheme for rescued labourers.

Conclusion

- Bonded labour shames a nation striving for inclusive growth, as true freedom remains elusive while even one person remains in bondage. As **Gandhiji** urged, society must be judged by how it treats its weakest, and justice demands a holistic, root-cause approach.

------- End of Chapter --------

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Health, Nutrition, Education & Human Capital

{Social Sector – Nutrition} Hidden Hunger in India

❖ **Context (TS):** Millions of children and adults in India endure severe undernutrition and hidden hunger, highlighting a persistent and deeply rooted national crisis.

- **Hidden hunger**, or **micronutrient deficiency**, is a form of **undernutrition** in which a person does not receive enough essential vitamins and minerals despite adequate calorie intake.

India's Hidden Hunger Landscape

- **National Burden:** India hosts **one quarter** of the world's hungry population, with over **190 million undernourished** and nearly half of the global burden of wasting.
- **Child Undernutrition:** About **35.5%** of children **under five** are **stunted** (low height for age), and **18.7%** are **wasted** (low weight for height).
- **Adolescent Deficits:** Around **24%** of Indian adolescents remain **thin** (below healthy body mass), and nearly **80%** face multiple micronutrient deficiencies.
- **Gender Impact:** Women and children are disproportionately impacted. According to **NFHS-5**, **57%** of **women** and **67%** of children aged 6-59 months are anaemic.
- **State Hotspot:** **Gujarat**, **Jharkhand**, and **Bihar** record significantly higher malnutrition levels than the national average.

⇨ *In the **Global Hunger Index** (GHI) **2025**, India ranked **102nd out of 123 countries** and received a score of **25.8**, placing it in the **"serious"** hunger category.*

Consequences of Hidden Hunger

- **Intergenerational Cycle:** Maternal malnutrition raises the risk of **low-birth-weight babies** and initiates a cycle of nutritional deficiencies across generations.
- **Early Damage:** Micronutrient deficiencies in the **first 1,000 days** cause permanent losses in physical growth and permanently limit cognitive development.
- **Productivity Loss:** Weakness, fatigue, and frequent illnesses can reduce an adult's work capacity. India loses about **4% of its GDP** due to micronutrient malnutrition.
- **Dividend Threat:** Hidden hunger weakens the health, learning, and skills of youth, and **lowers the productive potential** of India's demographic dividend.
- **Health Burden:** Weakened immunity increases infection risks and leads to higher hospitalisations, which in turn raise household and public healthcare costs.

Government Initiatives Addressing Hidden Hunger

- **Mission POSHAN 2.0: Saksham Anganwadi** and **POSHAN 2.0** improve nutrition for children and mothers through upgraded Anganwadi services and real-time monitoring.
- **Pradhan Mantri Poshan Shakti Nirman (PM Poshan):** Provides hot cooked meals and fortified rice to schoolchildren and supports better attendance and daily nutrition.
- **Food Fortification:** Mandatory fortification of rice, edible oil, and salt adds iron, folic acid, and essential vitamins to widely consumed staples.

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- **Anaemia Mukt Bharat (AMB):** Supplies iron-folic acid tablets and conducts regular deworming and strengthens awareness to reduce anaemia prevalence.
- **Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY):** Offers conditional cash transfers to pregnant and lactating women to support nutrition and compensate for partial wage loss.
- Eat Right India: Promotes safe food practices and encourages balanced diets through nationwide **FSSAI-led outreach**.

Challenges of Hidden Hunger in India

- **Dietary Diversity Gap:** Food security programs remain **cereal-centric**, limiting intake of protein, fruits, vegetables, and micronutrients.
- **High Anaemia Burden:** NFHS-5 reports **57% of women** & **67% of children** (6–59 months) are anaemic.
- **Regional Inequalities:** States such as **Bihar, Jharkhand, and Gujarat** continue to have malnutrition rates above the national average.
- **Poor Awareness:** Limited nutrition literacy and unhealthy dietary practices hinder effective utilisation of available nutrition interventions.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Diversified Nutrition:** Promote **millets, pulses, eggs, fruits, and vegetables** through PDS, PM Poshan, and ICDS schemes.
- ✓ **Targeted Supplementation:** Strengthen iron-folic acid, vitamin A, and deworming programs for children, adolescents, and women.
- ✓ **Fortification Expansion:** Ensure universal access to fortified rice, edible oil, and salt through food security and welfare programs.
- ✓ **Behavioural Change:** Scale up **POSHAN Abhiyaan's Jan Andolan approach** to improve nutrition awareness, breastfeeding, and dietary practices.

Read More> *Malnutrition in India*

{Social Sector – Nutrition} India's Need for Nutritional Transformation **

❖ **Context (TH):** India's food policy is evolving from food security to nutritional security, with growing emphasis on functional foods and smart proteins to meet health, economic, and sustainability goals.

Functional Foods and Smart Proteins

- **Functional Foods:** Nutrient-enriched foods that promote health. E.g., Bio-fortified crops like zinc rice (IIRR Hyderabad) and iron pearl millet (ICRISAT) developed under ICAR programmes.
- **Smart Proteins:** Bio-manufactured proteins that reduce livestock dependence, including plant-based, fermentation-derived, and cultivated meat proteins. E.g., Startups like GoodDot and Blue Tribe Foods are pioneering plant-based alternatives; **Zydus LifeSciences** entered fermentation-based protein R&D.

Why India Needs Nutritional Transformation?

- **Persistent Malnutrition:** Around **35.5% of children** are stunted and **19% wasted** (NFHS-5, 2021), showing that food quantity does not ensure nourishment.
- **Protein Deficit:** Average protein intake at **~47 g/day** is below the FAO-recommended **60 g/day**, contributing to poor muscle mass and fatigue.
- **Urban-Rural Gap:** Urban households consume **25–30%** more protein than rural ones (NITI Aayog, 2023).

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- **Rising Non-Communicable Diseases:** India has **77 million diabetics** and **25 million obese adults** (IDF 2023, WHO 2024), demanding nutrition-dense, low-sugar diets.
- **Environmental Pressure:** Agriculture contributes **18–20%** of India's GHG emissions (FAO 2022); shifting **Economic Opportunity:** The global alternative-protein market, projected at **$240 billion by 2030**, can generate jobs in India's bio-manufacturing sector.

Challenges in India's Nutritional Shift

- **Regulatory Vacuum:** FSSAI has no defined standards for cultivated meat or fermentation-based foods.
- **Public Perception: Only 28%** of Indians trust lab-made foods, limiting adoption (NCAER 2024).
- **Infrastructure Deficit:** India has fewer than 15 large-scale fermentation plants (DBT 2024), constraining protein manufacturing capacity. The EU Farm-to-Fork Strategy funds >100 pilot bio-s.
- **Cost Accessibility:** Functional foods cost **20–30% more** than conventional staples (NCAER 2024). E.g. A fortified rice pack costs **₹50/kg versus ₹38/kg** for regular rice.
- **Skill Gaps: Less than 10%** of food-science graduates specialise in nutritional biotechnology (AICTE 2023).

Way Forward

- ✓ **National Nutrition Innovation Policy:** Formulate an inter-ministerial policy integrating DBT, MoHFW, and FSSAI. E.g., **Japan's FOSHU Model** ensures pre-market validation and consumer safety.
- ✓ **FSSAI Regulatory Framework:** Establish clear definitions, safety tests, and labelling norms for smart proteins and bio-fortified foods. E.g., **Singapore's Novel Foods Safety Protocol (2020)**.
- ✓ **Public–Private Collaboration:** Foster partnerships under **BIRAC** and **NITI Aayog** for R&D infrastructure. E.g. **India's BioE^3 incubators** can replicate the EU's BioManufacturing Valley concept.
- ✓ **Consumer Awareness Campaigns:** Promote acceptance of new food technologies through **Eat Right India** and school nutrition education.
- ✓ **Farmer Inclusion:** Integrate small farmers into bio-fortified crop value chains with MSP incentives and assured procurement. E.g., **ICRISAT's model** of community millet fortification networks in Maharashtra.
- ✓ **R&D and Skill Development:** Introduce **nutritional biotechnology** courses in agricultural and food institutes to build human capital. E.g., **China's National Innovation Centre** for Smart Food.

Read More> *The Need for Food Literacy*

{Social Sector – Health} Childhood Obesity Crisis in India **

❖ **Context (IE):** The World Obesity Atlas 2026 highlights **rising global trends in childhood obesity** and India's rapidly increasing burden.

Global Childhood Obesity Trends

- **Prevalence:** Childhood overweight and obesity now affect **20.7% of children worldwide**, rising sharply from **14.6%** in **2010**.
- **Geographic Shift:** The obesity epidemic mainly affects low- and middle-income countries, led by China, India, and the US.
- **Weight Transition:** Children with obesity have surpassed underweight children globally for the first time.
- **Future Projections:** About **227 million children** will live with obesity, and **507 million** will be overweight or obese by **2040**.

India's Childhood Obesity Burden

- **Rank:** India is now **second globally** in the number of children living with overweight and obesity.

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- **Age Pattern:** **Children aged 5–9 make up 36%** of India's overweight or obese population, while adolescents **aged 10–19 account for 64%**.
- **Regional Share:** India leads the WHO **South-East Asia Region** with **over 45 million** individuals aged 0–19 living with overweight or obesity.
- **Growth Rate:** India reports one of the fastest rises in childhood obesity globally, with an average annual increase of nearly 5%.

Structural Drivers of Childhood Obesity

- **Physical Inactivity:** About **74% of Indian adolescents** fail to meet the WHO physical activity guidelines due to sedentary lifestyles.
- **Dietary Pattern:** Children consume more ultra-processed foods and sugary drinks, increasing daily calories and obesity risk.
- **Nutrition Gap:** Only 35.5% of school children receive regulated meals; 32.6% of infants get sub-optimal breastfeeding, weakening early metabolic protection.
- **Maternal Factors:** High BMI and **Type 2 diabetes** in women of reproductive age elevate the risk of obesity in their children.

Future Burden and Implications for India

- **Future Burden:** India may have **56 million children** with **high BMI by 2040**, including 20 million children living with obesity.
- **Rising NCDs:** By 2040, BMI-related hypertension could **impact 4.21 million children**, while hyperglycaemia might affect 1.91 million children.
- **Economic Burden:** Obesity-related diseases may **cost over 3% of the global GDP by 2060**, risking India's fiscal stability.
- **Demographic Risk:** Early diabetes and cardiovascular disease in youth threaten India's future workforce productivity and demographic dividend.

Way Forward for India's Childhood Obesity Burden

- ✓ **Taxation Overhaul:** Implement progressive taxation on ultra-processed foods and high-sugar beverages to deter consumption and fund paediatric health initiatives.
- ✓ **Curriculum Integration:** Mandate daily, structured physical education modules across all school boards to reverse rising sedentary lifestyles.
- ✓ **Maternal Intervention:** **Empower Anganwadi networks to monitor maternal BMI and promote exclusive breastfeeding, ensur**ing early childhood metabolic protection.
- ✓ **Advertising Restrictions:** Enact stringent statutory bans on the targeted digital and broadcast marketing of high-calorie junk foods appealing to minors.

Read More > *Obesity in India*

{Social Sector – Health} Mental Healthcare in India **

- **Context (**TH**)**: WHO reports more than **$1 trillion in global productivity loss** annually due to untreated mental health issues.

What is Mental Health?

- According to the WHO, mental health is defined as well-being, enabling individuals to realise their potential, cope with stress, work productively, and contribute to the community.
- **Scope:** Includes conditions like anxiety, depression, bipolar disorder & schizophrenia.

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Mental Healthcare in India: Statistics

- WHO estimates that the burden of mental health problems in India is **2443 disability-adjusted life years (DALYs)** per **10000 population.**
- **15%** of India's adult population experiences mental health issues. Urban areas have a higher prevalence (13.5%) compared to rural (6.9%).
- **Lifetime prevalence** of mental disorders in India is **13.7%.**

⇨ *Disability-Adjusted Life Year (DALY) is a **time-based measure** of the **burden of disease**, combining years of life lost due to premature mortality (YLLs) and years of life lost due to disability (YLDs). One DALY represents the **loss of one year of full health**.*

Impact of Poor Mental Health

- **Productivity Impact:** Depression and anxiety cause **12 billion lost workdays annually (WHO)**.
- **Social Well-being:** **1 in 8 people globally** suffer from mental disorders (WHO).
- **Economic Loss:** Mental illness costs **USD 1.03 trillion globally (2012–2030)**.

Challenges in Addressing Mental Well-Being

- **Treatment Gap:** **70–92% treatment gap** due to stigma and limited services.
- **Professional Shortage:** India has **0.75 psychiatrists per 1 lakh population**.
- **Stigma Barrier:** Social taboos prevent early mental health care seeking.
- **Insurance Gap:** Mental health coverage is underutilised despite inclusion in insurance.
- **Urban Concentration:** Mental health services are largely concentrated in urban areas.

Initiatives for Mental Well-being

Government Initiatives

- Mental Healthcare Act, 2017**:** Ensures equal legal status for mental and physical health, mandating insurance coverage and rights-based treatment for mental illnesses.
- **National Mental Health Programme (1982) & District Mental Health Programme (1996):** Aims to provide accessible, affordable mental healthcare via community-based services and awareness.
- Tele MANAS**:** A nationwide tele-mental health initiative offering 24x7 digital counselling and support, especially for underserved and remote regions.
- **National Suicide Prevention Strategy (2022):** Aims to reduce suicide rates through public awareness, destigmatisation, early detection, and intervention mechanisms.

International Initiatives

- **Mental Health Action Plan (2013–2030):** Provides a global roadmap to strengthen governance, expand access, and integrate mental health into primary healthcare.
- **World Mental Health Report 2025:** Urges countries to reform outdated policies, combat stigma, and shift focus toward community-based and rights-oriented care.
- **Global Development Priority:** Recognises mental health as essential for achieving SDGs, especially those related to education, poverty alleviation, and gender equality.

Way Forward

✓ **Expand Insurance Access:** Full compliance with MHCA, promote affordable, inclusive coverage.
✓ **Public Awareness:** Mass campaigns to normalise mental health treatment.
✓ **Digital Expansion:** Leverage platforms like Tele MANAS and app-based therapy for wide reach.
✓ **Policy Enforcement:** Stronger IRDAI monitoring to ensure coverage and transparency.

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✓ **Employer Role:** Mandate workplace-based mental health support under group insurance.

Read Also> ***Mental Health in India***

{Social Sector – Health} Palliative Care

❖ **Context (TH):** In India, millions endure unnecessary suffering, making it imperative to integrate palliative care into its healthcare system.

What is Palliative Care?

- Meaning: Palliative care is a form of specialised care that addresses a person's physical, emotional, social, and spiritual needs.
- **Curative Difference:** Focuses on pain relief and quality of life.
- **Rising Demand:** Increasing NCDs like cancer, diabetes, and respiratory diseases.
- **WHO Gap:** Only **14% receive palliative care** despite high global need.

Palliative Care in India

- **Access Gap:** Only **1–2% access palliative care** despite 7–10 million needing it.
- **System Pressure:** Integration reduces hospitalisations and the family's financial and emotional burden.
- **Policy Progress:** Palliative care included in **National Health Policy 2017**.

Challenges

➢ **Accessibility:** Access remains uneven, particularly in rural and economically disadvantaged areas. Systemic inefficiencies continue to impede its effective delivery.

➢ **Shortage of Trained Professionals:** While India's **doctor-population ratio of 1:834** exceeds the WHO norm of 1:1000, the shortage of specialists in palliative care limits access to comprehensive pain management and end-of-life support.

➢ **Limited Funding and Infrastructure:** Inadequate financial support and poor infrastructure hinder the expansion and delivery of quality palliative care services.

➢ **Incomplete Integration:** Although palliative care is part of the primary healthcare framework, its integration into tertiary care settings remains insufficient.

➢ **Cultural and Social Barriers:** In many parts of India, discussions around death, terminal illness, and palliative care are **taboo**, making families reluctant to seek such services early.

Way Forward

✓ **Tele-Palliative Care:** ASHAs and telemedicine expand rural access. E.g., Kerala home-care model.

✓ **Medical Education:** MBBS inclusion improves skills. WHO recommends early palliative training.

✓ **Task-Shifting:** Nurses trained for care. E.g, India National Health Mission programmes.

✓ **Insurance Coverage:** Ayushman Bharat supports coverage that reduces out-of-pocket expenditure significantly.

✓ **Research & Policy:** Evidence-based approach; WHO palliative care guidelines guide policy.

{Social Sector – Health} One Health Approach *

❖ **Context (TH):** The Supreme Court's directive on Delhi's stray dogs highlights **zoonotic risk prevention**, linking human, animal, and environmental health under a One Health framework.

About the One Health Approach

- It is a collaborative framework **linking human**, **animal**, & **environmental health** to tackle shared risks.

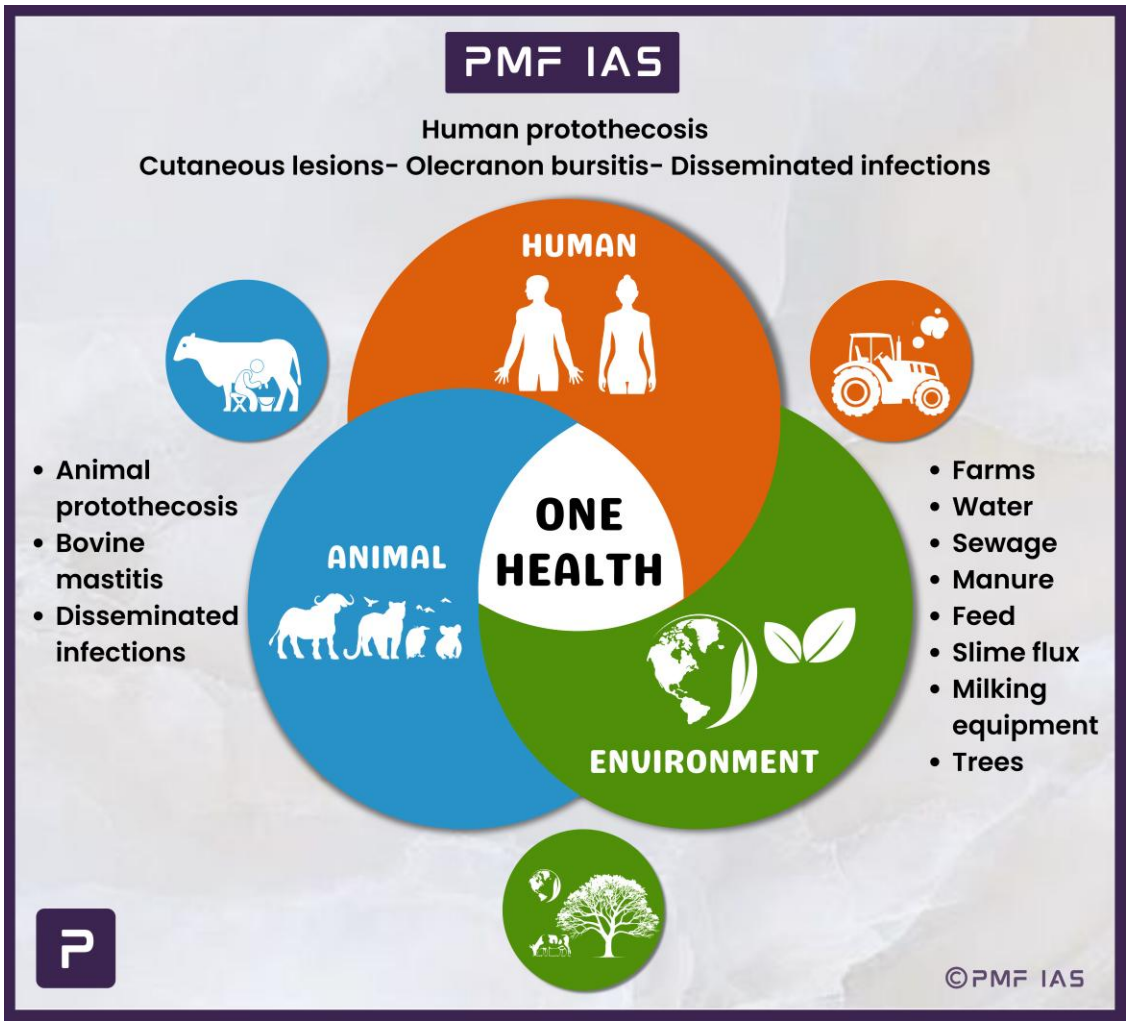
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- **Interdisciplinary Scope:** Medical, veterinary, and ecological sciences converge to guide interventions.
- **Global Standing:** WHO, FAO, UNEP, & WOAH formally endorse the framework for **zoonotic governance**.
- **Policy Anchor:** India's National One Health Mission provides institutionalised multisectoral coordination.

Operational Tools of One Health

- **Mass Immunisation:** Large-scale animal vaccination interrupts critical zoonotic transmission chains.
- **Livestock Monitoring:** Continuous veterinary surveillance enables hotspot detection & early response.
- **Drug Oversight:** Regulating veterinary pharmaceuticals prevents resistance & ecological disruptions.
- **Waste Control:** Hygienic carcass and garbage management lowers disease-vector proliferation.
- **Integrated Databases:** Linking human, veterinary, and ecological data strengthens zoonotic surveillance.



Public Health Significance of One Health

- ✓ **Zoonotic Containment:** Targeting animal reservoirs curtails rabies, Nipah, avian influenza, etc.
- ✓ **Health Security:** Coordinated prevention systems lower epidemic risks across human populations.
- ✓ **Food Chain Integrity:** Monitoring livestock health ensures safe meat and dairy supplies.
- ✓ **AMR Safeguard:** Cross-sector regulation of antibiotics reduces antimicrobial resistance escalation.
- ✓ **Conservation:** One Health aids conservation by reducing conflicts and safeguarding ecosystems.

Structural Challenges in Implementation

- ➢ **Fragmented Agencies:** Health, veterinary & municipal systems work in silos without coordination.

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- **Infrastructure Deficit:** Weak diagnostic labs restrict timely zoonotic disease confirmation & treatment.
- **Funding Imbalance:** Animal health services attract far less investment than human health.
- **Community Barriers:** Public resistance & misinformation obstruct animal vaccination and surveillance.
- **Climate Stressors:** Rising temperatures and erratic rainfall expand pathogen niches and vectors.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Mission Deepening:** Broaden India's One Health Mission through stronger inter-ministerial leadership.
- ✓ **Vaccination Expansion:** Scale up immunisation campaigns targeting rabies and avian influenza.
- ✓ **Laboratory Network:** Establish district-level zoonotic labs with integrated diagnostic facilities.
- ✓ **AMR Strategy:** Operationalise **India's One Health AMR plan** to regulate antimicrobial use.
- ✓ **Digital Integration:** Build national zoonotic surveillance platforms using AI and GIS tools.

Read More> *One Health Approach*

{Social Sector – Health} Out-of-Pocket Expenditure in India *

❖ **Context (TH):** India's **Out-of-Pocket Expenditure** (**OOPE**), at **39.4%** of **Total Health Expenditure (THE)**, remains a primary driver of medical impoverishment & a critical barrier to Universal Health Coverage.

- The National Health Authority (NHA) defines OOPE as direct household payments for health services at the point of care, excluding third-party reimbursements or subsidies.

NHA Data on OOPE

- **Sustained Decline:** OOPE fell from 62.6% (2014-15) to **39.4% (2021-22)**, reflecting a major structural shift toward public health financing.
- **Public Funding:** Government health expenditure increased from 29% of the Total Health Expenditure (2014-15) to **41.4% (2019-20)**, reflecting a significant expansion in public spending on health.
- **Global Gap:** India's OOPE remains **nearly double the global average (18-20%)**, revealing persistent gaps in financial risk protection.

Issues with NHA Estimates

- **Data Lag:** Reliance on outdated National Sample Survey (NSS) 2017-18 data **forces extrapolations**, masking current household health spending realities.
- **Pandemic Blindspot:** The model ignores the V-shaped cost surge during COVID-19, distorting actual financial risk patterns.
- **Macroeconomic Contradiction:** National Income Accounts show health's GDP share rising, while NHA depicts steady OOPE decline.

Factors Behind High OOPE

- **Limited Funding:** India invests **~2% of its GDP in healthcare**, well below the **WHO's 5% target**, forcing families to turn to private healthcare services.
- **Private Reliance:** Nearly **70% of outpatient** and **60% of inpatient treatments** are delivered privately, significantly increasing healthcare costs.
- **Expensive Medications:** Medications make up **~60% of outpatient OOPE**, with price disparities reaching up to 3400%, heavily burdening average patients.
- **Insurance Gap:** An estimated **40 crore Indians**, the "*missing middle*", lack health insurance, exposing them to high financial risk from medical costs.

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- **Weak PHCs:** Inadequate primary health centres (PHCs) lead to the referral of even minor illnesses to tertiary hospitals, which unnecessarily raises treatment costs.

> ⇨ ***Missing Middle:*** *Households that are too poor to afford private health insurance yet not poor enough to qualify for government-subsidised schemes.*

Consequences of High OOPE

- **Catastrophic Spending:** 17% of Indian households spend **over 10% of their income** on health, eroding savings and jeopardising financial stability
- **Poverty Induction:** Healthcare costs push **~55 million Indians into poverty** annually (WHO-World Bank), reinforcing deep socioeconomic disparities.
- **Debt Cycle:** Families resort to high-interest informal loans for treatment, triggering distress asset sales and **intergenerational debt**.
- **Care Denial:** Fear of unaffordable costs leads to postponed care, resulting in advanced diseases and preventable mortality.
- **Inequality Expansion:** OOPE disproportionately burdens rural poor, women, and informal workers, exacerbating existing social and health inequities.

> ⇨ ***Catastrophic Health Expenditure (CHE):*** *WHO defines CHE as health spending **above 40% of capacity-to-pay**, with SDG indicators additionally using a 10% expenditure threshold.*

Way Forward

- ✓ **Integrated Data:** Combine NSS, CES, and CMIE datasets to build a reliable and precise national health expenditure framework.
- ✓ **Fiscal Commitment:** Increase public health spending to **2.5% of GDP** (NHP 2017 target) to lessen household financial burdens.
- ✓ **Holistic Insurance:** Expand Ayushman Bharat to include outpatient services, adopting Thailand's model of holistic financial protection.
- ✓ **PHC Empowerment:** Equip Ayushman Arogya Mandirs with free essential medicines and diagnostics to establish them as credible first-contact points.
- ✓ **Price Regulation:** Empower the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) to enforce price controls on a broader range of essential medicines and diagnostics.

> ⇨ ***NSS:*** *The **National Sample Survey** provides large-scale household data on consumption, employment, and health expenditure through periodic rounds.*
> ⇨ ***CES:*** *The **Consumer Expenditure Survey** measures household spending patterns, offering insights into poverty, inequality, and living standards nationally.*
> ⇨ ***CMIE:*** *The **Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy** conducts independent surveys on employment, consumption, and business activity, filling real-time data gaps.*

Read More > *Universal Health Coverage in India*

{Social Sector – Health} Healthcare Sector of India *

❖ **Context (TH):** The Centre has informed Parliament that **India's doctor-population ratio is 1:811**.

Status of India's Healthcare System

- **Health Spending:** Public health expenditure stands at **1.9% of GDP** (FY 2023-24).
- **Cost Burden:** Out-of-Pocket Expenditure **(OOPE)** decreased to **39.4%** of Total Health Expenditure in 2021-22 from **62.6%** in **2014-15**.

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- **Doctor Availability:** The doctor-population **ratio of 1:811 exceeds** the **WHO norm of 1:1000**.
- **Primary Healthcare:** Over **1.77 lakh** Health and Wellness Centres (HWCs) have been set up, reflecting a shift to Comprehensive Primary Health Care (CPHC).
- **Disease Burden:** Non-communicable diseases (NCDs) like diabetes, cardiovascular diseases, and cancers cause over **60% of deaths**.

Key Challenges in India's Healthcare Sector

- **Low Spending:** Public health expenditure remains below the 2017 National Health Policy **target of 2.5%.**
- **Rural Shortages:** Despite an improved overall doctor–population ratio, rural and specialist gaps persist.
- **NCD Burden:** Dominance of NCDs overburdens long-term care systems and health resources.
- **Cost Burden:** A near 40% Out-of-pocket expenditure remains high for sustainable health spending.

Government Measures and Initiatives

- **Ayushman Bharat:** It is the flagship scheme for **Universal Health Coverage (UHC)**.
  - **AAMs:** Over 1.7 lakh **Ayushman Arogya Mandirs** (formerly HWCs) provide comprehensive primary care with a focus on **NCD screening** and preventive care.
  - **PM-JAY: Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana** provides **₹5 lakh per family per year** for **secondary and tertiary care** to 12 crore poor and vulnerable families.
- **NHM:** The **National Health Mission** supports states in strengthening rural and urban health systems, improving service delivery, and expanding public health capacity.
- **PM-ABHIM:** The **PM Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission** aims to build public health infrastructure, including critical care hospital blocks and public health laboratories.
- **PMBJP:** The **Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana** provides quality generic medicines at low costs through **Janaushadhi Kendras**, helping to reduce OOPE.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Health Financing:** Raise public health expenditure to **2.5% of GDP**, strengthening infrastructure, workforce capacity, and service delivery.
- ✓ **Rural Access:** Expand specialists, telemedicine, and services through **1.77 lakh+ Ayushman Arogya Mandirs** across underserved regions.
- ✓ **NCD Prevention:** Prioritise screening and lifestyle interventions as NCDs account for **over 60% of deaths nationwide**.
- ✓ **Financial Protection:** Strengthen PM-JAY and Janaushadhi coverage to further reduce 39.4% Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE).

Read More > *Innovation in Healthcare Sector* | *India's Primary Healthcare Sector*

{Social Sector – Health} Universal Health Coverage in India

❖ **Context (TH):** The **Lancet Commission** of experts called for a **citizen-centred healthcare delivery system** in India as the main vehicle for Universal Health Coverage.

Need for Citizen-Centric Health Coverage in India

- **Low Public Spending:** Public health expenditure **remains below 2% of GDP**, far below the National Health Policy **target of 2.5% of GDP**.
- **Rising NCD Load:** Non-communicable diseases account for **~60% of deaths** in India, requiring continuous primary care and prevention.

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- **Disease Burden:** India has **~140 million elderly (60+)**, increasing demand for long-term care.

Challenges Faced

- **Human Resource Shortage:** Many states face **20–30% vacancies** in specialist and medical officer positions at public facilities, which hinders quality and continuity.
- **High Catastrophic Spending:** Approximately **14–17% of households** face catastrophic health expenditures (various estimates), indicating weak financial protection.
- **Fragmented Care System:** India has **~70% outpatient care** largely in the private sector, causing discontinuity, duplication of tests and variable standards.
- **Poor Preventive Focus:** Screening and early diagnosis remain low; diabetes and hypertension often remain underdiagnosed for years, increasing complications load.

Key Recommendations by the Lancet Commission

Citizen-Centric Integrated Care

- **Citizen-Centric Care:** Shift from top-down public health planning to include people's priorities, lived experiences and feedback in decisions. E.g. **Kerala's People's Plan model** for local health governance.
- **Public Primary Vehicle:** Make publicly financed and publicly provided care the main backbone for Universal Health Coverage (UHC). E.g. **Ayushman Bharat Health and Wellness Centres (HWCs)**
- **AYUSH Integration:** Empower practitioners of Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha and Homoeopathy (AYUSH) within integrated care teams for preventive coverage.

Workforce & Frontline Empowerment

- **Competency Focus:** Move beyond formal qualifications to evaluate provider competencies, values, motivations and ethical conduct in real service delivery.
- **Frontline Empowerment:** Strengthen autonomy, training and decision-support for frontline workers to improve **last-mile continuity**. E.g., **Tamil Nadu's Makkalai Thedi Maruthuvam (**doorstep care)

Digital Technology-Led Reform

- **Digital Integration:** Use digital platforms to link registered providers with payers and patients for seamless, integrated care delivery pathways. E.g. Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM) with ABHA IDs.
- **Point-of-Need Delivery:** Deploy Artificial Intelligence (AI), genomics and capital-efficient innovations for advanced diagnostics at primary/community levels.

Governance & Financing Reforms

- **Fund Flow Efficiency:** Digitise fund flow, simplify procedures and reduce bureaucratic hurdles to improve utilisation and timely service delivery.
- **Outcome-Based Financing:** Shift from line-item budgets to global budgets with evaluation based on health outcomes, building accountability and trust.

{Social Sector – Health} Preventive Healthcare in India **

- **Context (TH):** India's healthcare system is heavily skewed towards reactive treatments, with preventive health measures receiving only about 14% of funding.
- Preventive healthcare comprises proactive medical measures, clinical screenings, and lifestyle modifications to prevent disease or detect physiological anomalies before symptoms manifest.

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- **Adoption Gap:** Only about 1 in 3 Indians undergo regular health check-ups. Nearly **75% avoid diagnostic testing** until severe symptoms appear.

Strategic Significance of Preventive Healthcare in India

- **Economic Protection:** Routine primary screenings detect physiological anomalies early to safeguard household savings against out-of-pocket expenditure that **impoverishes 55 million Indians annually**.
- **Epidemiological Control:** Mass immunisation and screening protocols intercept high-risk metabolic conditions before clinical onset to prevent non-communicable disease, responsible for **65% of deaths**.
- **Infrastructure Relief:** Grassroots wellness protocols divert manageable clinical loads locally to decongest a tertiary government hospital network with only **0.79 beds per 1,000 citizens**.
- **Spatial Equity:** Pre-symptomatic screenings across decentralised health networks deliver immediate local diagnostics, eliminating the need to seek urban medical specialists.

Government Schemes for Preventive Healthcare

- **Primary Screening:** Ayushman Arogya Mandirs conduct mass population-level screenings to identify silent non-communicable disease risks before they escalate into chronic conditions.
- **Disease Surveillance:** **Integrated Health Information Platform** (IHIP) aggregates real-time grassroots epidemiological data to detect early warning signals and contain regional outbreaks.
- **Immunisation Coverage:** U-WIN Portal digitises the maternal and child vaccination lifecycle to predict drop-out trends and secure the 90% full immunisation target.
- **Behavioural Modification:** Eat Right India and Fit India institutionalise dietary and fitness standards to combat sedentary lifestyles and reduce mortality from non-communicable diseases.
- **Digital Integration:** **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission** (ABDM) unifies fragmented clinical records into single longitudinal health profiles to enable seamless nationwide health tracking.

Challenges in Preventive Healthcare

- **Low Awareness:** Uptake of preventive care remains low, as people seek treatment only after illness develops. E.g., 75% avoid diagnostics early.
- **Funding Gap:** Health spending prioritises treatment over prevention, limiting early detection systems and programmes. E.g., 14% spending on prevention.
- **Weak Primary:** Primary healthcare lacks infrastructure, staff, and diagnostic capacity for early screening. E.g., rural screening facility shortage.
- **Behavioural Resistance:** Cultural neglect and poor health-seeking habits reduce preventive check-up adoption. E.g., only 1-in-3 check-ups.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Primary Strengthening:** Expand Health and Wellness Centres for accessible screening and early detection services. E.g., **Ayushman Bharat HWCs**.
- ✓ **Digital Expansion:** Use AI and ABDM for predictive, integrated, and real-time health monitoring systems. E.g., U-WIN immunisation tracking.
- ✓ **Awareness Drive:** Promote lifestyle change and preventive behaviour through education and campaigns. E.g., **Fit India Movement**.
- ✓ **Health Surveillance:** Strengthen real-time disease monitoring for early outbreak detection and response. E.g., IHIP disease alerts.

Read More > *India's Primary Healthcare Sector*

{Social Sector – Health} Health Insurance Schemes in India **

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❖ **Context (TH):** Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PMJAY) and **State Health Insurance Programmes (SHIPs)** highlight insurance-led challenges in achieving equitable Universal Health Coverage (UHC).

Current Trends in the Insurance Scheme Landscape

- **Expanding Coverage:** PM-JAY and SHIPs jointly cover nearly **80% citizens**.
- **Growing Budgets:** Combined outlay reached about ₹28,000 crore in FY 2023–24.
- **Rising Spending:** SHIP allocations **increased 8–25% annually** since 2018.
- **Low Utilisation:** Only **35% insured** patients used benefits under PM-JAY/SHIPs.
- **Public–Private Split:** Public hospitals form **51% empanelment** but capture only **one-third payouts**.

Significance of Insurance Schemes

- **Inclusive Coverage:** Government insurance widens healthcare access and narrows social inequalities.
- **System Relief:** Insurance helps decongest hospitals and promotes timely medical treatment.
- **Infrastructure:** Risk pooling supports the growth of hospitals & health infrastructure nationwide.
- **Poverty Reduction:** By reducing health shocks, insurance supports poverty alleviation and mobility.
- **Social Legitimacy:** Public insurance reinforces **healthcare as a right**, not a discretionary service.

Structural Challenges in Insurance Schemes

- ➢ **Private Bias:** Public funds primarily flow to profit-driven, weakly regulated private hospitals.
- ➢ **Hospitalisation Skew:** Insurance favours costly inpatient admissions, neglecting basic primary care.
- ➢ **Payment Delays:** PM-JAY dues of ₹12,161 crore forced service suspension, eroding system credibility.
- ➢ **Unequal Treatment:** Private hospitals discourage insured patients, while public hospitals favour them.
- ➢ **Fraud Cases:** Over 3,200 hospitals flagged for false claims, undermining the scheme's integrity.

Reforms for Equitable Health Financing

- ✓ **Public Spending:** Raise health expenditure from 1.9% **GDP** to **2.5%** under the NHP-2017 target.
- ✓ **Gatekeeping:** Adopt **Thailand-style** capitation with gatekeeping, routing to primary centres first.
- ✓ **Non-Profit:** Implement **Canada-style** non-profit hospital funding to curb private profiteering.
- ✓ **Timely Payments:** Ensure NHA clears claims **within 30 days** to retain provider trust.
- ✓ **Fraud Control:** Deploy AI-based monitoring and audits to detect and prevent false claims.

Read More> *Healthcare Expenditure in India* / *Universal Health Coverage in India*

{Social Sector – Health} Medical Tourism in India **

❖ **Context (PIB):** India has become a **leading global hub** for medical tourism, which involves travelling abroad to receive affordable or locally unavailable specialised medical care.

Current State of Medical Tourism in India

- **India ranked 10th** among 46 countries in the **Medical Tourism Index 2020–21.**
- Medical tourism **increased over three times** from 1.8 lakh in 2020 to **6.6 lakh in 2023**.
- **Foreign Tourist Arrivals** (FTAs) reached **1,31,856** between January and April 2025, **4.1% of total FTAs**.
- **Bangladesh** is the **top source country**, followed by Iraq, Somalia, Oman, and Uzbekistan.
- India accounts for **8%** of the global medical tourism market, valued at **$7.69 billion**.

Government Initiatives to Promote Medical Tourism

- **Strategic Roadmap:** The **2022 National Strategy and Roadmap for Medical and Wellness Tourism provides a framework** and brand positioning.
- **Heal in India Campaign:** Promotes India via public-private partnerships and digital patient facilitation.
- **Visa Facilitation:** **E-medical** and **E-medical Attendant visas** are available for **171 countries**.

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- **Digital Platform:** **Medical Value Travel portal** offers **single-window services** in multiple languages.
- AYUSH Visa**:** Introduced in **2023** for foreigners seeking traditional Indian medicine treatments.
- **Gujarat Model:** **First** to integrate **medical tourism**, it collaborates with regional wellness retreats.
- **Financial Assistance:** The **Market Development Assistance Scheme** aids wellness tourism providers.

Why is India a popular choice for medical tourism?

- **Cost Advantage:** Treatments cost **60–80% less** than in **Western countries**, including the US & Europe.
- **Medical Expertise:** English-speaking, often **Western-trained doctors** ensure quality communication.
- **Advanced Equipment:** Supports cardiology, oncology, orthopaedics, and other specialities.
- **AYUSH Systems:** Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha, and Homoeopathy attract wellness tourists.
- **Shorter Wait Times:** Patients access specialised treatments faster than in many developed countries.

Challenges in Medical Tourism in India

- **Quality Variations:** Only a fraction of India's hospitals hold international accreditations such as **NABH and JCI**, undermining global trust.
- **Infrastructure Gaps:** Medical tourism remains concentrated in metros, while Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities lack world-class facilities.
- **Post-Treatment Continuity:** Limited international follow-up care and digital health integration create challenges for foreign patients.
- **Global Competition:** Countries like **Thailand, Singapore, and Turkey** offer aggressive marketing and seamless patient services.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Global Accreditation:** Increase **NABH/JCI-certified hospitals** to strengthen India's reputation for safe and quality healthcare services.
- ✓ **Integrated Medical Hubs:** Develop medical tourism clusters combining hospitals, hotels, AYUSH centres, and rehabilitation facilities.
- ✓ **Digital Continuity:** Expand telemedicine and Medical Value Travel platforms for seamless pre-treatment and post-treatment patient care.
- ✓ **Brand India Healthcare:** Strengthen the **Heal in India** campaign to capture a larger share of the **$7.69 billion global market**.

{Social Sector – Health} India's Diagnostic Ecosystem

❖ **Context (IE):** Strengthening affordable, decentralised diagnostics is vital to achieving India's universal health coverage and reducing **healthcare access inequities**.

Diagnostic Landscape in India

- **Market Size:** India's diagnostic laboratories market is valued at **₹1.54 trillion** in FY2024.
- **Service Dominance:** **Pathology** and **In Vitro Diagnostics** together hold a major market share.
- **Market Structure:** **Organised diagnostic chains** hold a **15% share**, limiting quality standardisation.
- **Quality Gap:** **Only 1.2%** of 100,000 labs have **NABL accreditation**, undermining reliability.
- **Urban Bias:** Concentration of **75% revenue in cities** constrains rural access equity.
- **Workforce Deficit:** Rural doctor-to-population ratio is approximately **1:11,082** nationwide.

Importance of Accessible Diagnostics

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- **Early Detection:** Timely testing identifies diseases sooner, enabling more effective treatment strategies.
- **Cost Efficiency:** Early diagnosis **reduces treatment costs**, easing patient and system burdens.
- **UHC Link:** Diagnostics expand service coverage, fulfilling universal health coverage commitments.
- **Epidemic Control:** Rapid detection of infectious diseases limits outbreaks and mortality risks.
- **Equity Driver:** Local diagnostics reduce rural-urban health outcome disparities nationwide.

Challenges for Universal Diagnostics

- **Infrastructure Deficit:** Many primary health centres **lack essential diagnostic equipment & facilities**.
- **Skilled Workforce:** Shortage of trained technicians delays accurate testing and timely reporting.
- **Cost Barriers:** High private-sector test prices exclude economically vulnerable populations.
- **Insurance Gaps:** Coverage excludes outpatient diagnostics, limiting financial protection for patients.
- **Urban Concentration:** City-focused diagnostic networks **limit rural access** to timely essential tests.
- **Regulatory Weakness:** Voluntary accreditation limits quality control in unorganised laboratories.

Government Initiatives

- **NLED Framework:** **National List of Essential Diagnostics** specifies tier-wise tests for uniform coverage.
- **ICMR Guidelines:** ICMR protocols ensure evidence-based test selection nationwide.
- **PHC Strengthening:** **Semi-auto analysers** at Primary Health Centres enhance diagnostic capabilities.
- **Molecular Testing:** TB and **disease-specific** molecular diagnostics extended to all **district hospitals**.
- **Vector Surveillance:** Sub-centre dengue and malaria testing speeds up local outbreak detection.
- **CHC Expansion:** **Dental X-ray units** in Community Health Centres widen oral health screening.
- **Tele-diagnostics:** **Remote pathology** and **radiology** link rural facilities to urban specialist expertise.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Insurance Inclusion:** Expand coverage to outpatient diagnostics, reducing patient financial vulnerability.
- ✓ **Rural Infrastructure:** Establish fully equipped diagnostic units in underserved rural health facilities.
- ✓ **Skill Development:** Train more **laboratory technicians** for accurate, timely diagnostic service delivery.
- ✓ **Mandatory Accreditation:** Make **NABL certification compulsory** for all diagnostic laboratories.
- ✓ **Tech Integration:** Scale **tele-diagnostics** and **AI tools** to augment specialist diagnostic shortage.
- ✓ **Sample Logistics:** Strengthen cold-chain transport for timely sample transfer from remote locations.
- ✓ **Disease Prioritisation:** Update essential diagnostics lists regularly to match changing disease patterns.

Read More: *Challenges in India's Diagnostics Sector*

{Social Sector – Health} AI in Healthcare **

❖ **Context (TH):** Artificial Intelligence (AI) is **enhancing care in healthcare** through tools like **eSanjeevani** and **TB screening.** However, without inclusivity, it may deepen disparities.

Key Challenges for Health AI Systems

- **Digital Literacy Gaps:** AI tools often assume tech and health literacy, which many rural or low-literacy users lack, leading to mistrust, misuse, or care delays.
- **Representation Gaps:** Male-biased datasets can result in misdiagnoses for women. A 2024 McKinsey study found that women are **up to 7 times more** likely to be misdiagnosed for heart conditions.
- **Systemic Exclusion:** AI may provide accurate advice, but it often overlooks cultural realities. In conservative settings, women may overlook their health unless advice reflects their lived reality.

Solutions for Better-Informed Health AI

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- ✓ **Inclusive Data:** Assess AI performance across demographics; retrain biased systems with diverse data to ensure clarity and accessibility for all users.
- ✓ **Community Partnerships:** Involve diverse community panels in AI design and testing to ensure cultural relevance and local validation.
- ✓ **Clear Logic:** Clearly explain AI decisions and limitations; publicly share dataset details and bias testing to **promote trust**.
- ✓ **Equity Checks:** Monitor real-world outcomes and access equity and enable independent audits to identify and correct new disparities quickly.

{Social Sector – Education} Medical Education in India

❖ **Context (TH):** Indian medical education is undergoing rapid changes, yet several gaps have emerged.

Regulation of Medical Education in India

- **National Medical Commission (NMC):** The NMC regulates medical education, sets standards, and grants approval for medical colleges in India.
- **State Medical Councils:** They oversee the implementation of **NMC guidelines** at the state level and regulate medical professionals.
- **Entrance and Licensing Exams:** Entrance exams like **NEET (National Eligibility cum Entrance Test)** for admission and **NEXT (National Exit Test)** for licensing ensure uniform assessment across the country.

Current Gaps in Medical Education

Curriculum Issues

- **Clinical Training Deficit:** Bedside teaching has nearly disappeared due to inverted schedules prioritising morning lectures over clinical rotations.
- **Theoretical Overload:** Despite **Competency-Based Medical Education (CBME)**, more focus is placed on lectures, with limited practical application.
- **Standardized Practices Lacking:** Irregular implementation of CBME across institutions leads to inconsistent training quality.

Regulatory Shortcomings

- **Inspection Gaps:** Inconsistent and irregular inspections allow subpar institutions to operate.
- **Relaxed Norms:** Eased criteria for establishing medical colleges compromise education quality.

Infrastructure and Faculty Deficit

- **Inadequate Facilities:** Many new colleges lack essential infrastructure, including laboratories & libraries.
- **Shortages:** Shortage of qualified faculty affects **teacher-student engagement** & learning outcomes.
- **Poor Faculty-Student Ratios:** Reverse of Western standards, hindering effective mentorship and academic interaction.

Quality Decline

- **Lower Standards:** Reduced failure rates suggest declining rigour, with even mediocre students passing.
- **NEXT Implementation Delays:** Uncertainty in the rollout of the NEXT affects uniform assessment.

Rapid Expansion

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- **Increased Colleges and Seats:** Medical colleges increased from **under 100** in **1970** to **766 in 2024**, with MBBS seats rising from 64,464 to 1,15,812 in a decade.
- **Policy Push:** Upgrading district hospitals into colleges aims to improve healthcare access.

Challenges of Rapid Expansion

- **Quantity Over Quality:** Expansion without adequate infrastructure undermines education standards.
- **Misaligned Western Models:** Copying Western practices without local adaptation leads to inefficiencies.

Recommendations for Reform

- ✓ **Revive Bedside Teaching:** Reinstate morning clinical rotations for hands-on patient interaction.
- ✓ **Streamline CBME:** Ensure uniform and practical implementation of competency-based education.
- ✓ **Adapt Curriculum to Local Needs:** Customize teaching practices to address India-specific challenges.
- ✓ **Consistent Inspections:** Implement regular, unbiased evaluations of institutions to maintain quality.
- ✓ **Stringent Approval Norms:** Avoid politically-driven relaxation of standards to establish medical colleges.
- ✓ **Enhance Facilities:** Invest to equip institutions with necessary infrastructure (labs, libraries & hospitals).
- ✓ **Recruit Faculty:** Incentivize qualified professionals to join academia to address faculty shortages.
- ✓ **Expedite NEXT Rollout:** Develop clear guidelines & implement the test for uniform assessment.

{Social Sector – Education} Five Years of NEP 2020

❖ **Context (TH):** As India marks five years of NEP 2020, **NIPUN Bharat** is driving a quiet classroom transformation, advancing foundational literacy and numeracy as the country's **largest learning mission**.

Key Features and Impact of NIPUN Bharat

- **Direct Funding:** NIPUN dedicates **80% education budget to focus on** classroom quality.
- **State Customisation:** States like UP, Haryana, Assam develop FLN-aligned materials.
- **Decentralised Monitoring:** UP conducted **4 lakh+ assessments**, Odisha 57,000 classroom visits.
- **Learning Gains:** MP improved **oral reading fluency by 10% points (2023–24)**.

Challenges Ahead

- ➢ **Uneven Implementation:** Progressive states lead, widening gaps; FLN gains vary widely across India.
- ➢ **Institutional Capacity:** Public schools face shortages; PTR often exceeds 30:1 in many states.
- ➢ **Political Will:** Education spending remains around 2.9% of GDP, below the NEP 6% target.
- ➢ **Teacher Training:** Teachers spend 40%+ time on non-teaching work, limiting skill development

Way Forward

- ✓ **Extend Timeline: Extend NIPUN beyond 2027**, ensuring sustained state ownership and continuity.
- ✓ **Expand Coverage:** Cover Balvatika to Grade 5 under the NEP 2020 framework.
- ✓ **District FLN Units:** Uttar Pradesh conducted 4 lakh assessments for FLN monitoring.
- ✓ **Annual Diagnostics:** Foundational Learning Study 2022 guides evidence-based learning interventions.
- ✓ **Community Ownership: NIPUN Gram Sabhas** engage panchayats and parents in learning.

{Social Sector – Education} Indian Knowledge Systems *

❖ **Context (TP):** Aryabhatta College's **Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS)** initiative reflects NEP 2020's thrust on **integrating traditional Indian knowledge** into higher education through scientific methods.

About Indian Knowledge Systems

- It was introduced by the **Ministry of Education (MoE)** under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.

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- **Aim:** To **revive** and **integrate** India's ancient intellectual traditions into modern education.
- **IKS Centre:** Over 50 government-funded **Indian Knowledge Systems centres** have been established.
- **Functions:**
  - ❖ **Interdisciplinary Collaboration:** Coordinate and promote **interdisciplinary IKS research** across national & international institutions.
  - ❖ **Group Formation:** Establish & mentor **subject-specific research groups** comprising scholars from diverse institutions.
  - ❖ **Knowledge Dissemination:** Promote popularisation schemes for **Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS)**.
  - ❖ **Funding Support:** Facilitate funding avenues for IKS-related research projects & academic initiatives.
  - ❖ **Policy Advocacy:** Make policy recommendations for Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS) promotion.

Challenges in Implementing Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS)

- ➢ **Evidence Gap:** Several traditional knowledge claims lack peer-reviewed validation, raising concerns over academic rigour and scientific credibility.
- ➢ **Knowledge Imbalance:** Despite India's diverse heritage, IKS curricula often emphasise Vedic traditions over tribal, Buddhist, and Jain contributions.
- ➢ **Faculty Shortage:** Over **50 IKS centres** exist, yet institutions face shortages of trained scholars with interdisciplinary expertise.
- ➢ **Implementation Challenges:** **NEP 2020** mandates integration, but limited teaching materials, translations, and standardised curricula hinder effective adoption.

Suggestions for Improvement

- ✓ **Academic Integrity:** Mandate **evidence-based research** & **peer-review** to uphold academic integrity and counter pseudoscience.
- ✓ **Knowledge Pluralism:** Incorporate Buddhist, Jain, tribal, & regional traditions alongside Vedic sources.
- ✓ **Curricular Integration:** Introduce IKS as optional, interdisciplinary courses complementing modern disciplines to ensure voluntary engagement.
- ✓ **Maintain Transparency:** Clarify that IKS is academically driven, and engage openly with critics to build trust and credibility.
- ✓ **Course Evaluation:** Use feedback, audits, and external reviews to improve IKS course quality & relevance continuously.

{Social Sector – Education} AI in Schools **

- ❖ **Context (PIB | TH):** The **Ministry of Education** has announced the introduction of an **Artificial Intelligence (AI) curriculum** for **Classes 3 and above** beginning from the 2026–27 academic year.
- **Policy Alignment:** The curriculum will align with the **National Education Policy (NEP) 2020** while promoting the vision of **'AI for Public Good'**.

Benefits of Introducing AI in Schools

- **Cognitive Development:** AI-based education encourages creativity, computational reasoning, and **problem-solving skills** among young learners.
- **Workforce Preparedness:** Early AI exposure develops necessary skills vital for future employability in an AI-integrated world.
- **Personalised Learning:** AI-driven tools tailor lessons to individual learning styles and incorporate accessibility features like speech-to-text and real-time translation to support diverse learners.

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- **Teacher Efficiency:** Automating routine tasks like grading enables educators to dedicate more time to focus on student engagement and mentorship.
- **Ethical Literacy:** Educating about AI ethics in schools raises awareness of bias, privacy, and fairness, promoting responsible use.

Risks and Challenges

- **Cognitive Dependency**: Overreliance on AI tools can diminish students' analytical abilities and impede the development of critical thinking skills.
- **Social Disconnection:** Excessive use of AI tools can weaken student–teacher and peer interactions, reducing opportunities for social and emotional growth.
- **Digital Divide:** High costs of AI infrastructure hinder adoption in under-resourced areas. Additionally, low-income students lack devices, connectivity, and digital skills, which worsens educational inequalities.
- **Academic Integrity:** Generative AI tools make plagiarism and cheating easier, undermining the reliability and credibility of traditional assessment systems.
- **Data Ethics**: AI systems trained on biased datasets can **reinforce stereotypes** and lead to unfair evaluations. Large-scale data collection also raises significant concerns over privacy and data security.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Problem-Centric Design:** Introduce AI tools to solve specific educational challenges, such as enhancing comprehension or lowering grading time.
- ✓ **Teacher Training:** Institutionalise continuous professional development to **equip teachers with AI literacy** and responsible integration practices.
- ✓ **Human Oversight:** Implement the "**human-in-the-loop**" approach for all critical decision-making, ensuring educators remain responsible for the final decisions.
- ✓ **Hybrid Learning:** Encourage blended classrooms by combining traditional and digital methods to maintain **continuity during connectivity gaps**.
- ✓ **Performance Evaluation:** Track measurable outcomes such as engagement levels, feedback speed, and skill improvement to assess **AI's educational efficacy**.
- ✓ **Equity and Inclusion:** Prioritise affordable digital infrastructure and localised content development to ensure nationwide access and participation.

Read More > *Artificial Intelligence*

{Social Sector – Education} Internationalisation of Higher Education

❖ **Context(TH): NITI Aayog** released a comprehensive road map to **internationalise India's higher education system,** aiming to correct the sharp inbound–outbound imbalance.

Current Imbalance in India's Higher Education System

- **Inbound–Outbound Gap:** In 2024, for every 1 international student studying in India, **28 Indian students** went abroad, indicating a severe asymmetry in academic mobility.
- **Low Inbound Base:** India hosted only about **47,000 foreign students** (2022), despite a **518% rise** since 2001, showing growth from a very low base.
- **Outbound Concentration:** Of around **13.5 lakh** Indian students abroad, nearly **8.5 lakh** study in high-income countries like the US, UK and Australia.
- **Economic Drain:** Overseas tuition and living expenses are projected at **₹6.2 lakh crore by 2025**, close to **2% of GDP**, exerting macroeconomic pressure.

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Significance of Internationalisation of Higher Education

- **Brain Drain Control:** The **1:28 mobility ratio** reflects significant talent loss, reinforced by **16 lakh citizenship renunciations** since 2011.
- **Fiscal Stability:** Outward remittances for education **rose by ~2000%** in a decade, linking higher education policy directly to balance-of-payments health.
- **Trade Deficit Impact:** Overseas education spending equals **~75% of India's trade deficit** (FY25), making domestic capacity expansion economically critical.
- **Soft Power Gain:** Raising inbound students to **7.9–11 lakh by 2047** can boost India's global influence and knowledge exports.

Challenges Faced for Internationalisation of Higher Education

- **Funding Constraints**: 41% of Indian institutions identify limited scholarships and financial aid as the biggest hurdle to attracting foreign students.
- **Quality Perception:** Around 30% of institutions report a weak global perception of Indian education quality, despite its scale and diversity advantages.
- **Campus Readiness:** Gaps in housing, student services and internationalised curricula reduce India's competitiveness as a study destination.
- **Regulatory Friction:** Visa rules, tax compliance, banking access and tenure norms raise entry barriers for foreign faculty and researchers.

Reforms Proposed by NITI Aayog

- ✓ **Vishwa Bandhu Schemes:** Introduce scholarships and fellowships to attract foreign students, researchers and faculty to Indian universities at scale.
- ✓ **Bharat Vidya Kosh:** Set up a **$10 billion** national research sovereign fund, with 50% diaspora/philanthropy contribution matched by government support.
- ✓ **Academic Mobility:** Launch an **EU's Erasmus+** like multilateral mobility programme **("Tagore Framework")** tailored to groupings such as ASEAN, BRICS and BIMSTEC.
- ✓ **Foreign Campuses:** Ease norms for international campuses and **campus-within-campus models** to globalise Indian academic ecosystems.
- ✓ **Ranking Reform:** Expand NIRF to include parameters like outreach, inclusivity and global partnerships to incentivise international engagement.
- ✓ **Diaspora Outreach:** Create **Bharat ki AAN (Alumni Ambassador Network)** to brand Indian higher education through globally placed alumni.

{Social Sector – Education} University Affiliation System **

❖ **Context (TH):** Despite expanding access to higher education, the university affiliation system has become administratively burdensome and academically rigid.

About India's University Affiliation System

- The affiliation system is a **hub-and-spoke** framework in which a parent university oversees a network of affiliated colleges.
- **Hub:** Affiliating university designs the curriculum, conducts examinations, awards degrees, and ensures regulatory compliance.
- **Spoke:** Affiliated colleges deliver approved courses, maintain local infrastructure, and provide day-to-day student support.

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- **Scale:** **Over 80%** of colleges in India operate under the affiliation system and account for **81%** of total **student enrolment**.
- **Nodal Body:** **University Grants Commission** (UGC) sets the guidelines and regulations under which universities grant affiliation to colleges.

Significance of University Affiliation Framework

- **Quality Benchmarking:** Affiliation protocols enforce baseline standards for infrastructure, faculty quality, and regulatory oversight.
- **Geographic Inclusion:** **More than 60%** of affiliated colleges are located in rural areas, expanding higher education access in underserved regions.
- **Cost Efficiency:** The model allows the government to expand higher education without the capital expenditure required to build independent universities.
- **Course Uniformity:** Standardised curricula facilitate **seamless lateral movement** for students across diverse socio-economic backgrounds.
- **Admin Relief:** It relieves smaller institutions from the burden of designing curricula and conducting high-stakes examinations.

Limitations of the University Affiliation Model

- **Administrative Burden:** Managing hundreds of affiliated colleges turns many state universities into overburdened examination centres.
- **Academic Rigidity:** Centralised curriculum control prevents colleges from updating courses to meet evolving industry requirements.
- **Accountability Gap:** The structural divide between degree-awarding universities and teaching colleges blurs responsibility for poor academic outcomes.
- **Accreditation Gap:** A lack of systemic incentives for quality improvement leaves **over 70%** of affiliated colleges without NAAC accreditation.
- **Research Gap:** The separation of teaching and research concentrates academic innovation on university campuses, weakening **grassroots research ecosystems**.

Way Forward for the University Affiliation System

- ✓ **Autonomy Shift:** Promote **graded autonomy under NEP 2020** to transition affiliated colleges into degree-awarding institutions with academic and administrative independence.
- ✓ **Accreditation Push:** Expand **NAAC accreditation coverage** using digital and simplified processes to include large numbers of unaccredited rural colleges.
- ✓ **Curriculum Flexibility:** Enable **decentralised curriculum design** aligned with local industry needs to improve employability and relevance of undergraduate programmes.
- ✓ **Capacity Building:** Strengthen mentorship between universities and affiliated colleges to improve governance, faculty quality, and institutional management systems.
- ✓ **Research Support:** Provide seed funding and incentives to integrate research culture in undergraduate colleges and improve innovation outcomes.

{Health, Nutrition, Education & Human Capital – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. Hidden hunger remains one of India's most persistent public-health challenges. Discuss the key drivers behind its continuation and suggest measures to effectively address this silent crisis. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

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Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about hidden hunger and mention current data.
- **Body:** Discuss the key drivers behind the continuation of hidden hunger in India, its impact, and suggest measures to address this silent crisis effectively.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on an integrative and multi-pronged approach to address this silent crisis.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Hidden hunger, or micronutrient deficiency, occurs when people get enough calories but lack essential vitamins and minerals. In India, **190 million** are undernourished, **35.5%** of children are stunted, and **80%** of adolescents face deficiencies (NFHS-5).

The Key Drivers Behind Its Continuation

- **Poverty Persistence:** Extreme poverty has fallen to **2.3% in 2022–23** (World Bank), limiting access to nutrient-rich food.
- **Anaemia Epidemic:** Over **67.1% of children** and **59.1% of adolescent girls** are anaemic (NFHS-5).
- **Diet Insecurity:** Despite food availability, many households cannot afford a healthy diet; ~43% lack nutrient-adequate diets per UN/FAO.
- **Gender Disparity:** Women and girls often eat last, contributing to persistent iron-deficiency anaemia across reproductive age groups.

India's Hidden Hunger Landscape

National Burden	Over 190 million undernourished; half global wasting.
Child Undernutrition	35.5% stunted, 18.7% wasted under-five children.
Adolescent Deficits	24% thin; 80% suffer micronutrient deficiencies.
Gender Impact	Women, children are disproportionately affected; high anaemia rates.
State Hotspot	Gujarat, Jharkhand, Bihar above national malnutrition average.

Hidden Impacts

- **Intergenerational Cycle:** Maternal malnutrition leads to 22% low birth weight in newborns (NFHS-5).
- **Stunted Growth:** 35.5% of children are stunted, affecting physical and cognitive development.

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- **Productivity Loss:** Hidden hunger costs India about 4% of GDP due to reduced workforce efficiency.
- **Health Burden:** Micronutrient deficiencies increase infections, raising child mortality (2.9% under-five).

Measures to Effectively Address this Silent Crisis

- ✓ **Governance Convergence:** Enhance **POSHAN Abhiyaan** using real-time **Poshan Tracker** monitoring; Odisha cut child stunting from **38%** (2015) to **30%** (2023).
- ✓ **Food Fortification: Scale iodised salt** and **fortified rice/oil** initiatives; national goitre prevalence fell from 13% (1998) to **2%** (2022).
- ✓ **WASH Integration:** Integrate with **Swachh Bharat Mission** and **Jal Jeevan Mission** to curb infection-driven malnutrition; 50% of stunting linked to poor WASH conditions (WHO-UNICEF).

Conclusion

- Hidden hunger is a silent crisis undermining India's **demographic dividend** and **economic growth**. Convergent governance, nutrition security, fortification, WASH integration, and awareness campaigns are essential to break this vicious cycle and achieve **SDG-2**.

Q. Mental health remains a neglected area of public health in India. Critically assess the policy and operational gaps and suggest a holistic approach to improve mental well-being at the population level. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the mental health in India by mentioning the current data.
- **Body:** Critically assess the policy, operational gaps and suggest a holistic approach to improve mental well-being.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on the government's vision about health and highlighting the strategy.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Mental health, defined by WHO as a **state of well-being**, affects **15%** of Indian adults. Urban prevalence is 13.5%, with suicide rates at **21.1 per 100,000 population**.

Policy Gaps

- **Fragmented Integration:** Mental health policies are **poorly integrated** with primary healthcare (NMHS).
- **Low Funding: Only 0.06% of GDP** allocated to mental health (WHO).
- **Legislative Delay:** Implementation of the **Mental Health Care Act 2017** remains slow.
- **Program Overlap:** Multiple schemes exist, causing confusion and inefficiency in delivery.

Operational Gaps

- **Workforce Shortage:** India has **~0.3 psychiatrists** per 100,000 population (WHO).
- **Urban Concentration: 70%** of mental health facilities are located in cities.
- **Low Awareness: Only 10–12%** of mentally ill receive treatment (NIMHANS).
- **Infrastructure Deficit:** Limited hospital beds and rehab centres for mental health patients nationwide.

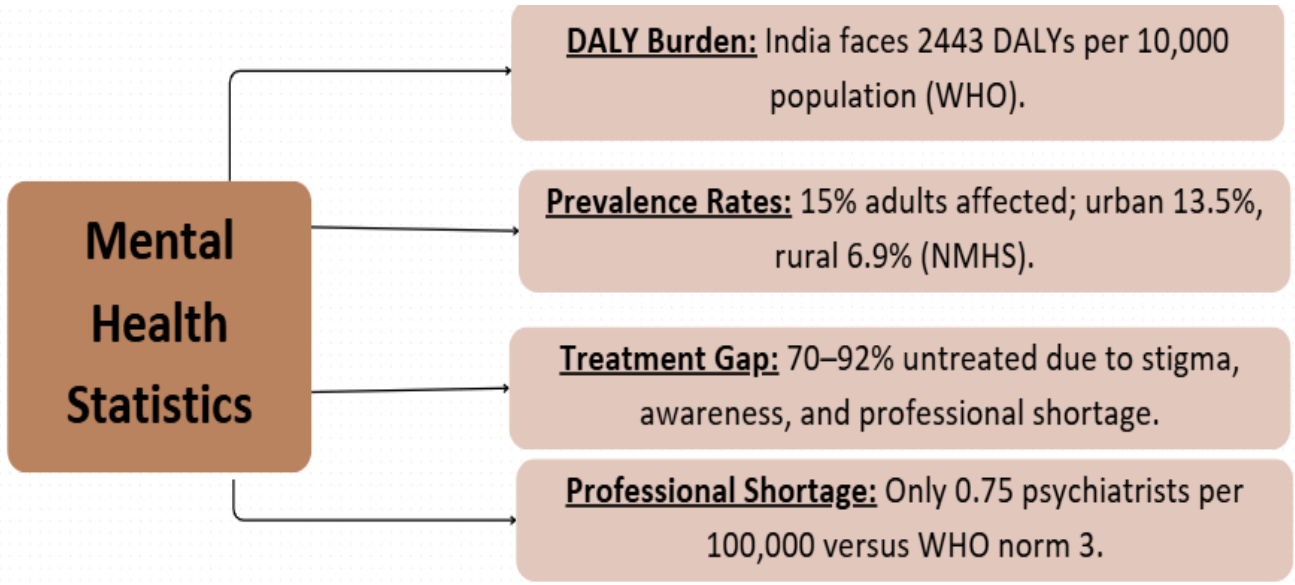
Holistic Approach to Improve Mental Well-Being

- ✓ **Workforce Expansion:** Increase psychiatrists from **0.75 to 3 per lakh population**, and train psychologists, counsellors (WHO).

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- ✓ **Tele-Mental Health:** Strengthen **Tele MANAS**, offering **24×7 digital counselling** for rural and remote populations (Ministry of Health).
- ✓ **Community Programs:** Promote peer support and rehabilitation groups to reduce stigma, E.g., district-level NMHP initiatives.
- ✓ **School & Workplace:** Implementing mental health curricula and workplace counselling & early intervention can minimise adolescent depression by 20% (NMHS).
- ✓ **NGO Collaboration:** Partner with NGOs to scale awareness and training, leveraging local networks like Sangath and Mpower.



Conclusion

- India's mental health strategy requires a **rights-based**, **integrated approach** with policy reform, workforce expansion, and digital solutions. As per the government vision, **"good health" ensures physical, mental, and social well-being**.

Q. India's health financing, dominated by high out-of-pocket expenditure (OOPE), poses a major barrier to achieving SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-being). Analyse the policy gaps and outline a roadmap to reduce OOPE and achieve Universal Health Coverage (UHC) by 2030. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

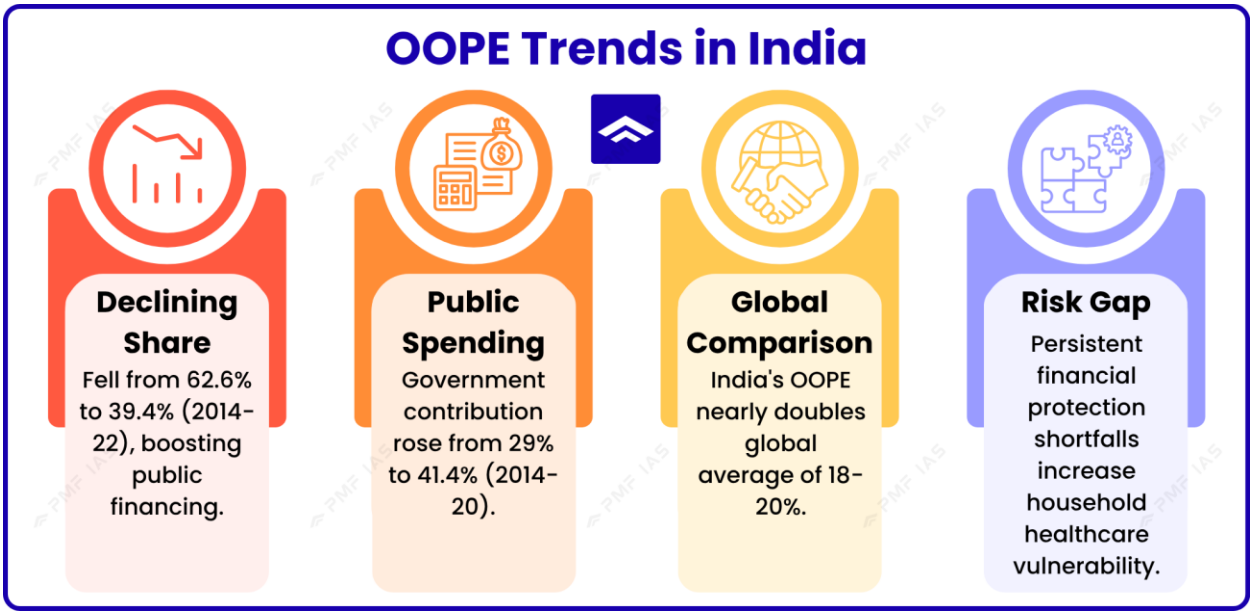
- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about OOPE by mentioning the current data.
- **Body:** Write how high OOPE poses a major barrier to achieving SDG 3, policy gaps and outline a roadmap to reduce OOPE and achieve Universal Health Coverage (UHC) by 2030.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a multi-pronged approach to achieving UHC by 2030.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India's health financing system is heavily reliant on out-of-pocket expenditure (OOPE), which accounts for **39.4% of Total Health Expenditure (THE)**. High OOPE deters timely care and obstructs progress towards **SDG 3** on health and well-being.

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How High OOPE Poses a Barrier to Achieving SDG 3

- **Medical Poverty:** **OOPE is 39.4%** of THE, pushing **~55 million Indians** into poverty annually (WHO).
- **Low Funding:** Public health spending accounts for **1.35% of GDP**, limiting infrastructure and care (NHP).
- **Insurance Gap:** Nearly **40 crore Indians** lack adequate coverage, and outpatient care is largely uncovered (NHA).
- **Medicine Costs:** Medicines constitute **~70%** of outpatient OOPE, with price disparities up to 3,400% (NPPA).

Policy Gaps

- **Funding Gap:** India's 1.35% of GDP public health spending limits infrastructure, workforce, & care quality.
- **Fragmented Insurance:** Schemes like **Ayushman Bharat** cover mainly hospitalisation, leaving outpatient care uninsured.
- **Inequitable Access:** Poor rural and marginalised access increases reliance on private providers & OOPE.
- **Pharmaceutical Costs:** High prices of medicines and diagnostics contribute to **70% of OOPE**.

Roadmap to Reduce OOPE and Achieve Universal Health Coverage (UHC) by 2030

- ✓ **Increase Expenditure:** Raise government expenditure to **at least 2.5–3% of GDP** to strengthen infrastructure and primary care.
- ✓ **Generic Medicines:** Strengthen Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana and enforce price caps on essential drugs.
- ✓ **Holistic Insurance:** Expand Ayushman Bharat to include outpatient services, adopting **Thailand's model** of holistic financial protection.
- ✓ **Digital Health Integration:** Utilise telemedicine, electronic health records, and AI-based diagnostics to reduce costs and enhance efficiency.

Conclusion

- **A multi-pronged approach**, boosting public spending, expanding insurance, promoting generics, and integrating digital health, is key to reducing **OOPE** and achieving **UHC by 2030**.

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Q. "Accessible, equitable, and affordable primary healthcare is the cornerstone of a resilient and inclusive public health system." Discuss the key challenges in achieving 'Health for All' in India and suggest measures to strengthen the primary healthcare system. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Introduce the answer by briefly summarising primary health care and its importance.
- **Body:** Discuss the key challenges in achieving 'Health for All' in India & suggest measures to strengthen the primary healthcare system.
- **Conclusion:** Write a futuristic conclusion mentioning the importance of equitable, resilient, and preventive health architecture for the new India.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India, with its **vast population** and **diverse health needs**, faces persistent challenges in delivering quality primary healthcare to all. Strengthening this first point of contact is crucial to achieving the vision of **Universal Health Coverage** and inclusive development.

Key Challenges in Achieving 'Health for All' in India

- **Inadequate Infrastructure:** Only **30%** of India's Primary Health Centres (PHCs) meet **Indian Public Health Standards** (IPHS), with many lacking essential equipment and diagnostic tools (MoHFW).
- **Shortage of Healthcare Workforce:** India faces a **70% shortfall** of specialist doctors at Community Health Centres (CHCs) and significant vacancies among nurses and ANMs. (Rural Health Statistics)
- **Urban-Rural Disparity:** Nearly **66%** of India's population resides in rural areas, yet only **33%** of the country's doctors serve them, creating a severe care access gap.
- **High Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE):** OOPE accounts for **nearly 48%** of total health expenditure (NHA), pushing millions below the poverty line annually.
- **Low Public Health Spending:** India spends only **2.1%** of its GDP on healthcare (2023), much lower than the global average of 6%.

Measures to Strengthen the Primary Healthcare System

- ✓ **Strengthen Ayushman Bharat–Health and Wellness Centres (AB-HWCs):** Expand and equip HWCs with diagnostics, medicines, and trained staff.
- ✓ **Invest in Digital Health Infrastructure:** Accelerate rollout of **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission** for telemedicine and health record access.
- ✓ **Enhance Workforce Training & Retention:** Encourage rural service; enhance frontline skills.
- ✓ **Increase Public Health Financing:** Raise health spending to **3% of GDP** with a focus on primary care.
- ✓ **Community Participation:** Involve local bodies and community health workers to ensure accountability and trust in the system.

Conclusion

- A resilient primary healthcare system is the **bedrock of New India's health mission**. Strengthening it ensures timely, affordable, and quality care, reduces catastrophic spending, and brings us closer to achieving **SDG-3: Good Health and Well-being for All by 2030**.

Q. With the rise of digital health platforms, Artificial Intelligence is increasingly shaping healthcare policies. Discuss the regulatory frameworks needed for responsible AI deployment in India. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

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Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction by mentioning eSanjeevani and Tele-MANAS.
- **Body:** Write how Artificial Intelligence is shaping healthcare policies, regulatory frameworks needed for responsible AI and the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a comprehensive framework for inclusive access to Artificial Intelligence in health care.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- AI is reshaping Indian healthcare via platforms like **eSanjeevani** and **Tele-MANAS**, enhancing access and diagnostics. However, concerns over data privacy, bias, and equity demand strong regulatory frameworks.

Artificial Intelligence is Shaping Healthcare Policies in India

- **Digital Records:** Ayushman Bharat uses AI to build health records for 1.4 billion citizens.
- **Tele Health:** **eSanjeevani** and **Tele-MANAS** apply AI for telemedicine and mental health.
- **Disease Surveillance:** **PM-ABHIM** leverages AI for outbreak prediction and monitoring.
- **Policy Roadmap:** NITI Aayog's AI Strategy identifies healthcare as a priority sector.
- **Ethical Framework:** **ICMR's 2023 guidelines** ensure AI use is transparent, inclusive, and patient-centric.

Need for Regulatory Frameworks

- **Data Privacy:** Healthcare involves sensitive data. Absence of strong safeguards can lead to breaches.
- **Algorithmic Accountability:** Bias in AI models may worsen inequalities in access and treatment.
- **Ethical Use:** Ensuring transparency, informed consent, and patient autonomy.
- **Quality Assurance:** Lack of clear standards compromise the safety of AI-based diagnosis & treatment.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Regulatory Authority:** Establish a **National AI Health Authority** to certify and monitor AI tools. E.g., CDSCO oversight of AI-based diagnostic devices.
- ✓ **Ethical Charter:** **Establish an AI charter** that ensures fairness, transparency, and inclusivity. E.g., WHO's AI ethics guidelines as global reference.
- ✓ **Clinical Validation:** Mandate trials and validation of AI algorithms before deployment. E.g., NITI Aayog's AI TB detection pilot validated with ICMR.
- ✓ **Innovation Partnerships:** Foster public–private collaborations through rigorous safety protocols. E.g., Microsoft–Apollo AI cardiology platform.

Conclusion

- AI is writing the **"code for humanity"** at an unprecedented scale, transforming healthcare delivery in India. This requires ethical, inclusive, and innovation-driven frameworks to ensure safe and equitable access for all.

Q. The health-poverty trap in India cannot be eliminated through insurance-based models alone. Discuss the role of strengthening primary and secondary healthcare systems in achieving Universal Health Care. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction about India's health-poverty trap and insurance by mentioning the facts.

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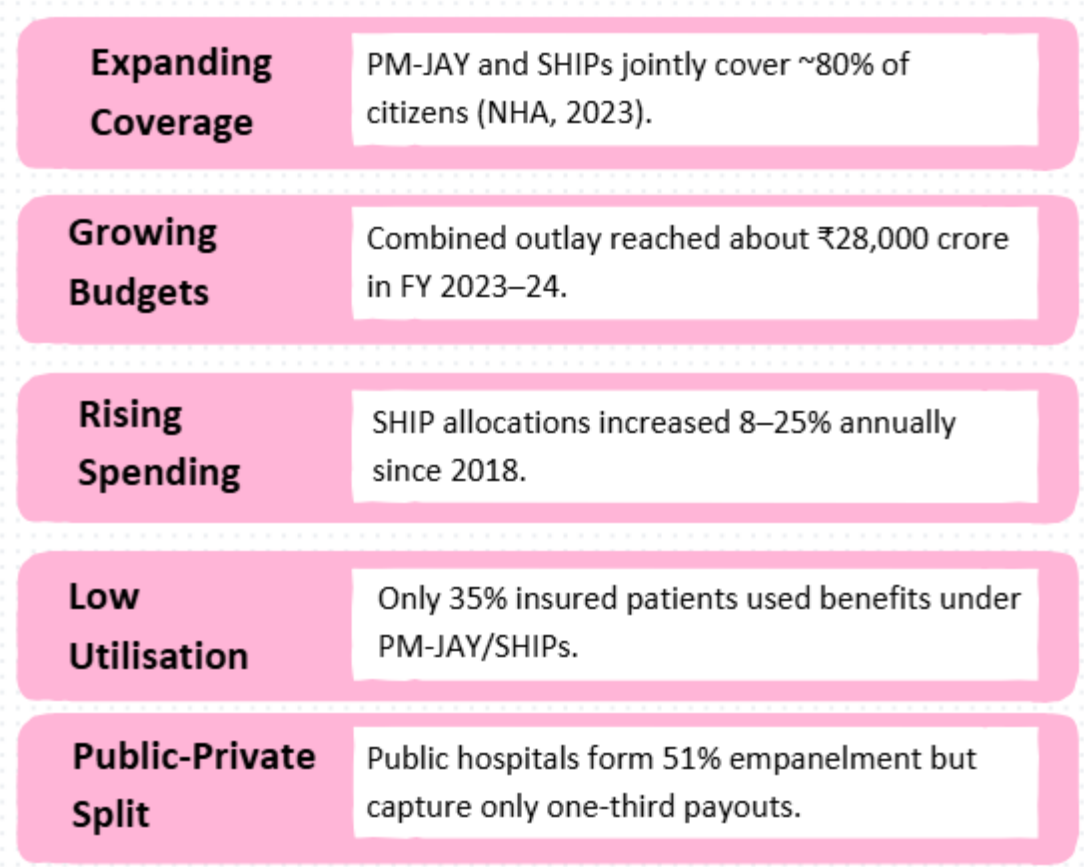
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- **Body:** Discuss how insurance alone fails the health-poverty trap, the role of primary and secondary healthcare systems in achieving universal health care and the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** In conclusion, mention the government vision with a way forward.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India's health-poverty trap persists, with **39.4% of expenditure out-of-pocket**. Schemes like PM-JAY cover **80%**, but robust primary and secondary care is essential for equitable UHC.

Current Trends in the Insurance Sector



Insurance Alone Fails the Health-Poverty Trap

- **Limited Coverage:** PM-JAY & SHIPs cover ~80% of the population, leaving informal workers vulnerable.
- **Primary Care Neglect:** Insurance prioritizes hospitalisation, overlooking preventive and primary care.
- **High OoPE:** **39.4%** of health expenses remain out-of-pocket, risking catastrophic costs (PIB).
- **Infrastructure Gaps:** Weak rural primary and secondary facilities limit insurance effectiveness (MoHFW).

Role of Primary and Secondary Healthcare Systems in Achieving Universal Health Care

- **Preventive Care Expansion:** 1.5 lakh Health & Wellness Centres under Ayushman Bharat provide preventive services, **reducing hospitalisation** (MoHFW).
- **Reduced OoPE:** Strong PHC and CHC networks keep catastrophic health spending **below 2% in Kerala**.
- **Rural Accessibility:** **Over 70% of the rural population** is served by functional PHCs and CHCs, enhancing timely care (NHM).

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- **System Resilience:** During COVID-19, PHCs and district hospitals **managed 60% of testing** and triage, easing tertiary load (MoHFW).

Way Forward

- ✓ **Increase Spending:** Raise health expenditure from **1.9% to 2.5% of GDP** to strengthen infrastructure.
- ✓ **Expand PHC Networks:** Operationalise 1.5 lakh Health & Wellness Centres under Ayushman Bharat for **rural coverage** (MoHFW).
- ✓ **Preventive Care:** Promote early detection and vaccination campaigns, E.g., COVID-19 vaccination drive reaching 2 billion doses (MoHFW).
- ✓ **Digital Health Integration:** Use the **eSanjeevani** telemedicine platform for remote consultations, serving millions nationwide (MoHFW).

Conclusion

- With the Government's vision of **"Securing the Unsecured,"** an integrated approach, such as primary and secondary healthcare with insurance, is key to **Universal Health Coverage (UHC),** reducing out-of-pocket costs and protecting vulnerable populations.

------- End of Chapter --------

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Poverty, Inequality, Urbanisation & Labour Transformation

{Social Sector – Poverty & Inequality} Poverty Measurement in India

❖ **Context (IE):** The **Household Consumption Expenditure Survey** (HCES) 2023-24, released by NSO in January 2025, has revived debate on India's poverty metrics. While official reports suggest record-low poverty, the **Thali Index** offers a more grounded view of food deprivation and access to nutrition.

Issues with Calorie-Based Poverty Metrics

➢ **Culturally Detached:** Calorie norms don't reflect diverse **regional diets** or culturally accepted food habits like the Indian thali.
➢ **Overlooks Essential Non-Food Costs:** Housing, healthcare, education, and transport consume a large part of household budgets, reducing money left for food yet these are ignored in calorie-based methods.
➢ **Ignores Regional Price Variations:** Food prices differ across states, making uniform calorie thresholds misleading for real-life affordability and access.

A More Grounded Metric: The Thali Index

- The Thali Index uses the **cost of a basic vegetarian thali** (₹30 as per CRISIL) to assess how many balanced meals one can afford, offering a simple, grounded, and intuitive way to measure poverty.
- The index includes food accessed via the **Public Distribution System** and welfare schemes, making it more reflective of real consumption patterns on the ground.

Why India Needs a New Poverty Lens?

- **High Food Deprivation:** In 2023–24**, 40%** of rural and **10%** of urban Indians could not afford two thalis a day, indicating severe food insecurity.
- **Contrast with Official Data:** World Bank and SBI data claim poverty is below 5% in both rural and urban India, showing a **disconnect** between statistical poverty and lived experience.
- **Relevance of Food Expenditure:** Since food is non-negotiable, actual food expenditure is a sharper lens for understanding economic stress than broader consumption metrics.

Implications for Subsidy Policy

The findings have important implications for the design and targeting of food subsidies:

- **Optimal Targeting:** At the **70th percentile**, rural individuals already afford twice the number of thalis as those at the **5th percentile**, even without subsidies.
- **Reform, not abandon:** Rather than phasing out subsidies due to allegedly low poverty, the focus should be on rationalising them:
  - ❖ Curtail food subsidies for **higher-income** households.
  - ❖ Enhance support for the most deprived, based on food consumption capacity.
- **Rethinking Welfarism:** Restructure food subsidies through a **graded model** based on income or thali affordability to reduce leakage, ensure nutrition, and enhance fiscal efficiency.

Way Forward

✓ Adopt the **Thali Index** as a supplementary tool for evaluating food security and standard of living.
✓ Integrate **regional dietary diversity** and **cost variations** into national-level poverty assessments.
✓ Encourage a shift from calorie-counting to nutrient-based and culturally resonant food metrics.
✓ Ensure that food security remains central to poverty-alleviation strategies, especially amid rising living costs and urbanisation.

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{Social Sector – Inequality} Land Inequality in Rural India **

❖ **Context (IE):** A new report by the World Inequality Lab has highlighted a high concentration of land ownership in rural India.

- **Data Coverage:** The report titled "**Land Inequality in India: Nature, History, and Markets**" is based on the **Socio-Economic Caste Census (2011)**, covering 650 million individuals across 2.7 lakh villages.
- **Measure of Inequality:** Gini coefficient (Gini Index) is used to quantify the degree of land inequality across rural households.

⇨ ***Gini coefficient*** *is a statistical measure used to assess the* ***distribution of income, wealth, or resources*** *in a population.*

⇨ *It ranges* ***from 0 to 1****, where* ***0*** *indicates* ***perfect equality*** *and* ***1*** *indicates* ***maximum inequality****. The Gini index is the same value multiplied by 100 (ranging from 0 to 100).*

Key Findings of the Report

- **Land Concentration:** Top **10% households own 44%** rural land.
- **Extreme Ownership:** Top **1% alone control 18%** rural land.
- **Landlessness Crisis:** Around **46% rural households remain landless** nationwide.
- **Regional Disparities:** **Punjab 73% landless**; Bihar shows high inequality.

Causes of Land Inequality

- **Historical Legacy:** Former zamindari regions exhibit higher inequality than erstwhile princely states.
- **Caste Inequality:** Higher **SC populations** often correlate with unequal land ownership patterns.
- **Market Advantage:** Fertile, market-linked regions witness greater land concentration and inequality.
- **Reform Gaps:** **46% households are landless** despite decades of land reform efforts.

Measures to Address Land Inequality

✓ **Land Reforms:** Ensure strict implementation of land ceiling & tenancy laws to redistribute surplus land.
✓ **Digitise Land Records:** Promote modern land records (**Digital India Land Records Modernisation Programme**) for transparency and ownership security.
✓ **Support Small Farmers:** Provide credit, irrigation, technology, & market access to improve productivity.
✓ **Land Leasing Reforms:** Legalise and regulate land leasing to protect tenant farmers and improve land use efficiency.
✓ **Inclusive Rural Development:** Promote non-farm employment, skill development, and diversification to reduce dependence on land.

{Governance – Issues} Rural–Urban Migration

❖ **Context (DTE):** The Economic Survey 2025–26 highlights that Indian cities are nearing capacity limits due to continuous rural youth migration, urging the revival of rural economies.

Causes of Rising Rural Migration

- **Infrastructure Deficit:** Around **35%** of rural households still lack access to quality healthcare facilities **within 5 km,** while rural secondary school dropout rates remain above 17%.
- **Income Disparity:** Average urban wages are nearly 1.7 to 2 times higher than rural earnings, especially in construction, services and informal manufacturing sectors.
- **Aspirational Shift:** **Over 60% of rural youth** express preference for non-farm urban employment, citing better lifestyle and social mobility prospects.

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Rural–Urban Migration Strain

Emerging Urban Challenges

- **Overburdened Cities:** Urban population has risen from **31% in 2011** to **nearly 36% in 2025**, sharply increasing demand for housing, transport and civic services.
- **Informal Settlements Growth:** **About 24%** of India's urban population now **lives in slums**, with migrant inflow being a major contributing factor.
- **Urban Unemployment Pressure:** Youth unemployment in urban areas remains **around 15–18%**, particularly among low-skilled migrant workers.
- **Environmental Stress:** Major cities **face water deficits of 20–40%,** alongside rising air pollution levels **exceeding WHO limits by 4–6 times**.

Social Impact on Rural Areas

- **Elderly Left Behind:** **Nearly 12%** of India's rural population is **now above 60 years**, with over one-third living without active family support due to migration.
- **Labour Shortages in Agriculture:** Seasonal farm labour shortages have increased by nearly **20–25%** in several states, affecting crop cycles.
- **Community Fragmentation:** Migration rates from **rural households exceed 28%**, weakening traditional kinship networks and local institutions.

Way Forward

✓ **Rural Livelihood Diversification:** Promote non-farm employment through schemes like **Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana–National Rural Livelihood Mission (DAY-NRLM)**.

✓ **Decentralised Skill Infrastructure:** Strengthen district-level skill ecosystems through **Rural Self Employment Training Institutes** (**RSETIs**) and align training with local market demand.

✓ **Rural Infrastructure Revamp:** Accelerate investments in healthcare, education and digital connectivity under initiatives like BharatNet and Ayushman Bharat to improve quality of life.

✓ **Social Security for Ageing Villages:** Expand pension coverage and community care systems through schemes like Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme to protect elderly households.

{Governance – Issues} Urban Governance *

❖ **Context (TH):** The recent death of Yuvraj Mehta in Greater Noida goes beyond a mere accident, highlighting systemic failures in India's urban governance.

Urban Infrastructure Landscape

- **Road Safety:** Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (**MoRTH**) attributes **over 2,000 deaths annually** to poor engineering, often misclassified as driver negligence.
- **Economic Impact:** Poor road safety and infrastructure failures cost the Indian economy about **3.14% of GDP annually**.
- **Capacity Deficit:** Municipal corporations face staff vacancies of **35% to 41%**, creating critical shortages of engineers and safety inspectors.
- **Planning Gaps:** **NITI Aayog** notes that **nearly 65%** of India's urban settlements lack statutory master plans due to governance classification issues.

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- **Legal Challenges:** **Conviction rates** under **Section 304A** remain historically low as the law struggles to pin liability on systemic institutional failure.

Key Reasons Behind Systemic Failure

- **Demographic Overload:** Rapid migration drives population growth beyond infrastructure capacity, forcing cities to operate at 200-300% of their designed capacity.
- **Institutional Fragmentation:** Governance is **fragmented across multiple agencies** (PWD, Jal Board, Police), creating **jurisdictional silos** that hinder unified accountability.
- **Legal Immunity:** Agencies often evade liability for operational negligence by invoking the colonial doctrine of Sovereign Immunity, leaving victims uncompensated.
- **Constitutional Gaps:** The **74th Amendment** remains unimplemented in spirit, as states have failed to fully devolve "**Funds, Functions, and Functionaries**" to local bodies.
- **Regulatory Failure:** A nexus between contractors and officials often results in the approval of substandard projects without mandatory safety audits.
- **Ethical Erosion:** A "**normalisation of negligence**" prioritises procedural paperwork over the moral imperative to save lives in crises.
- **Disaster Management:** The **approach is reactive**, with insufficient investment in **preventive audits** or resilience infrastructure until tragedies occur.

Structural Reform Pathways

- ✓ **Counter-Magnet Cities:** Develop **Tier-2** and **Tier-3 cities** (e.g., Patna and Lucknow) to ease migration pressure on overcrowded metros.
- ✓ **Legal Reform:** Enact a **"Civil Liability Act"** to make government agencies financially accountable, removing the sovereign immunity shield.
- ✓ **Unified Governance:** Establish a Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority (**UMTA**) to eliminate inter-agency coordination failures.
- ✓ **Quality Assurance:** Institutionalise independent third-party safety audits for all infrastructure projects, aligned with **ISO 39001 standards**.
- ✓ **Capacity Building:** Equip urban police stations with basic disaster-response kits (e.g., drones, cutters) to enable immediate action.
- ✓ **Participatory Governance:** Legally empower **Resident Welfare Associations** (**RWAs**) to conduct **social audits of local hazards**.

{Poverty, Inequality, Urbanisation & Labour Transformation – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. Critically analyse the factors contributing to the significant decline in poverty rates among various religious and social groups in India between 2011-12 and 2023-24. Also, examine the persistent challenges in poverty alleviation and suggest measures to sustain inclusive growth. (15 Marks) (250 Words)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Briefly define poverty and highlight the significant decline in poverty rates among various social and religious groups from 2011-12 to 2022-23.
- **Body:** In the body, discuss the factors contributing to the decline in poverty and also discuss the challenges in poverty alleviation.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasise the success of poverty reduction efforts and the need for sustained, inclusive, and equitable development.

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Model Answer (250 Words)

- India's poverty rate declined from **12.2%** in 2011-12 to around **2%** in **2022-23**, with major reductions among Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), and Muslims. This progress reflects economic growth, welfare policies, and structural shifts.

Factors Contributing to the Decline in Poverty

- **Economic Growth and Employment Expansion:** India's **7%+ GDP** growth created jobs in manufacturing, services, and the gig economy, improving incomes across social groups.
- **Urbanisation and Rural Diversification:** Migration, non-farm employment, and remittances diversified income sources for low-income families.
- **Rising Wages and Increased Consumption:** Higher real wages and domestic demand enhanced purchasing power, lifting millions out of poverty.
- **Government Welfare and Financial Inclusion:** PM Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana, MGNREGA, PM-JAY, Ujjwala Yojana, and JAM Trinity ensured benefits for SCs, STs, and minorities.

Challenges in Poverty Alleviation

- **Data Limitations and Measurement Issues:** The outdated Tendulkar (₹870/month) and Rangarajan (₹1,098/month) poverty lines underestimate true poverty levels.
- **Regional and Gender Disparities:** Poverty remains high in Bihar, Jharkhand, and Chhattisgarh, while women and informal workers lack social security.
- **Job Quality and Informal Sector Issues:** Over 90% of the workforce in informal jobs face low wages and inadequate protection.
- **Slow Structural Reforms:** Agriculture, labour laws, and manufacturing reforms persist at a slow pace, limiting income mobility.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Human Capital Investment:** Focus on education, skills, and healthcare for long-term poverty reduction.
- ✓ **Formalisation of Workforce:** Expand social security and upskilling for informal workers.
- ✓ **Targeted Development:** Special economic zones & rural-industrial corridors can bridge disparities.
- ✓ **Agricultural Modernisation:** Boost farm incomes through market reforms, irrigation, & MSP enhancements.

Conclusion

- While India's progress in reducing poverty is notable, ongoing efforts in inclusive growth, skill development, and social protection are crucial for sustained advancement.

------- End of Chapter --------

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Governance, Law, Technology & Public Administration

{Governance – Laws} Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023 **

❖ **Context (TH):** Concerns have been raised over **Section 44(3)** of the **DPDP Act, 2023**, citing threats to transparency under the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005.

Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023

- **Background:** Enacted in response to the Supreme Court's recognition of privacy as a fundamental right in **Justice K.S. Puttaswamy vs. Union of India** (**2017**).
- The Act aims to regulate the processing of digital personal data while balancing individual privacy rights with lawful data processing needs.
- **Applicability:** Covers all entities processing digital personal data within India and those offering goods/services to individuals in India from outside.

Key Provisions

- **Definitions:** Defines **Data Principal** (individual whose data is collected), **Data Fiduciary** (entity processing data), Personal Data (identifiable individual data), Processing (data handling operations).
- **Individual Consent:** Explicit consent is **mandatory** for data processing; individuals can withdraw consent anytime. **Guardians** must provide consent for minors under 18.
- **Right to Erase & Nominate:** Individuals can request correction, deletion or delinking of misleading/irrelevant personal data; Can nominate someone to exercise these rights in case of death/incapacity.
- **Language Accessibility:** Information regarding data collection and processing must be provided in a language understandable to the data principal.
- **Data Localisation:** Critical personal data must be stored and processed **only within India**.
- **Sensitive Personal Data:** Includes financial, health, biometric, caste, religious & sexual orientation data.
- **Cross-Border Data Transfer:** Govt will notify countries where data fiduciaries can transfer personal data after assessment.
- **Obligations of Data Fiduciaries:** Ensure data accuracy, security, and proper disposal.
- **Additional Obligations for Significant Data Fiduciaries:** Certain entities handling large volumes or sensitive data must take extra precautions, including appointing a **Data Protection Officer** and an independent **Data Auditor**.
- **Data Protection Board of India (DPBI):** To monitor compliance, handle breaches, and impose penalties.
- **Financial Penalties:** Non-compliance can result in penalties **up to ₹500 crore**, which will be deposited in a **Data Protection Fund** to support DPBI activities.
- **Exemptions:** Govt entities can process data without consent for law enforcement, public welfare, and emergencies. Exemptions also apply to legal enforcement, security, research, and archiving.

Section 44(3) of the DPDP Act

- **Amends Section 8(1)(j)** of the **RTI Act, 2005**.
- **Amendment Despite Niti Aayog's Opposition:** Niti Aayog had flagged that by removing the public interest clause would weaken the RTI Act.

Aspect of Section 8(1)(j)	Before DPDP	After DPDP

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Personal Information Disclosure	Allowed if public interest justified it	Blanket exemption, no public interest test
Legislative Access Test	If not denied to Parliament, it could not be denied to citizens	Provision removed
Transparency vs. Privacy Balance	Assessed case-by-case	Exemption applied uniformly
Public Officials' Asset Details	Could be accessed in cases of corruption	Can now be denied

Impact on the RTI Act

- **Transparency Reduction:** Eliminates the public interest override, potentially limiting access to crucial government-related data, thus weakening public accountability.
- **Restricted Access to Public Officials' Data:** Privacy provisions may be misused to shield public officials from legitimate inquiries like assets, liabilities, and misconduct cases, affecting governance and trust.
- **Weakens Judicial Precedents:** Overrules rulings that favored transparency in cases of public interest.
- **Broad Exemption Risks:** May lead to blanket denials of legitimate information requests under RTI.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Periodic Review of DPDP Act:** Regular assessments to ensure exemptions do not unduly restrict information access.
- ✓ **Clear Guidelines for Disclosure:** Define criteria balancing privacy and transparency, like the **EU's** General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR).
- ✓ **Stronger Oversight Mechanisms:** Implement checks to prevent misuse of exemptions, similar to the **UK's Information Commissioner's Office.**
- ✓ **Digital Literacy & Awareness:** Educate citizens on their rights under both the RTI Act and DPDP Act, following models like **Australia's Information Commissioner's campaigns**.

{Governance – Laws} Online Gaming Regulation in India **

- **Context (TH):** Recently, Parliament passed the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Bill, 2025, aiming to ban Real Money Games (RMGs) while promoting e-sports and social gaming.

Key Provisions

Three Categories

- **E-sports:** Recognised under the **National Sports Governance Act, 2025**; prize money permitted.
- **Social Gaming:** Recreational and educational games promoted by the government.
- **RMGs:** Games played for money/stakes (E.g., Poker, Rummy, Ludo variants), completely banned.

Penalties

- **Offering/Financing RMGs:** Up to 3 years jail / ₹1 crore fine / both.
- **Advertising:** Up to 2 years jail / ₹50 lakh fine / both.
- **Legal Enforcement:** Offences are cognisable & non-bailable under BNSS, 2023.
- **App Blocking:** CERT-IN is empowered to block apps; Interpol may be roped in against offshore operators.
- **Player Immunity:** **No penal action** against individual players.

Rationale Behind the Act

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- **Health Risks:** WHO links RMGs to addiction, distress, and suicide cases.
- **Financial Threats:** Government flagged **₹30,000 crore GST evasion and fraud risks**.
- **Algorithm Manipulation:** RMG algorithms manipulate user engagement and fairness outcomes.

Legal and Constitutional Concerns

- **State vs Centre Jurisdiction:** Betting/gambling falls under the **State List (Entries 34 & 62)**.
- **State Bans:** States such as Telangana, Tamil Nadu, and Andhra Pradesh already have bans.

Supreme Court Intervention

- **Skill Classification:** SC previously ruled games like **Rummy & Fantasy Sports** involve **substantial skill**.
- **Trade Rights:** The Act blurs the line between **skill** and **chance**, violating Article 19(1)(g), Right to Trade.
- **GST Dispute:** SC has stayed GST notices; its verdict on taxation and classification is pending.

Challenges

- **Ambiguity:** Varying state laws (**Telangana**, **Tamil Nadu bans**) create uncertainty for operators.
- **Money Laundering:** Global unregulated market **~USD 1.7 trillion** leads to risks of financial crimes.
- **Financial & Mental Risks:** **23%** of youth face stress, with annual RMG losses **~₹20,000 crore**.
- **Cybersecurity Threats:** **11 million gaming** accounts exposed in 2024.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Gaming Measures:** Age-gating, spending limits, self-exclusion tools, and counselling support.
- ✓ **Whitelist & Enforcement:** Maintain verified operators & block illegal platforms via banks and ISPs.
- ✓ **Innovation & Talent Hubs:** Establish gaming incubators to foster startups, local talent, and global competitiveness.

{Governance – Laws} Age of Consent Debate *

❖ **Context (TH):** The Supreme Court in **State of Uttar Pradesh vs Anurudh** flagged misuse of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences **(POCSO) Act, 2012**, in consensual adolescent relationships.

Salient Features of POSCO Act, 2012

- POCSO Act is the **first comprehensive law** in India dealing specifically with sexual abuse of children. It seeks to protect children from sexual assault, sexual harassment and pornography.
- It criminalises **all sexual activities** for those **under the age of 18**, even if consent was factually present between two minors. **(Section 63)**.
- **Section 19** of the POCSO Act requires mandatory reporting of suspected offences.
- **Each district** shall designate a Sessions Court to be a Special Court. The state government shall establish it in consultation with the **Chief Justice of the HC**.
- A POSCO case must be disposed of within a year from the date the offence is reported.

POCSO (Amendment) Act, 2019

- The amendment has enhanced punishment under various sections of the Act, including the death penalty for aggravated sexual assault on children.
- The act **added two more grounds** to the definition of aggravated penetrative sexual assault, Assault resulting in the death of the child & Assault committed during a natural calamity.

Arguments for Lowering the Age of Consent

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- **Reality of Adolescent Behaviour:** NFHS-4 shows **39% girls had first sex before 18** (and 11% before 15), meaning the law criminalises lived reality.
- **Misuse in Romantic Cases:** Enfold study of **7,064 POCSO judgments** (2016–20) found **24.3%** involved romantic relationships; **82% victims** refused to testify, indicating forced criminalisation.
- **Clogging Justice System:** Enfold–Project 39A study found **25.4% of Section 6** (aggravated assault) cases involved consensual relationships.

Arguments Against Lowering Age of Consent

- **Deterrence Risk:** Lowering the age could weaken the "**bright-line" protection**, enabling trafficking, grooming, and exploitation disguised as consent.
- **Known-Perpetrator Abuse:** MoWCD 2007 study found **>50%** abusers known to the child (family/teachers/neighbours), where "consent" is often coerced.
- **Vulnerability of Minors:** Many adolescents lack emotional/financial independence; legal exceptions could reduce reporting and embolden predators.
- **Law Commission Warning:** **Law Commission 283rd Report (2023)** warned lowering consent age could make POCSO a "paper law", undermining fight against trafficking/child marriage.

Key Challenges in Current Framework

- **Weaponisation by Families:** POCSO is often filed to counter elopement or romance, turning adolescents into complainants under pressure.
- **Investigative Rigidity:** Mandatory reporting and non-compoundable nature reduce the scope for sensitive handling even when the relationship is consensual.
- **Judicial Inconsistency:** Delhi HC in **State vs Hitesh (2025)** urged law to respect consensual adolescent romance, but **Mohd. Rafayat Ali vs State** (Delhi HC) held consent immaterial under POCSO.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Close-in-Age Exemption:** Introduce **"Romeo–Juliet" clause** where consensual relationships between 16–18-year-olds are not treated as rape. E.g. **Canada-style "close-in-age" model**.
- ✓ **Judicial Screening:** Mandate early judicial review to detect coercion/exploitation before arrest; E.g**., pre-trial scrutiny guidelines** via SC directions for police/courts.
- ✓ **Safeguard Triggers:** Keep strict POCSO applicability if power imbalance exists; E.g., exclude exemption for teacher/guardian/employer relationships (position of trust).
- ✓ **Sex Education:** Expand adolescent Sexual and Reproductive Health Education through the Adolescent Education Programme and RKSK **(Rashtriya Kishor Swasthya Karyakram)** modules.

{Governance – Reforms} Police Reform in India

❖ **Context (TH):** PM Modi stressed the need for police reform while addressing the 60th All India Conference of Director Generals in Raipur, held under the theme of '***Viksit Bharat: Security Dimensions***'.

Need for Police Reforms in India

Political and Structural Inertia

- **Structural Stagnation:** Colonial-era institutional design restricts flexibility and undermines democratic policing. **Ten states** still use frameworks derived from the **Police Act 1861**.
- **Non-Compliance:** Supreme Court directives to create **independent police boards** and **fixed-tenure** systems remain unmet. Not a single state in India has fully complied with all **Prakash Singh directives**.

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- **Political Pressure:** Political leverage over postings forces officers to **prioritise political interests over the rule of law**. 72% personnel faced political pressure in cases involving influential persons. (SPIR 2019).
- **Weak Oversight:** Inadequate complaint bodies render public grievance redressal ineffective. **30%** of functional **State Police Complaints Authorities** (SPCAs) **lack a judicial member** (IJR 2022).

Workforce and Capacity Crisis

- **Work Fatigue:** Excessive duty hours and inconsistent weekly rest impair on-ground performance. An average **police workday** is **14 hours** (SPIR 2019).
- **Promotion Stagnation:** Limited promotion avenues reduce motivation for the bulk of the workforce. Constables form 86% of the force, but often retire with only one promotion after 30 years.
- **Training Deficit:** Outdated training fails to prepare officers for modern forensics, cybercrime, or human-rights compliance. 64% received no in-service training in the last 5 years (IJR 2022).

Diversity & Trust Deficit

- **Gender Gap:** Low female participation restricts **gender-sensitive policing** in sensitive cases. Women comprise 12% of the police force, far below the 33% target.
- **Minority Bias:** Weak minority representation in higher ranks reduces perceived neutrality. Despite forming 14% of the population, Muslims constitute only 3-4% of the police force.
- **Trust Deficit:** Fear of police aggression discourages crime reporting and community cooperation. CSDS Survey shows **14% of citizens** are "**highly fearful**" of the police

Human Rights & Infrastructure Issues

- **Custodial Violence:** The absence of an **anti-torture law** allows "third-degree" methods to continue without consequences. India **signed** the **UNCAT in 1997**, but has **yet to ratify** it.
- **Infrastructure Deficit:** Lack of basic amenities in police stations reduces working comfort and public accessibility. In 2020, **257** police stations had **no vehicles**, and **638** had **no telephones**.
- **Modernisation Lag:** Underutilisation of modernisation funds leaves forces with shortages in weapons and vehicles. 30-40% of the Police Modernisation Fund (MPF) remains unspent annually (IJR 2022).

Major Recommendations by Commissions

National Police Commission (1977-81)

- ✓ Create a **State Security Commission** in every state to prevent political misuse of police.
- ✓ **Ensure minimum assured tenure** for DGPs and key police officers.
- ✓ Restrict government interference and strengthen the internal authority of police leadership.

Ribeiro Commission (1998)

- ✓ Set up a **Police Establishment Board (PEB)** to oversee transfers, promotions, and discipline.
- ✓ **Replace** the colonial **Police Act of 1861** with a modern statute.
- ✓ Establish an **Independent Police Recruitment Board** for non-gazetted officers.

Padmanabhaiah Committee (2000)

- ✓ Separate Investigation responsibilities from the law-and-order duties.
- ✓ Create **Police Training Advisory Councils** at the central and state levels.
- ✓ **Retrain constables** and require personnel to retire if they fail to meet updated standards.

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Malimath Committee (2002-03)

- ✓ **Reform criminal justice** processes in evidence, investigation, and trials.
- ✓ Form a national-level law enforcement agency for specialised cases.
- ✓ Strengthen victim rights and witness protection systems.

Model Police Act Committee (2005-06)

- ✓ Replace the 1861 Act with a **rights-based Police Act**.
- ✓ Create a **State Police Board** for oversight and appointments.
- ✓ Enforce a **mandatory two-year minimum tenure** and regulate **transfers by rank**.

National Human Rights Commission (2021)

- ✓ Insert **Section 114B** in the **Evidence Act** to place the burden of explaining custodial injuries on police.
- ✓ Install **CCTV cameras** nationwide as directed by the Supreme Court.
- ✓ Institutionalise community policing and implement **Prakash Singh directives**.

Supreme Court Directions in the Prakash Singh Case (2006)

- **Tenure Protection:** Fix a **minimum two-year tenure** for DGPs, IGs, SPs, and SHOs; later prohibited the appointment of temporary or "acting" DGPs.
- **Transfer Insulation:** Shift all postings, transfers, promotions, and service matters to **Police Establishment Boards** (PEBs).
- **Accountability Mechanisms:** Establish **State Police Complaints Authorities** for public grievances and **State Security Commissions** to prevent political interference.
- **Functional Separation:** Separate investigation from law-and-order duties and constitute a **National Security Commission** for appointment and oversight of central police chiefs.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Legal Renewal: 10 states still use the 1861 Act**, lacking modern policing reforms.
- ✓ **Political Insulation:** No state fully implements all six Prakash Singh directives.
- ✓ **Human Staffing:** Constabulary forms **86%** of the force, often working 14-hour shifts daily.
- ✓ **Tech Policing:** 64% of personnel lack training; 30–40% of **modernisation funds** remain unspent.
- ✓ **Rights Assurance:** Custodial violence persists despite incomplete CCTV coverage in states.

Read More > *Police Reforms in India*

{Governance – Reforms} Prison Reform in India **

❖ **Context (TH):** Recently, the Supreme Court directed the **immediate release of prisoners** detained beyond sentence completion, exposing systemic lapses in prison governance.

Current Framework of Prison Governance

- Prison governance reflects **India's federal structure**, balancing state autonomy with national standards.
- **Constitutional Entry:** Prisons fall under the **State List, Entry 4**, in the **Seventh Schedule**.
- **Primary Law:** The **Prisons Act 1894** and **state manuals** regulate prison administration.
- **Administration:** **State Home Departments** manage prisons, deciding priorities and resource use.
- **Oversight Bodies:** Courts and NHRC inspections ensure rights compliance and procedural safeguards.
- **Advisory Role:** **BPR&D** issues reform guidelines, promoting uniform prison administration standards.

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- **Legal Aid:** NALSA provides free services to inmates, preventing unlawful, prolonged detention.
- **Special Laws:** Juvenile Justice Act and **Probation of Offenders Act** enable non-custodial sentencing.

Rationale for Urgent Prison Reforms

- Reforming prisons transforms them from punitive warehouses into rehabilitative state institutions.
- **Fundamental Rights:** Humane prisons uphold dignity under **Article 21** and equality under **Article 14**.
- **Rehabilitation:** Reform-oriented systems **reduce recidivism**, strengthening long-term public safety.
- **Overcrowding Relief:** Probation, parole, etc., reduce occupancy, improving management.
- **Legal Efficiency:** Timely inmate release prevents illegal detention, reinforcing judicial authority.
- **Reintegration:** Skills training curbs reoffending, supporting social stability and crime reduction.
- **International Commitments:** **Mandela Rules** compliance elevates India's human rights reputation.

⇨ ***Mandela Rules:*** *The **UN Standard Minimum Rules** mandate humane treatment, guiding reforms to improve prison conditions and protect inmate rights.*

Structural and Operational Deficiencies in Indian Prisons

- Persistent deficits in infrastructure, staffing, and technology undermine prison reform goals.

➢ **Overcrowding: Occupancy exceeding 130%** worsens health, hygiene, mental well-being, and safety.
➢ **Undertrial Crisis:** Undertrials form **77% of inmates**, prolonging detention and delaying rehabilitation.
➢ **Infrastructure Deficit:** Dilapidated facilities reduce inmate dignity, safety, & rehabilitation effectiveness.
➢ **Delayed Release:** Prisoners completing sentences remain confined, violating judicial directives.
➢ **Health Challenges:** Limited medical and mental healthcare increases disease, mortality, and stress levels.
➢ **Gender Sensitivity:** Women inmates face inadequate maternity care, sanitation, and security provisions.

Governmental Interventions for Prison Modernisation

- Targeted initiatives integrate technology, skill-building, and humane management principles.
- **Model Prison Manual 2016:** Establishes humane standards for uniform prison management nationwide.
- **E-Prisons Project:** Digital inmate records prevent detention beyond the authorised sentence term.
- **Open Prisons:** Semi-open facilities aid reintegration and lower security-related expenditure.
- **Legal Aid Clinics:** Prison-based lawyers expedite trials for underprivileged and indigent inmates.
- **Swachh Jail Campaign:** Hygiene drives improve prison living standards and health outcomes.
- **State Reforms:** **Kerala cafeterias**, **Tihar industries** enhance inmate income and self-reliance.

Global Models to Guide Indian Prison Reform

- Adopting proven international practices can recalibrate India's correctional philosophy.

✓ **Scandinavian Model:** **Norway's open cells** and inmate autonomy foster dignity and responsibility.
✓ **Halfway Houses:** **Japan** offers supervised housing with job placement assistance for ex-prisoners.
✓ **Digital Monitoring:** **South Korea's GPS anklets** replace custody for low-risk offenders.
✓ **Education Integration:** **US universities** run accredited courses inside correctional facilities.
✓ **Mental Health Units:** **Canada** integrates psychiatric hospitals within prisons for acute cases.

Read More> *Prison Reforms*

{Governance – Issues} Regulatory Impact Assessments in India

❖ **Context (LM):** Several government committees have urged the institutionalisation of Regulatory Impact Assessments (RIAs) to evaluate the costs, benefits, and long-term societal effects of laws.

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- RIA is a systematic, **evidence-based process** to evaluate the potential costs, benefits, and impacts of proposed regulations **before implementation**.
- **Components:** It involves defining the problem, evaluating alternatives, including non-regulatory approaches, analysing costs and benefits, and consulting stakeholders.

Significance of Implementing RIA

- **Compliance Rationalisation:** Regulatory checkpoints can reduce annual overhead costs of **up to ₹17 lakh** for manufacturing MSMEs by streamlining over 1,450 compliance obligations.
- **Investment Predictability:** Institutionalised regulatory filters guarantee long-term policy consistency, which can reverse recent sharp declines in net FDI.
- **Trade Integration:** Mandating RIA processes will prevent non-tariff barriers and satisfy regulatory transparency clauses in India's recent Free Trade Agreements.
- **Federal Alignment:** RIA bridges the compliance disconnect between Union and State frameworks, shielding central deregulatory measures from fragmented local guidelines.

Implementation Challenges of RIA

- **Analytical Limitations:** Gaps in econometric expertise and granular baseline data hinder reliable modelling of regulatory impacts on informal-sector enterprises.
- **Institutional Inertia:** Entrenched bureaucratic cultures may reduce mandatory RIA assessments to box-ticking exercises that carry no institutional accountability.
- **Federal Divergence:** **Constitutional friction** and **political short-termism** from state governments can undermine uniform execution of the RIA mandate across regional jurisdictions.
- **Statutory Vulnerability:** Without an enforceable legal mandate, ministries can bypass pre-legislative scrutiny and implement unvetted rules with immediate effect.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Analytical Augmentation:** Establish an **Economic Intelligence Unit** within the Cabinet Secretariat to equip line ministries with econometric tools to address data limitations.
- ✓ **Statutory Codification:** Enact a **Regulatory Transparency Act** to establish a legal framework compelling all government agencies to conduct independent pre-legislative assessments.
- ✓ **Federal Harmonisation:** Leverage the **NITI Aayog Governing Council** to forge cross-state consensus and synchronise disparate regional and central compliance frameworks.
- ✓ **Procedural Mandates:** Enforce a **mandatory 60-day public consultation period** that guarantees economic scrutiny before parliamentary enactment.

Read More > *Regulatory Reform in India*

{Governance – Issues} Freebies in Indian Politics **

❖ **Context (TH):** The Supreme Court criticised the indiscriminate distribution of **election-linked freebies**, emphasising development spending and targeted welfare schemes.

- It warned that universal handouts weaken labour participation and undermine productivity culture.

About Freebies

- Freebies are **short-term populist measures** aimed at electoral gains, lacking long-term structural economic support. **RBI categorises them as non-merit goods**.
- **Welfare vs. Freebies:** Welfare schemes invest structurally in human capital, contrasting sharply with temporary, non-merit consumer subsidies.

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Constitutional–Legal Framework

- **Balaji Precedent:** In *S. Subramaniam Balaji vs. State of Tamil Nadu*, the Court excluded **manifesto promises** from **"corrupt practice"** under the Representation of the People Act, 1951.
- **DPSP:** **Articles 38** and **39** of the Constitution mandate social welfare and inequality reduction, providing a defence for various redistribution schemes.
- **Spending Autonomy:** **Article 282** permits public purpose expenditure alongside the deficit ceilings mandated by the **FRBM Act**.

Arguments in Favour of Freebies

- **Safety Net:** Subsidised food, housing, and cash transfers **prevent extreme poverty and distress**, enhancing health and productivity.
- **Capability Expansion:** Targeted support enhances access to education and female mobility, aligning with **Amartya Sen's capability approach**.
- **Demand Boost:** Direct transfers increase the disposable income and may stimulate economic growth through a **multiplier effect**.
- **Market Correction:** State relief cushions agrarian distress and jobless growth in sectors where markets fail to generate employment.
- **Equity Fulfilment:** Redistribution advances the constitutional goal of social justice in historically disadvantaged regions.

Arguments Against Freebies

- **Fiscal Stress:** Indiscriminate subsidies **widen deficits**, increase debt-to-GDP ratios, and heighten credit risks for States.
- **Capex Crowding:** High consumption spending crowds out crucial investments in infrastructure, technology, and long-term asset creation.
- **Electoral Distortion:** Pre-poll competitive populism undermines informed voter choice and distorts fair democratic competition.
- **Resource Mispricing:** Free electricity in **Punjab** led to groundwater depletion and DISCOM losses, as highlighted by the CAG report.
- **Credit Erosion:** Blanket loan waivers weaken financial repayment discipline and distort institutional lending norms.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Fiscal Council:** Establish an **independent Fiscal Council** to publicly assess the feasibility of manifestos before elections.
- ✓ **RPA Reform:** Debate amending **Section 123** of the **Representation of the People Act, 1951**, to include electoral accountability.
- ✓ **Sunset Clause:** Mandate time-bound subsidies with periodic audits to prevent permanent fiscal burdens.
- ✓ **Voter Literacy:** Promote fiscal literacy to help citizens recognise the long-term inflationary and tax implications of freebies.

Read More > *Freebies Culture in Indian Politics*

{Governance – Issues} Digital Literacy *

❖ **Context (TH): Kerala** becomes **1st state** to achieve **total digital literacy**.

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What is Digital Literacy?

- **Digital Literacy:** The ability of individuals and communities to **understand** and **use digital technologies** for meaningful actions **within life situations**.
  - ❖ It includes basic skills like using smartphones, navigating the internet, using email, and understanding digital safety and privacy.
- **Digitally Literate Household:** If **at least one person** in the household can operate a **computer** and use the **internet** (among individuals **5 years of age and older**).
- **Objective:** To impart basic ICT skills relevant to the needs of the trainees, which would enable them to use IT and related applications to participate actively in the democratic process and further enhance opportunities for their livelihood.

Digital Literacy Status in India

- Only **38% of households** in India are digitally literate. In **urban areas**, digital literacy is relatively higher at **61%** compared to just **25% in rural** areas.
- Education, healthcare, and finance sectors underwent rapid digitisation during the pandemic.

Importance of Digital Literacy

- **Socioeconomic Benefits:** Digital literacy in India empowers individuals to access government services, online education, and employment opportunities.
- **Bridging the Gender Gap:** Equipping women with digital skills can increase their participation in the workforce and decision-making processes.
- **Boosting the Digital Economy:** A digitally literate population fosters innovation, entrepreneurship, and participation in the growing digital marketplace.
- **Good Governance:** People can also bypass machinery at lower levels of government, thus having access to enhanced accountability & transparency in service deliveries.
- **Knowledge Economy:** Since the nation targets & projects towards becoming a knowledge economy, digital literacy will ensure the participation of more & more people in digital platforms.

Challenges in Achieving Universal Digital Literacy

- ✓ **Limited Access:** Rural areas lack internet, devices, and reliable digital connectivity.
- ✓ **Skills Gap:** Teachers and learners lack essential digital literacy skills.
- ✓ **Illiteracy Barrier:** Poor foundational literacy limits effective engagement with digital content.
- ✓ **Language Barrier:** English dominance reduces access for non-English-speaking users.
- ✓ **Affordability Issue:** High device and data costs exclude poorer populations.

Initiatives

- **Digital India Program:** Launched in **2015**, the Digital India campaign aims to transform India into a digitally empowered society and knowledge economy.
- **National Digital Literacy Mission (NDLM):** The NDLM aims to impart digital literacy training to at least one person per household in select states and union territories.
- **National Digital Library of India (NDLI):** The NDLI is a digital repository of learning resources that provides access to many e-books, e-journals, and other educational materials.
- **SWAYAM & DIKSHA Platforms:** These online learning platforms provide free educational resources to students and teachers, promoting digital education.
- **Scheme for Promotion of Information Technology in Rural India (SPIRIT):** This digital literacy program provides financial assistance to NGOs and institutions for setting up rural IT training centres.

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Way Forward for Universal Digital Literacy

- ✓ **Digital Infrastructure:** **Expand BharatNet** and **affordable broadband connectivity** to bridge the rural-urban digital divide, where only 25% rural households are digitally literate.
- ✓ **Inclusive Capacity Building:** Integrate digital literacy into school curricula and scale **PMGDISHA** to cover women, the elderly, and marginalised communities.
- ✓ **Local Language Content:** Develop **multilingual digital platforms** and AI-enabled interfaces to overcome language barriers and improve accessibility.
- ✓ **Affordable Access:** Promote low-cost smartphones, subsidised internet plans, and community digital centres through PPPs to ensure universal digital inclusion.

{Governance – Issues} Global AI Governance

❖ **Context (TH):** The Secretary-General of the **UN** International Telecommunication Union (ITU) called for a **global AI regulation** amid concerns over job losses, deepfakes, and societal disruptions.

Need for Global AI Governance

- **Fragmented Global Rules:** National AI laws are inconsistent, failing to address cross-border risks.
- **AI Power Concentration:** Few nations and firms control AI, deepening global inequality.
- **Cross-border Security Risks:** AI misuse in warfare and disinformation threatens global stability.
- **Rights and Freedoms at Risk:** Surveillance and profiling erode privacy and democracy.
- **No Binding Global Law:** Absence of international legal norms leaves AI unregulated.

Read More > *Regulating AI*

Challenges in Global AI Governance

- ➢ **Geopolitical Rivalries:** US–China tensions hinder consensus, both invest **$100B+ annually in AI**.
- ➢ **Sovereignty Concerns:** Countries resist binding norms, fearing loss of control over **national AI policies**.
- ➢ **Capacity Divide:** Over **60% of developing countries** lack AI governance frameworks (UN data).
- ➢ **Big Tech:** Top **5 tech firms** control the majority of global AI investment and data.
- ➢ **Institutional Vacuum:** No global regulator exists; governance is fragmented across OECD, G20, and UN initiatives.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Regular UN Dialogues:** Convene **biannual global forums** to align national rules & share best practices.
- ✓ **Flexible Governance:** Promote adaptable structures balancing innovation, ethics, & cooperation.
- ✓ **Capacity Building:** Build training centres in developing countries to enhance regulatory capabilities.
- ✓ **Common Standards Platform:** Establish a global registry of shared definitions and AI evaluation norms.
- ✓ **Independent Expert Panel:** Form a **global AI panel** to guide risk assessment and ethical frameworks.
- ✓ **Global AI Fund:** Create an **UN-backed fund** to improve equitable access to AI tools.
- ✓ **India's AI Law:** Finalise MeitY's draft law to regulate AI risks and foster innovation.

{Governance – Initiatives} Digital Governance *

❖ **Context (PIB | DDN):** Department of Personnel and Training **(DoPT)** launched **five digital governance initiatives** to strengthen transparency, efficiency, and citizen-centric administration.

Key Initiatives Launched

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- **Ex-Servicemen Reservation Guidelines**, a consolidated, user-friendly reference manual standardising reservation rules across Central Ministries.
- **AI-powered Recruitment Rules Generator** to auto-draft recruitment rules, reducing procedural delays.
- **e-HRMS 2.0 App** to enable digital access to service records and HR processes for employees.
- **iGOT AI Sarthi** and **iGOT AI Tutor** to personalise learning pathways and map competency requirements.
- **Karmayogi Learning Lab 2.0** to create immersive digital training content using augmented reality (AR), virtual reality (VR), gamification and interactive simulations.

Benefits of Digital Governance in India

- **Transparency Gains:** **Aadhaar-linked Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT)** reduced human discretion, saving ₹3.5 lakh crore by eliminating **ghost beneficiaries**.
- **Administrative Efficiency:** **e-Office 7.0** achieved **93%** digital file handling across Central Ministries, accelerating decisions and record management.
- **Equitable Access:** **UMANG** delivered over 2,300 government services in **23 languages** through a single mobile platform, democratising access to government services
- **Last-Mile Connectivity:** BharatNet connected **2.14 lakh Gram Panchayats**, and widespread 5G connectivity enabled telemedicine, e-education, and digital crop insurance access.
- **Grievance Redressal:** AI-enabled **Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System (CPGRAMS)** resolved over 7,900 grievances daily through outcome-based monitoring.
- **Financial Formalisation:** **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)** led by UPI processes over **10 billion monthly transactions**, formalising workers through digital financial footprints.

Challenges of Digital Governance in India

- **Digital Divide:** Unequal **internet access**, device availability, and **digital literacy** limit the effective use of online government services.
- **Data Security:** Large citizen databases face risks of cyberattacks, leaks, and misuse due to uneven institutional cybersecurity capacity.
- **Skill Gaps:** Limited digital skills among officials hinder the effective adoption of platforms like e-Office and AI-based systems.
- **System Fragmentation:** Poor interoperability among ministry databases prevents seamless data sharing and integrated service delivery.
- **Algorithm Risks:** The expanding use of artificial intelligence creates risks of bias, opacity, and weak **accountability** in administrative decision-making.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Digital Inclusion:** Expand **BharatNet connectivity**, affordable devices, and local-language interfaces to ensure universal access to digital services.
- ✓ **Data Protection:** Operationalise the **Digital Personal Data Protection Act** with clear rules, penalties, and independent oversight mechanisms.
- ✓ **Capacity Building:** Invest in continuous digital training for officials through **Mission Karmayogi** and iGOT platforms.
- ✓ **System Integration:** Standardise data formats and APIs to improve interoperability across ministries under Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) frameworks.
- ✓ **Algorithm Accountability:** Establish transparent AI guidelines, audits, and grievance mechanisms to prevent bias and ensure administrative accountability.

Read More > *E-Governance in India*

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{Governance – Initiatives} Technological Sovereignty

❖ **Context (IE):** PM Modi's Independence Day speech emphasised **technological sovereignty** as key to India's self-reliance and economic independence.

Tech Sovereignty & Its Significance for India

- Technological sovereignty is a nation's capacity to develop technologies using indigenous infrastructure, serving as a fundamental aspect of national sovereignty.
- **Strategic Autonomy**: It reduces **reliance on foreign semiconductors**, platforms, and cloud systems.
- **National Security:** It secures key infrastructure with resilient supply chains and defence technologies.
- **Economic Growth:** Sovereign technologies contribute to India's goal of a **$1 trillion digital economy** by **2028**.
- **Innovation Edge:** Indigenous technologies tackle **India-specific issues** overlooked by global companies.

Bottlenecks to Achieving India's Tech Sovereignty

- India faces a paradox of abundant talent yet **fragile technological ecosystems**.
  - **Brain Drain Crisis:** 65% of leading US AI firms have Indian-origin leaders, reflecting talent exodus.
  - **Academic Weakness:** Indian universities lack scalable research and industry–academia collaborations.
  - **R&D Deficit:** India invests **0.7% of GDP** in research, less than its peers' 2–3%, limiting sovereignty.
  - **Service Trap:** IT giants prioritise services over innovation; India lacks indigenous equivalents to OpenAI.
  - **Infrastructure Gap:** AIRAWAT has only 656 GPUs, significantly fewer than the 10,000+ of global leaders.
  - **Funding Shortage:** IndiaAI and Quantum Missions are **underfunded** compared to global ambitions.

Way Forward for Achieving Tech Sovereignty

- ✓ **R&D Boost:** Increase R&D expenditure to **1.5% of GDP by 2030** and build a national AI ecosystem.
- ✓ **Product Startups:** Incentivise IP-driven, **product-first AI start-ups** and develop local cloud frameworks.
- ✓ **Chip Mission:** Accelerate India Semiconductor Mission and Vedanta–Foxconn chip fabrication projects.
- ✓ **Global Ties:** Balance **technological autonomy** with cooperation through Quad and EU initiatives.
- ✓ **Research Nexus:** Create **IIT–industry clusters** based on DARPA's collaborative innovation model.
- ✓ **Reverse Brain Drain:** Offer AI fellowships, incentives for returnees, and AI Centres of Excellence at IITs.

Read More> *The MANGO Paradox*

{Governance – Initiatives} One Nation One Licence One Payment **

❖ **Context (IE | BS):** A **DPIIT-led committee** released a working paper titled '**One Nation, One License, One Payment**' proposing a new copyright framework for AI training.

- **India** would become the **first to adopt a statutory licensing model** with retrospective royalty obligations if the proposal is implemented.

Key Recommendations

- **Blanket License:** Introduce a **compulsory license** permitting AI developers to use all lawfully accessed copyrighted works for training.
- **Hybrid Compensation Model:** Provide creators with **statutory remuneration** while ensuring developers non-discriminatory access to training data.
- **Centralised Body:** Create **Copyright Royalties Collective for AI Training** (CRCAT), a non-profit body to collect royalties from AI companies and distribute them to rights holders.

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- **Royalty Rates:** Adopt a fair, revenue-based royalty model determined by a **government-appointed expert committee** to ensure nationwide uniformity.
- **Retroactive Payment:** Apply royalty payments **retrospectively** to commercially successful AI systems already trained on copyrighted materials.
- **Data disclosure:** Mandate AI developers to submit a '**Sufficiently Detailed Summary' of all datasets used** to ensure transparency.

Need for an AI Royalty Framework for India

- **Legal Gap:** Addresses the lack of legal exceptions for text-and-data mining or AI training in India; the scope of existing exceptions under the **Copyright Act, 1957**, remains unclear.
- **Fair Compensation:** Ensures payment for sectors heavily used in AI training; E.g. India's **publishing industry** alone generates **₹8,000+ crore annually**, yet receives zero compensation from AI dataset use.
- **Level Playing Field:** Prevents dominance of large players in licensing; E.g. top AI firms raised **$50+ billion** globally in 2024, widening the bargaining gap with small Indian creators/startups.
- **Digital Sovereignty:** Establishes India as a rule-setter in AI governance; E.g., India is home to **1.3 million registered creators**, giving global weight to a statutory model.
- **Reduced Litigation:** Reduces infringement under **Section 51** of the **Copyright Act, 1957,** lowering disputes; E.g. **DNPA** publishers (48 major Indian news outlets) have filed cases against unlicensed AI training.

Challenges for Implementation

- **Global Precedent Risk:** No major economy mandates government-fixed rates, raising unpredictability.
- **Rate-Setting Complexity:** Diverse content sectors complicate pricing; E.g. India has over 20 copyright categories with varying economic values, making uniform rates difficult.
- **Institutional Capacity Gaps:** CRCAT must manage huge datasets, requiring advanced auditing tools.
- **Startup Burden:** Royalty and retroactive payments may impact scalability; for example, India's AI startup ecosystem crossed **$1.5 billion** in funding in 2024, but margins remain thin for early-stage players.
- **Judicial Uncertainty:** Rate challenges may clog courts (**22,000+ IP-related pending cases** in 2023).

Way Forward

- ✓ **Adaptive Regulation:** Begin with flexible royalty tiers and revise based on market outcomes; E.g. similar to phased tariff adjustments used in India's telecom sector.
- ✓ **Tech–Creator Dialogue:** Build continuous consultation channels between AI firms and creative sectors to reduce conflicts; E.g., similar to **Australia's bargaining code consultations**.
- ✓ **Support For Startups:** Offer concessional royalty slabs or credits; E.g., modelled on MSME support frameworks like **Startup India Seed Fund** and **Digital India Innovation Fund** to ease early-stage costs.
- ✓ **Strengthen CRCAT:** Build automated audit engines, royalty calculators, and metadata verification systems for efficient distribution.

{Governance – Civil Services} Resignation of Civil Servants and Associated Delays

- **Context (IE):** Delays in processing IAS resignations, as seen in **Kannan Gopinathan's case**, highlight procedural gaps, administrative discretion, and challenges to officers' political and career rights.

Trends in IAS Resignations

- **Total Resignations:** **31 IAS officers** resigned since the introduction of CSAT in 2010; **11** during UPA (2010–2014) and **20** during NDA (2015–May 2025).

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- **AGMUT Resignation:** **Kashish Mittal** resigned in 2019 after a transfer from Delhi to Arunachal Pradesh; relieved the same year.
- **Political Transitions:** **O P Chowdhary** (Chhattisgarh cadre) and **Ashwini Vaishnaw** (Odisha cadre) resigned and later joined the BJP, with Chowdhary now serving as State Finance Minister.

Legal and Procedural Framework

- **Service Rules:** IAS, IPS, & IFS resignations are governed by **Rules 5(1) & 5(1A) of the DCRB Rules, 1958**.
- **Clear Resignation:** A resignation must be unconditional and clearly communicated to be valid.
- **Submission Process:** State cadre officers submit to the **Chief Secretary**; central deputation officers submit via the ministry to the cadre.
- **AGMUT Routing:** Resignations of AGMUT cadre officers are processed through the **Ministry of Home Affairs**.
- **Authority Approval:** For IAS, the competent authority to accept or reject resignation is the Minister in charge of the **Department of Personnel and Training** (**DoPT**), effectively the **Prime Minister's Office**.

Principles and Exceptions in Acceptance

- **General Principle:** Resignations should generally be accepted if an officer is unwilling to continue service, ensuring administrative fairness.
- **Exceptions Allowed:** Acceptance can be delayed if the officer handles critical work, has pending disciplinary cases, or owes dues/bonds.
- **Withdrawal Before:** Officers can withdraw their resignation before acceptance, which automatically nullifies it.
- **Withdrawal After:** Post-acceptance withdrawal is allowed in the **public interest** (usually within 90 days), but not for **political intentions**.

Key Reasons Behind IAS Resignations

- **Political Protest:** Officers resign in dissent against government policies. E.g., **Kannan Gopinathan** quit in 2019 over Kashmir restrictions following the abrogation of Article 370.
- **Career Transition:** Officers leave for the private sector or entrepreneurship. E.g., **Ashwini Vaishnaw** resigned from the Odisha cadre in 2011 to start his own business.
- **Political Ambitions:** Officers resign to join politics or contest elections. E.g., **O P Chowdhary** resigned from the Chhattisgarh cadre and later became the State Finance Minister.
- **Transfer/Posting Issues:** Officers resign due to inconvenient or unsuitable postings. E.g., **Kashish Mittal** quit in 2019 after transferring from Delhi to Arunachal Pradesh.

Impacts of Delayed Resignations

- **Political Rights:** Officers cannot join political parties or contest elections while their resignation is pending. E.g., **Kannan Gopinathan** has been barred from Kerala polls since 2019.
- **Career Limbo:** Delayed acceptance traps officers professionally, blocking alternate careers or private opportunities, as seen with Gopinathan remaining on AGMUT records.
- **Democratic Participation:** Fundamental democratic rights are restricted, preventing officers from electoral engagement even after intending to exit public service.

Procedural and Political Challenges

- **No Timelines:** Rules do not specify deadlines. E.g., **Kannan Gopinathan's** resignation has been pending for over six years, while **Shah Faesal's** 2019 resignation also faced years of delay.

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- **Wide Discretion:** DoPT/Minister exercises broad authority without enforceable oversight, causing delays as seen in **AGMUT cadre cases** and **Kashish Mittal's 2019** resignation.
- **Practice Gap:** Guidelines discourage retaining unwilling officers, but backlogs persist. E.g., Gopinathan's continued posting despite resignation highlights the implementation gap.
- **Political Sensitivity:** Resignations tied to dissent or political issues, like protests over Jammu & Kashmir restrictions or sensitive transfers in Arunachal Pradesh, often face additional procedural delays.

Way Forward: Reform and Recommendations

- ✓ **Time-Bound:** Introduce **statutory deadlines** (**90–120 days**) for resignation processing to reduce administrative delays, as seen in Gopinathan's six-year pending case.
- ✓ **Track Transparency:** Implement a **public tracking system** showing resignation status, stage, and reasons for delay, improving accountability and governance.
- ✓ **Political Clarity: Amend conduct rules** to define when officers can engage in politics post-resignation, preventing ambiguity like in Shah Faesal's delayed case.
- ✓ **Independent Oversight:** Create a **DoPT or judicial appellate body** to allow officers to challenge undue delays, ensuring fairness and procedural integrity.
- ✓ **Disciplinary Reform:** Streamline disciplinary case handling so genuine resignations aren't blocked unnecessarily, addressing bottlenecks in sensitive postings or politically charged transfers.

{Governance, Law, Technology & Public Administration – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. Examine the role of Artificial Intelligence in global governance and suggest a regulatory framework that India can adopt to ensure the inclusive and innovation-friendly AI deployment. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about the importance of Artificial Intelligence in global governance.
- **Body:** Write the role of artificial intelligence in global governance and suggest a regulatory framework.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on an ethical, inclusive AI framework ensuring transparency, accountability, and protection of rights.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- Artificial Intelligence is **reshaping global governance** by influencing decision-making, diplomacy, and development across borders.



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Role of Artificial Intelligence in Global Governance

- **Policy Formulation:** AI-driven analytics support evidence-based policymaking & predictive governance. E.g., disaster management.
- **Climate Monitoring:** AI-driven tools help nations model emissions and meet **Paris Agreement targets**. E.g., IBM's Green Horizons.
- **Conflict Tracking:** AI analyzes satellite images to monitor war zones.
- **Institutional Efficiency:** AI automates UN document processing & translation, enhancing efficiency.

Regulatory Framework

- ✓ **AI Regulation Act:** Enact a rights-based AI law aligned with the **Digital Personal Data Protection Act**.
- ✓ **Ethical Standards:** Adopt NITI Aayog's **"Responsible AI"** principles to ensure fairness, transparency, and accountability.
- ✓ **AI Sandbox:** Create **regulatory sandboxes** in sectors like health, agriculture, and education.
- ✓ **Engagement:** Strengthen participation in global AI forums like GPAI & support **UN-led AI governance**.

Conclusion

- India must adopt an **ethical**, **inclusive AI framework** ensuring transparency, accountability & protection of rights & balancing innovation with democratic values for responsible, globally aligned AI leadership.

Q. Delays and a lack of transparency in the IAS resignation process have raised concerns about fairness and administrative propriety. Critically examine the underlying issues and suggest measures to ensure a predictable and rule-based system. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction about the delays and opacity in the IAS resignation.
- **Body:** Write a reason for resignation from the IAS, then mention the underlying issue and suggest measures to ensure a predictable and rule-based system.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on time-bound procedures and independent oversight to ensure a predictable and rule-based system.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Recent cases like **Kannan Gopinathan's** prolonged pending resignation highlight delays and opacity in IAS processes, raising concerns over fairness, accountability, and rule-based governance.

Reasons for Resignation

- **Political Protest:** Officers resign to express dissent against policies. E.g., **Kannan Gopinathan** resigned in 2019 over restrictions on Kashmir following the abrogation of Article 370.
- **Career Transition:** Shift to the private sector or entrepreneurship. E.g., **Ashwini Vaishnaw** resigned from IAS (2011) to enter business before joining politics.
- **Political Ambitions:** Entry into electoral politics. E.g., **O. P. Chowdhary** resigned from IAS and later became Chhattisgarh Finance Minister.

Underlying Issues

- ➢ **Timeline Absence:** No statutory deadlines. E.g., **Kannan Gopinathan's** 6-year delay shows administrative inertia.
- ➢ **Discretion Overreach:** Broad DoPT powers without oversight lead to opaque, inconsistent decisions.

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- **Process Complexity:** Multi-layered approvals (State–MHA–DoPT) cause delays despite the 1988 guideline against retaining unwilling officers.
- **Rights Impact:** Politically sensitive cases delay exits, restricting **Article 19** freedoms and participation. E.g., Shah Faesal's resignation.

Measures to Ensure a Predictable and Rule-Based System

- ✓ **Time-Bound Processing:** Introduce **90–120-day deadlines** to prevent excessive delays, as seen in Kannan Gopinathan's prolonged pending resignation.
- ✓ **Transparent Tracking:** Implement a **digital portal displaying status and reasons** for delay, similar to RTI systems, enhancing accountability.
- ✓ **Defined Guidelines:** Establish clear acceptance/rejection criteria to reduce arbitrariness. E.g., Shah Faesal's delayed case.
- ✓ **Independent Oversight:** Create an **appellate mechanism** to address grievances and ensure fairness in politically sensitive resignation cases.

Conclusion

- Ensuring a **rule-based**, **transparent**, and **time-bound** resignation system is vital, as **"fair processes are the foundation of fair governance,"** strengthening accountability and trust.

Q. Discuss how the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025, seeks to safeguard players from the risks of real-money gaming while fostering e-sports as a source of innovation and employment in India. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the act and mention the aim of the act.
- **Body:** Discuss how the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025, safeguards players from the risks of real-money gaming & promoting e-sports and innovation.
- **Conclusion:** Summarise act & emphasise innovation and skill development in India's gaming ecosystem.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- The **Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025**, regulates Real Money Games (RMGs) to mitigate **financial**, **mental**, and **cybersecurity** risks while promoting e-sports and social gaming.

Safeguarding Players from Real-Money Gaming Risks

- **RMG Ban:** Prohibits Real Money Games (Poker & Rummy) to curb addiction & **₹20,000 cr** annual losses.
- **Player Safeguards:** Age limits, spending caps, and counselling reduce youth stress.
- **Legal Penalties:** Offenders face up to **3 years in jail** or **a fine of ₹ 1 crore**, and CERT-IN can block apps.
- **Player Protection:** Individuals playing RMGs are not penalised, safeguarding casual users.

Fostering E-sports and Innovation

- **E-sports Recognition:** Officially recognised under the **National Sports Governance Act, 2025**, and prize money & competitions permitted.
- **Social Gaming:** Promotes recreational and educational games to boost skills and creativity.
- **Talent Development:** Gaming hubs/incubators foster startups & employment, following best practices.
- **Regulatory Clarity:** Verified operator allow list ensures compliance, safety, and investor confidence.

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Conclusion

- The Act balances **player safety with industry growth**, mitigating RMG risks while enabling **innovation**, **employment**, and **skill development** in India's gaming ecosystem.

------- End of Chapter --------

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Welfare Architecture & Inclusive Development

{Governance – Initiatives} 50 Years of ICDS Programme **

❖ **Context (TH):** The **Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS)** programme, a flagship initiative of the Government of India, marked its **50th anniversary in 2025**.

About ICDS

- Launched in **1975**, it is the **world's most extensive** community-based **early childhood development programme**. It has now been restructured into **Mission Saksham Anganwadi** and **Poshan 2.0**.
- It functions as a **Centrally Sponsored Scheme** under the **Ministry of Women and Child Development**.
- **Objective:** to enhance the nutritional and health status of **children aged 0-6**, support their overall development, and decrease mortality and malnutrition.
- **Integrated Services:** The ICDS scheme provides **six core services**—supplementary nutrition, preschool non-formal education, nutrition and health education, and immunisation.
- **Implementation:** It is carried out through a nationwide network of **Anganwadi Centres (AWC)**.

Key Achievements

- **Coverage:** ICDS has **over 9 crore beneficiaries** nationwide with a network of nearly **1.4 million AWCs**.
- **Nutrition Support:** Approximately **95%** of children registered under ICDS avail supplementary nutrition.
- **Positive Outcomes:** Studies show improvements in early literacy and numeracy among children.

Key Challenges

➢ **Funding Strain:** **60:40 Centre–State** funding increases State burden and disparities.
➢ **Infrastructure Gaps:** Many AWCs lack toilets, water, and permanent buildings.
➢ **Worker Shortage:** Anganwadi workers remain underpaid, overburdened, and multi-tasked.
➢ **Technology Issues:** Poshan Tracker & **facial recognition systems (FRS)** errors risk beneficiary exclusion.
➢ **Nutrition Concerns:** High **stunting (35.5%) and wasting (18.7%)** persist nationally.

Way Forward

✓ **Infrastructure Funding:** Improve AWC's facilities and ensure flexible, adequate funding support.
✓ **Workforce Capacity:** Better pay, training, and reduced non-ICDS workload burden.
✓ **Tech Nutrition:** Fix **Poshan Tracker issues**, ensuring accurate beneficiary inclusion.

Karnataka's ICDS Innovations as a Model

- **System Expansion:** Karnataka expanded ICDS from a **pilot block to 204 blocks**, demonstrating planned administrative scaling.
- **Infrastructure Upgrade:** Over 47,720 AWCs now function from government-owned buildings equipped with kitchens, toilets, drinking water, and electricity.
- **Preschool Reform:** Converting 250 centres into **government Montessori units** connects ICDS preschool education with structured, bilingual, activity-based foundational learning.
- **Curriculum Standardisation:** The **Chilipili curriculum** offers weekly themes and hands-on activities to boost cognitive readiness and ensure consistent learning.
- **Childcare Coverage:** **Koosinamane crèches** address the **0–3 childcare gap** by providing Anganwadi-linked support for working women in rural and semi-urban areas.

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- **Nutrition Intervention:** The **Chiguru programme** integrates growth monitoring with community-based nutrition counselling, strengthening management in high-burden districts.
- **Worker Welfare:** Enhanced **state honorariums** and welfare measures improve Anganwadi workers' motivation, retention, and service delivery.

{Governance – Initiatives} Civic Engagement in Health Governance

❖ **Context (TH): India's doorstep healthcare schemes** highlight the urgent need to **integrate active community participation** in health governance structures.

Mechanisms for Civic Participation

- **Civic engagement:** Involves **structured citizen participation** in health decision-making processes.
- **Community Oversight:** **VHSNCs** plan and monitor equitable access to local healthcare.
- **Public Grievances:** **Jan Sunwai forums** in states address complaints through open hearings.
- **Hospital Governance:** **Rogi Kalyan Samitis**, as registered societies, manage facility-level resources.
- **Urban Engagement:** **Mahila Arogya Samitis** in urban slums mobilise women for health action.
- **Digital Feedback:** e-Sanjeevani OPD and referral modes gather patient inputs for service improvement.
- **Coordination:** Forums link health with sanitation & nutrition, strengthening governance integration.
- **Social Audits:** Community audits assess service quality and ensure transparent fund utilisation.

⇨ ***VHSNCs:*** *Village Health Sanitation and Nutrition Committees plan and monitor community wellbeing.*
⇨ ***Jan Sunwai:*** *Public forums resolving citizen grievances through open hearings.*
⇨ ***Rogi Kalyan Samiti:*** *Manages hospital resources for efficient public health delivery.*
⇨ ***Mahila Arogya Samiti:*** *Mobilises women for awareness and neighbourhood health action.*
⇨ ***e-Sanjeevani:*** *Delivers telemedicine consultations via government healthcare platforms.*

Governance Value of Civic Engagement

- Inclusive governance converts health systems from **service providers to social contracts**.
- **Legitimacy:** Citizen engagement strengthens trust, legitimising health governance frameworks.
- **Accountability:** Community oversight curbs corruption, ensuring equitable resource distribution.
- **Service Access:** Local participation boosts healthcare utilisation, enhancing public health outcomes.
- **Mutual Trust:** Engagement fosters collaboration, strengthening provider-community partnerships.
- **Equity Enhancement:** Inclusive forums reduce disparities, prioritising marginalised groups' needs.
- **Policy Alignment:** Community inputs shape policies, reflecting local health priorities.
- **Knowledge Exchange:** Blending community insights with expertise shapes effective health interventions.

Barriers to Meaningful Engagement

- Inactive platforms erode both community agency and institutional credibility.

➢ **Mindset Barrier:** Viewing communities as recipients hinders active health governance roles.
➢ **Metric-Driven Focus:** **Target-based metrics** ignore engagement quality, reducing policy effectiveness.
➢ **Leadership Disconnect:** Doctor-led systems often sideline community inputs, weakening alignment.
➢ **Platform Inefficiency:** Ambiguous committee mandates diminish accountability in health governance.
➢ **Fund Misallocation:** Bureaucratic delays underutilise funds, limiting community health initiatives.
➢ **Awareness Shortfall:** Limited rights knowledge restricts citizens' health governance engagement.

Way Forward

✓ Empowered citizens and responsive systems are twin pillars of health governance.
✓ **Mindset Shift:** Recognising **communities as partners** strengthens participatory health governance.

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- ✓ **Civic Empowerment:** Health rights education equips citizens for informed decision-making.
- ✓ **Inclusive Access:** Actively involving marginalised groups ensures equitable health outcomes.
- ✓ **Provider Training:** Sensitising health staff integrates community perspectives into governance.
- ✓ **Committee Empowerment:** Clear roles and resources make committees function effectively.
- ✓ **Transparency Measures:** Social audits enhance accountability and curb resource misuse.
- ✓ **Legal Frameworks:** Statutory backing secures community roles, sustaining governance participation.

Participatory Health Governance Programmes

- **Tamil Nadu:** **Makkalai Thedi Maruthuvam** delivers doorstep NCD care via community participation.
- **Karnataka:** **Gruha Arogya** expands home-based care, mobilising accredited local health workers.
- **Kerala:** **Aardram Mission** upgrades primary care with participatory family health centres.
- **Rajasthan:** **Chiranjeevi Yojana** applies citizen oversight to improve health insurance governance.
- **Odisha:** **Gaon Kalyan Samitis**, a VHSNC variant, monitor village health and nutrition.

{Governance – Reforms} Innovation Corridors for Viksit Bharat **

❖ **Context (BL): Innovation corridors** can realise **India's Viksit Bharat 2047 vision**, reiterated by the Prime Minister in his Independence Day speech.

- Innovation corridors are integrated clusters of research, design, manufacturing, and talent that accelerate breakthrough technologies in strategic sectors.

Need for Innovation Corridors

- **Pandemic Lesson:** COVID-19 vaccines show that interdisciplinary collaboration speeds up innovation.
- **Dependency Risk:** Reliance on imported technologies makes India vulnerable to tariffs and disruptions.
- **Historical Pattern:** Scientific breakthroughs like the **Webb Telescope** arise at intersections.
- **Demographic Dividend:** India's large youth population needs corridors to harness its potential fully.

Advantages of Innovation Corridors

- **Value Chains**: Domestic semiconductor packaging hubs anchor ecosystems and reduce import reliance.
- **High-Skill Jobs:** Corridors boost employment in semiconductors, defence, energy, and space sectors.
- **Economic Multipliers:** EV battery breakthroughs stimulate mining, power grid, and recycling industries.

Challenges in India's Adoption

- ➢ **Institutional Silos:** Weak industry–academia patent transfers restrict effective innovation collaboration.
- ➢ **Funding Gaps:** Shallow venture ecosystem limits investment in semiconductor and biotech research.
- ➢ **Infrastructure Deficit:** The absence of shared fabrication labs limits start-up prototyping capacity.
- ➢ **Regulatory Constraints:** Limited **sandbox frameworks** restrict innovations in fintech and biotech.
- ➢ **Regional Imbalance:** Metro-centric clusters marginalise innovation growth in non-metropolitan regions.

Way Forward

- ✓ **University–Industry Linkage:** ANRF partnerships can replicate **Stanford–Silicon Valley** linkages.
- ✓ **Infrastructure:** Domestic fabrication labs reduce reliance on overseas semiconductor prototyping.
- ✓ **Corporate Convergence:** Cascadia Corridor model shows cross-industry innovation benefits for India.
- ✓ **Cluster Integration:** China's G60 hubs illustrate scaling manufacturing through multi-city integration.
- ✓ **Regional Decentralisation:** **Kochi–Palakkad** industrial corridor as a model for decentralised innovation.

Read More > *Nation Building through Science and Innovation*

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{Welfare Architecture & Inclusive Development – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. Evaluate the effectiveness of Mission Mode programs in India in addressing governance challenges. Discuss their limitations and suggest how their successes can inform broader state reforms. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Briefly explain what Mission Mode Programs are and highlight their relevance in addressing governance challenges in India.
- **Body:** Elaborate on the effectiveness, limitations, and lessons to be learned from the programs.
- **Conclusion:** Conclude the answer by highlighting the need for broader systematic reforms.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Mission mode programs are focused, time-bound initiatives aimed at solving specific governance **challenges**. Programs like the **Mahakumbh Mela**, **Operation Flood**, and the **Delhi Metro** highlight India's ability to achieve significant outcomes by mobilising resources, expertise, and political will.

Effectiveness of Mission Mode Programs

- **Mission mode programs excel in prioritising specific objectives:**

1. **Mahakumbh Mela** showcases India's ability to manage a massive logistical challenge, handling over **400 million** pilgrims in **2025**.
2. **Operation Flood** transformed India into the **world's largest milk producer**, boosting rural livelihoods and enhancing nutritional security.
3. **Delhi Metro** exemplifies successful public-private partnerships, overcoming urban infrastructure challenges to provide world-class transit.

Limitations of the Mission Mode Programs

- **Narrow Focus:** Programs target specific issues, often leaving larger governance challenges like regulatory reform unaddressed.
- **Dependence on Leadership:** Success relies heavily on individual leadership, which can undermine sustainability if leadership changes.
- **Regulatory Bypass:** By sidestepping existing regulations, these programs provide short-term solutions without addressing systemic weaknesses.
- **Resource Diversion:** Focusing resources on specific programs can deplete capacity in other critical governance areas.

Lessons for Broader Reforms

- ✓ **Streamline Regulations and Enhance Coordination:** Simplify regulations and improve inter-departmental coordination to ensure efficiency.
- ✓ **Strengthen Institutions and Decentralise Decisions:** Build institutional capacity and grant greater autonomy to local governments for more responsive governance.
- ✓ **Promote Public-Private Collaboration:** Encourage collaboration between the public and private sectors to improve efficiency and scalability.
- ✓ **Leverage Data and Performance Metrics:** Use data-driven decision-making and implement performance-based evaluations for better governance.

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Conclusion

- While mission mode programs have addressed immediate governance challenges effectively, their successes highlight the need for broader systemic reforms to ensure sustainable & inclusive development.

Q. Discuss the policy measures & innovative strategies that can strengthen the effectiveness of prison reforms for crime prevention and social reintegration in India. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about the prison reforms in India by mentioning the current facts.
- **Body:** Discuss the need for prison reforms and suggest policy measures and innovative strategies to strengthen prisons.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on integration of global models with comprehensive prison reforms to lower recidivism and enhance public safety.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- Prison reforms in India are crucial for crime prevention and social reintegration, with **77% of inmates being undertrials** and **occupancy exceeding 130%**, exposing overcrowding and delayed rehabilitation.

Need for Prison Reforms

- **Overcrowding:** Many prisons operate **over 130%** capacity, straining resources and compromising safety.
- **Undertrial Backlog:** **77% of inmates** are undertrials, causing prolonged detention and delayed justice.
- **International Commitments:** **Mandela Rules** compliance elevates India's human rights reputation.
- **Infrastructure Deficit:** Dilapidated facilities undermine hygiene, security, and rehabilitation efforts.
- **Rehabilitation Gap:** Lack of skills training and reintegration programs increases recidivism.

Policy Measures and Innovative Strategies

- ✓ **Infrastructure Upgrade:** Reduce overcrowding, improve healthcare, sanitation, and women's facilities.
- ✓ **Digital Oversight:** **E-Prisons** and analytics monitor welfare, parole, and rehabilitation.
- ✓ **Legal Safeguards:** Expand legal aid, ensure timely release and parole systems.
- ✓ **Skill Development:** Vocational training & counselling reduce recidivism and enhance reintegration.

Conclusion

- Integrating global models like **Scandinavian open prisons** modernises India's prison system, ensuring humane rehabilitation. This approach lowers recidivism, enhances public safety, and aligns with international standards.

------- End of Chapter --------

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